

NOT A POTATO

THE SCOURING



ANDRIES J. GREYLING

Chapter 1 — Arrival on the Hill

The thing about a hill that isn't much of a hill is that it sneaks up on you sideways.

Frik knew the geometry from the maps — they all did, the autistic one had narrated the contour lines from the back seat for forty minutes in a voice like a metronome, the Ridgeway crossing here, the hillfort ramparts there, the dry valley called the Manger folded in below — but maps lie about the body of a place. They tell you elevation and forget weather. They give you a figure carved at 110 metres long and forget that you can't see it. That was the first joke the hill played, and Frik felt it land in his chest before he understood it: they had driven all this way to look at the most famous chalk drawing in Britain, and from the car park you could not see the horse at all.

He got out into wind. The wind here was a presence, a hand laid flat against the side of the head, and being Deaf he took it as pressure rather than sound, felt it shove the car door and tug his jacket and comb the grass into long silver runs down the slope. The grass was the green of something that had never once been thirsty. Sheep stood in it like punctuation. And above them, where the slope steepened toward the crown of the down, the turf was scarred open in lines of raw white that, this close and this high, refused to add up to anything.

A leg. A long swimming neck, maybe. A staring round eye, divorced from any head.

Frik turned in a slow circle on the gravel and felt the others arranging themselves around him — he tracked people the way other people

tracked sound, by where they put their weight. The LENS had already drifted ten feet off, camera not yet up, only watching, the way he always watched first, reading a place for its exits before he'd read it for its picture. The ADHD one — Devan — was bouncing toward a knot of people by a marquee half-erected at the field edge, drawn to the human warmth of them like a moth to a kettle. And the pattern-spotter, Wren, stood with her back to the horse and her face to the valley, because Wren had read the same thing Friik had: you don't look at the horse from the horse.

Friik tapped the LENS on the shoulder and signed, hands cutting the wind: *Where's the picture?* He pointed up the slope at the white scars. *Can't see it from here.*

The LENS made the small flat gesture they'd worked out between them over two books now — *wait* — and tipped his head down the hill, toward the Manger, toward the long green emptiness of the valley floor.

Right. You had to go away from it to see it. You had to stand in the valley, or be a bird, or be God. The people who cut this thing into the chalk somewhere between thirteen-eighty and five-fifty before Christ — and the dating was good, the dating was OSL, optically stimulated luminescence run on the quartz grains pulled up from under the chalk packing by the Oxford team, the kind of number that had quietly murdered the old story about King Alfred carving it after a battle — those people had made a creature that no one standing on its own back could ever read. They had made it for the valley. Or for the sky. Friik felt the size of that decision the way you feel a cold coming on, low and slow and certain: somebody, three thousand years gone, had aimed a picture at a place no living eye could comfortably stand.

He looked back up at the white lines and tried, the way you try to see the duck-rabbit, to make them resolve. They wouldn't. Up close it was just trenches in a hill, filled with crushed chalk, blinding where the cloud-light caught them.

Just trenches in a hill.

Friik crouched and put his hand flat on the nearest scour-line where it ran near the path, and the chalk was not soft. That surprised him. He'd expected something like cliff-face, friable, a thing you could erase with a boot-heel. Instead it was packed — rammed — a paste

of broken white driven down into a cut he could see was deep, deeper than the surface suggested, the edges of the trench standing crisp where turf met chalk. A metre down, the records said. They'd dug it a metre down, three thousand years ago, and packed it, because chalk on a slope wants to creep, wants to slump and smear and soften, and a metre-deep trench packed hard holds an edge against the long patient pull of the hillside.

Engineering. Somebody's grandmother's grandmother's people, a hundred generations back, had solved the problem of soil creep on a chalk down, and the solution was still working under his palm.

He stood, brushed white dust off his hand, and the dust did not all come off. It clung in the lines of his skin like the negative of a fingerprint.

That's the catch, then, he thought, and the thought had the shape Frik's thoughts always took — not words, exactly, but a felt diagram, a thing he'd have to translate later for the others. The catch was right here in the dust on his hand. The easy story, the story you'd tell a child, was: it's a drawing, it's three thousand years old, isn't that marvellous. And it was marvellous, and it was a drawing, and it was three thousand years old. But a drawing on paper is a thing that happened once. This was a thing that had to keep happening. Leave this slope alone — leave the wind and the rain and the patient green grass to themselves — and in twenty years there is no horse. The figure is not old the way a fossil is old. It is old the way a fire is old when somebody has kept feeding it for three thousand years.

He found he was grinning, and didn't entirely know why.

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Down by the half-built marquee, Devan had already made three friends and lost his hat to the wind. Frik came up in time to read the conversation off the faces, which was how he took most conversations: a stout man in a body-warmer doing the patient explaining-to-tourists face; a younger woman with a clipboard doing the polite-but-busy face; Devan doing his open, kinetic, *tell-me-everything* face that won people over right up until it didn't.

The marquee, the trestle tables stacked flat, the hand-painted sign leaning against a fence post — SCOURING — Sat 9am — VOLUN-

TEERS & FAMILIES WELCOME — all of it had the feel of a village fete assembling itself out of habit. There were cheese-rolling rumours (Devan signed them across to Frik, gleeful, *they roll cheese down the hill, the steep bit*), there was a sound system being argued over, there was a woman setting out a tea urn the size of a water heater. People moved in the easy unbothered way of people who have done this before and will do it again, who learned it from someone who learned it from someone.

Frik watched a grey-haired man hand a younger one a tool off the back of a trailer — not a modern tool, a worn thing, a sort of heavy mallet-and-tamper — and watched the younger man take it without a word, without a glance, the transfer so practised that neither of them looked at the object passing between their hands. They were looking at each other's faces. Something went across in that look that Frik felt go through him too, a small electric recognition: *that* was the thing. Not the mallet. The handing.

He filed it. The LENS had caught it too — the camera was up now, the soft motorless lift of it, and Frik knew without checking that the frame would hold both faces and the tool a blur between them, and that nobody in this field would notice the photograph being taken, which was the whole point of the LENS.

Then Devan turned, hat recaptured, face fallen a notch, and signed: *That lot. The clipboard people. They're not the festival.*

He angled his chin across the field.

There was a second marquee. Frik had taken it for part of the same gathering, but now he read it properly, and it was a different species of tent. White, taut, branded — a green logo, a line of clean type — and under it a folding display rack with renderings on it, and a slim man in a good coat gesturing at the renderings to two people from the village who stood with their arms folded and their feet planted, listening hard. The renderings, even at this distance, even half-furled in the wind, were the giveaway: a horse, the horse, but rendered crisp, complete, every line resolved and unbroken, glowing white against a green so saturated it looked stencilled. A horse that made sense from every angle. A horse you could put on a mug.

Heritage Consultancy, Devan signed, finger-spelling the long second word with a sour twist. *That bloke gave me a card.* He produced it.

Frik read it. ROWAN LEIGH, it said, with letters after the name, and below: *Restoring Britain's Story*.

Frik looked from the card to the renderings to the actual horse on the actual hill, the one made of disconnected white scars that refused to be a horse at all, and back to the rendering, and felt the gap between them open like a trapdoor.

Restore it to what, he signed slowly. *It's not broken*.

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Wren found the answer to the question nobody had asked yet, which was Wren's particular gift — she came back from her circuit of the valley rim with her phone out and her thumb already moving, and she stood square in front of Frik so he could see her hands and her mouth together, the way she always did, no fuss, just access.

WWII, she spelled. *They turfed it over. Forty-something to forty-five. Covered the whole thing with hedge cuttings and earth so the Luftwaffe couldn't use it as a landmark on the bombing runs to the factories.* She let that sit. *Then they uncovered it after. Dug it back out. Re-cut it.* Her face did the thing it did when a pattern closed, a small fierce satisfaction. *So even the gap got minded. Even when they hid it, they hid it on purpose, to bring it back.*

Frik turned this over. Three thousand years, give or take, and somewhere in the middle a generation had deliberately erased the horse to save the village underneath it from being bombed flat — had treated the figure as a thing precious enough to bury, and a thing certain enough to come back to that they kept the burial reversible. You don't bury a corpse the way you put away the good china.

The official story was still ironclad, and Frik liked it for being ironclad — the date, the trenches, the engineering, no aliens, no ley lines, no need for any of that. The marvel didn't require a mystery to prop it up. The marvel was the maintenance. The marvel was that a thing which vanishes in twenty years untended had not, in three thousand, vanished. Empires had vanished faster. Plague had come and gone and come again. The Romans had walked the Ridgeway right past it and left, and the horse had outlasted Rome the way it had outlasted everyone, not by being remembered for what it was — because nobody knew what it was, hadn't for centuries, the medieval folk thought

it was a dragon and gave it a hill to gallop to at night — but by being kept. By somebody every seven years or so deciding the lines must not fade.

And nobody, not Wren's phone, not the Oxford team, not the slim man under the white tent with his glowing rendering, could say *why*.

Frik liked that too. He liked it the way you like a held breath.

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The historical society came at them as a delegation, which is how you know you've stopped being a curiosity and become a problem.

Three of them, the stout body-warmer man among them, and a woman in front who did all the talking and most of the looking. She had the local committee face down cold — courteous, immovable, a face that had said no to better-dressed people than these. Devan tried first, all warmth and quick hands, the camera explained, the project explained, *we just want to document, to listen, not to interfere* — and Frik watched the woman's politeness set like cooling tallow.

He couldn't hear the words. He didn't need them. He read the lift of her chin and the small backward set of her shoulders and the way her eyes went, just once, to the LENS's camera and stayed cold, and the way she said something short that made Devan's whole body go still.

She says, Devan signed, careful now, the kinetic gone out of him, the festival's not for filming. She says everyone wants a piece of the horse this year. He glanced toward the white tent. She thinks we're with them. Or like them. She says the village will scour the horse the way it's always scoured the horse, and they don't need outsiders to tell them what it means. A beat. She says: you can watch from the valley. Like everyone else.

Like everyone else. From the valley. Where the horse is legible and you are not invited up onto its back.

The delegation turned and went, and that was that, and the wind took the woman's words apart before they reached anyone who could hear them.

But Frik was watching past her, the way he always watched past the thing in front of him, and so he was the one who saw the other woman.

She stood apart from all of it — apart from the society, apart from the white tent, apart from the tea urn and the cheese-rumour and the stacked trestles. Older, weathered the way the hill was weathered, a coat that had been rained on many times. She had a tool in her hand — that same worn mallet-and-tamper, or its twin — and she was not using it, only holding it, the way you hold something you've held so often it's stopped being a separate object from your hand.

She wasn't looking at the renderings. She wasn't looking at the delegation, or the slim man, or the camera. She was looking up the slope, at the disconnected white scars that weren't a horse, with the absolute attention of someone reading a sentence the rest of them couldn't see was even written.

Then, for one second, she looked down off the slope and across the field, and her eyes went over the crew — over Devan's stillness, over the LENS, over Frik himself — and stopped on the white dust still clinging in the lines of Frik's open palm.

She saw it. He saw her see it.

Her face did something almost too small to read. Not a welcome. Not anything so warm. Just a flicker of — *noted*. A door not opened. A door noticed to exist.

Then she turned and went up the hill, toward the scars, where she was allowed and they were not, and the wind closed over the place where she'd stood.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story

The wind on the Uffington Castle ramparts does not stop. It is not a gust that comes and goes; it is a standing fact, a pressure that has been leaning on this hill since before there was a hill-figure to lean past, and Wren had stopped fighting it within the first ninety seconds of the climb. She had turned her collar up, planted her feet at the shoulder-width that felt right, and let the wind become the room.

From up here the Vale of the White Horse spread out the way a map spreads out — which was the wrong way to say it, because a map was the flat thing and this was the real thing, but Wren's brain had reached for the map first and she let it. The patchwork of fields. The dark hem of trees along a lane. Dragon Hill squatting below, its flat top too flat, too deliberate. The Manger, the dry valley folded into the slope like the land had been pinched between a giant's finger and thumb. And the figure itself, the Horse, running on the upper slope below them — except you could not see it. Not from here. Not properly.

"You can't read it from above," she said. Not to anyone. To the air, to confirm it out loud the way she confirmed things.

"That's the whole point of it, though, innit." This was Sol, the ADHD one, who had got to the top of the ramparts before any of them and was now doing a slow spin with his arms out like he was charging himself off the view. "It's a poster for the sky. Or the valley. Anywhere but where you'd actually stand to make it."

Frik was a few metres off, near the lip of the bank, watching two of the festival people set up trestle tables down in the lee of the hillfort.

His hands moved — *they're arguing about where the tea urn goes* — and Wren glanced over in time to catch the tail of it, the wry tilt of his mouth. He read the down-below scene like the rest of them read print. The LENS stood apart, as the LENS did, the camera up but not clicking, just framing, just watching the watching.

Wren had the facts. The facts were hers to carry, and she had carried them up the hill in good order, and she set them down now the way she liked to, in sequence, because sequence was how a thing became true.

“Right,” she said. “Official story. Straight version. So nobody gets it wrong later.” Sol made a small bow. “It’s a chalk hill-figure. About a hundred and ten metres, nose to tail. Cut into the slope below us, and the way they did it — the way they *still* do it — is they dug trenches. Not scraped the turf off. *Trenches*. About a metre deep, packed full of crushed white chalk.”

“A metre,” said Sol. “That’s a grave. That’s, like, a grave for a horse.”

“It’s engineering.” She liked the word and she let it sit. “If you just scrape the topsoil, the soil creeps. Hillsides move, slowly, all the time — frost heave, rain, sheep. A shallow figure smears and softens and you lose it in a season or two. But cut a metre down, pack it with chalk, and you’ve made a *kerb*. A boundary the slope can’t sneak across. That’s why the lines are still sharp. That’s why a three-thousand-year-old picture doesn’t look like a blur.”

“Three thousand,” Sol said, testing it. “We’re sure on three thousand?”

This was the part she had been looking forward to, the way some people look forward to a chorus.

“OSL.” She said the letters cleanly. “Optically stimulated luminescence. Palmer and Miles, Oxford Archaeological Unit, dug here properly in the nineties. The idea is: when a grain of quartz is buried, cut off from sunlight, it starts soaking up natural background radiation and storing it, like a battery filling. The last time it saw daylight, that battery was at zero. So you dig in the dark, you take the buried grains without exposing them, you measure how full the battery is in a lab, and you back-calculate the last time those grains were on the surface.”

“That’s mad,” said Sol, delighted. “You’re reading the *dark* off a rock.”

“You’re reading how long the dark’s been,” Wren said. “And it came back Late Bronze Age into the earliest Iron Age. Roughly thirteen-eighty to five-fifty BC.” She paused. “Which broke everything everyone thought they knew. People used to credit it to King Alfred — a monument for the Battle of Ashdown, ninth century. Or the Saxons. Centuries off. The Horse was already old, *ancient*, by the time those people came along and went, *we’ll have that, that’s ours*.”

The fish — there is always a fish, on this hill, in this wind, the heckling part of your own head that won’t sit still through a lecture — pointed out that a battery you can’t see and didn’t watch fill is a wonderful thing to take entirely on faith. Wren told the fish that’s why you publish your method, and the fish said *sure, sure*, and went quiet, satisfied for now.

Sol had wandered to the inner edge of the bank, looking down the slope toward where the Horse must be, the great spinal curve of it she’d seen from the valley road that morning — that strange, stretched, beautiful animal that didn’t look like a horse so much as the *idea* a horse leaves behind when it has finished running. Disjointed. Beaked. More dragon than mare, if you wanted it to be, and people had wanted it to be.

“So it’s a Bronze Age horse,” Sol said. “Carved by Bronze Age people, dated by sci-fi rock batteries, kept sharp by metre-deep trenches. Easy. We can go home.” He grinned at her. “What’s the catch, Wren. There’s always a catch with you.”

She did not answer straight away, because the catch was the kind of thing you had to feel before you said it, and she was feeling it now, standing on a four-thousand-year-old rampart with the wind not stopping.

“The catch is keeping it,” she said.

She crouched and put her flat hand on the turf of the bank. Springy, close-cropped, sheep-mown. Underneath, chalk. The whole down was chalk under a thin green skin, and the green skin *wanted* the chalk. That was the thing nobody put in the headline.

“Twenty years,” she said. “If you walked away from the Horse and never came back. Twenty years, give or take, and it’s gone. Grassed

over. The trenches fill, the chalk greens up, the grass marches in from the edges and closes the wound, because to the hill it *is* a wound, and the hill heals. You wouldn't get to a century. You wouldn't get close. There are old figures all over this country that *did* get left, and you know how we know they were there? Drawings. Records. Pale ghosts on a hillside that some farmer remembers his granddad mentioning. They go. They all go. Everything green eats them."

"But this one didn't," Sol said. Quieter now. He'd caught it.

"This one didn't." Wren stood, brushing chalk-grit off her palm, the faint white smear of it on her skin that she'd notice for an hour. "Which means somebody came back. Somebody came back, and came back, and came back. Every seven, eight, ten years, somebody walked up this hill with a hammer and a bucket and got down on the slope and *cut it open again*. Re-chalked it. Beat the white back into the lines. And then their kids did. And their kids. For three thousand years. Through the Romans. Through every plague that came through this valley. Through whatever the word *Saxon* meant when it was a thing happening to your village and not a museum label. Through a world war, when they—" she stopped, because this one was almost too good — "when they *turfed it over on purpose*. In the war. Covered it up so the German bombers couldn't use it as a landmark, a great white arrow pointing at the Midlands. And then the war ended and they came back up and uncovered it and scoured it clean again."

The fish had nothing. The wind had everything.

Down the slope, Frik had turned and was watching her hands, reading the shape of what she was saying off her face and her gestures even at this distance, and he signed something to the LENS that made the LENS lower the camera half an inch, which was the LENS's version of a laugh.

"So the maintenance is the marvel," Sol said. "Not the carving."

"The carving's a Tuesday," Wren said. "Hard, but a Tuesday. A few hundred people, a season, you've got a horse. The *keeping* —" She spread her hands the way Frik did when a thing was too big for the small words. "Three thousand years of agreeing. Every generation, without anyone alive who could tell you *why*, somebody decided the Horse must not fade. That's not a monument. A monument you build

and walk off from. This is —” and she ran out, the way she always did at the edge of the true thing, and just stood there with the wind in her teeth.

There was a man near the trestle tables, older, in a flat cap and a body-warmer the colour of dried mud, and he had been half-listening the way locals half-listen to incomers laying out the local facts. Wren came down off the bank with the others and he caught her eye and gave her a nod that meant *go on then*.

“You’ve got it about right,” he said. “OSL. Bronze Age. Trenches deep as a man’s leg.” He had clearly said all this before, many times, to many clipboards. “Three thousand years. We keep it up. Every seven year, roughly. That’s your textbook.”

“That’s the textbook,” Wren agreed.

“Aye.” He looked down the slope, to where the Horse was, where neither of them could see it. There was a small pleasure working at the corner of his mouth that she could not name and did not trust herself to. “It’s a horse, see. King Alfred’s horse, my nan’d have told you. Or a dragon — over Dragon Hill there, where the dragon’s blood’s so thick no grass’ll grow.” He said it flatly, a man reciting. “It’s a horse, official. Bronze Age horse.”

“You don’t sound sure,” Sol said, light, friendly, the trust-winner doing his work.

“Oh, I’m sure what the book says.” The man bent and picked up a coil of bunting that had blown loose, looping it over his arm, unhurried. “I’m sure of the book.” He straightened. “Whether the book’s sure what it *is* — that’s a different bucket. Book’ll tell you when. Book’ll tell you how deep. Book won’t tell you why old Mrs. Compton up the lane wouldn’t let you start the scouring with the *tail*. Always the eye. You do the eye first or you don’t bother.” He shrugged, a man declining to argue with a dead woman. “Why’s that in your book?”

Wren had nothing in her book about the eye. She felt the absence of it like a missing tooth.

“It’s not,” she said.

“No.” He seemed pleased, and not unkindly. “Lots isn’t.” He nodded

down at her hand, where the chalk was still ghosted across her palm. “You’ll want gloves,” he said, “if you mean to do more than write about it,” and went back to his bunting.

Frik had been watching the whole exchange — the old man’s face, the small private pleasure of it, the way he’d handed them the textbook with one hand and held the eye-first thing back with the other. He signed to Wren, slow so she’d be sure: *He gave you the dates. He kept the doing.*

She turned that over. The dates were everyone’s. The doing was his.

It was Sol who saw the banners first, because Sol saw everything that moved.

They were coming up the track from the car park on a flatbed, three of them rolled like sails, and a small crew in clean fleeces was already setting the first poles into the verge near the gate, where the festival people would pass. Wren watched the first banner go up the pole and catch the wind and snap taut, and the wind, which did not stop for anyone, made the cloth crack like applause.

It was a beautiful thing, the banner. That had to be said. A photograph of the Horse from the air, the white impossibly white, the curves cleaned and corrected, the figure floating on green so saturated it looked lit from inside. Across the top, in a serif that whispered *trust me, I’ve read the journals*:

THE UFFINGTON WHITE HORSE — AUTHENTIC RESTORATION

And below, smaller, the line that made the old man stop coiling his bunting and stand very still:

Restoring the figure to its original Bronze Age form. Heritage Consultancy.

“Original form,” Wren read aloud. The words went in wrong. They went in the way a number goes in when it’s a number you can’t make balance.

“You can’t restore something to original,” Sol said, and his lightness was gone. “Original was three thousand years ago. There’s nobody

alive saw original. There's not even a *book* saw original — the book's a guess in a lab, you said it yourself, it's how long the dark's been."

The second banner went up. The third.

Down at the trestle tables, the old man set his coil of bunting down on the trestle, carefully, and looked at the photograph of the Horse on the cloth — the corrected curves, the perfect white, the eye that someone in a studio had cleaned up without knowing you do the eye first — and he did not say anything at all. He just looked, the way you look at a likeness of someone you know, when the likeness has got the face right and the person wrong.

The LENS lifted the camera. This time it clicked.

And Wren stood with the chalk drying on her hand and the wind not stopping, and thought: *somebody is going to come up this hill and fix the meaning to a thing nobody's known the meaning of for a thousand years. They're going to make it sure.*

She did not yet know what that would cost. But she knew, the way she knew sequences, that *sure* and *kept* were not the same thing — and that the old man, who'd handed her the textbook with one hand, had not handed her the other.

Chapter 3 — Potato on the Chalk

Tomas got to the gate first, because Tomas always got everywhere first, then forgot why he'd come.

The morning had that Berkshire trick of being four weathers at once — sun on the valley, a slate-coloured argument piling up over the Vale, and on the hill itself a wind that came at you sideways and smelled of sheep and bruised grass. Below, the Horse ran. You couldn't see it from up here, not properly. That was the whole joke of the thing. You stood right on top of one of the most famous shapes in Britain and saw nothing but white scribbles and turf, the way a beetle on a billboard sees only paint. You had to go down into the valley, or up into the air, to read it. Tomas found that personally insulting and deeply correct, both, and bounced a little on his heels thinking about it while the others caught up.

The consultancy had a marquee. Of course they had a marquee.

It was white, and pegged tight, and it had a banner along the side that said HERITAGE FUTURES in a serif so tasteful it practically apologised for existing. Underneath, in smaller letters: *Restoring the Past for Tomorrow*. Tomas read it twice and felt the *Restoring the Past for Tomorrow* do a small ugly thing in his chest he couldn't name yet, so he filed it under LATER and went to find the coffee, because there was always coffee at a thing with a marquee.

There was. It was good coffee. He hated that it was good coffee.

"They've done the maths," said Aïsha, beside him, not looking up from the ground. She'd been reading the slope since they parked —

the long unhurried scan she did, the one that made strangers think she was rude and made Tomas think she was the only person actually present. “Drone survey. They’ve gridded it. There’s a stake every two metres down the saddle of the neck.” She nodded at a line of orange flags fluttering in the wind, neat as a runway. “Photogrammetry. They’ve got a model of the figure to the centimetre.”

“To the centimetre,” said Tomas. “That’s good. That’s thorough. I respect that.” He meant it. He did respect it. He respected a centimetre with his whole heart and also wanted, suddenly and badly, to pull every one of those orange flags out and replant them in a rude shape.

He did not. Frik was watching him, and Frik knew his hands before he did.

Calm, Frik signed, flat-palmed, dry as ever. Then, because Frik missed nothing and forgave less, he tipped his chin at the marquee, at the woman stepping out of it, and signed: *Watch her hands, not her mouth.*

Dr. Rowan Leigh had good hands. That was the first thing — she used them like a conductor, open, including, drawing you in. She had a clipboard she never looked at and a high-vis vest she wore like a cardigan, and she crossed the wet grass toward the gaggle of locals and council faces with the easy spring of someone who genuinely could not wait to show you the thing she loved.

“So.” She didn’t shout. She let the wind do the work, let people lean in. “Three thousand years. Give or take. OSL puts the cut between thirteen-eighty and five-fifty BC — Bronze Age into the earliest Iron Age. Late Bronze, almost certainly. People stood here” — she pressed two fingers to the turf, light, reverent — “and they dug trenches a metre deep, and they packed them with crushed chalk, and they made a creature you can only see by leaving the ground. That’s not graffiti. That’s not a doodle. That’s *intent*. That’s engineering.”

Tomas glanced at Aïsha. Aïsha gave the smallest nod. It was all true. Every word of it, gold-standard, dig it up and cite it. That was the thing about Rowan Leigh that made Tomas’s teeth ache — she was *right*.

“And it should have died,” Leigh went on. “By every rule of erosion it

should have gone. Leave a chalk figure on a living hillside, untended, and you have maybe twenty years before the grass takes it. Twenty. Wessex is full of lost ones — figures we know existed, named in deeds, gone now, green now, nothing.” She let that sit. “This one didn’t go. Because people came back. Generation after generation, they came back and they scoured it — cut the turf, re-packed the chalk, kept the shape. And they did it” — and here she smiled, and it was a real smile, a good one — “almost certainly without ever knowing what it *meant*. By the Middle Ages they thought it was a dragon. They’d lost the why and kept the what. Isn’t that extraordinary?”

It was. It was completely extraordinary. Tomas wanted to applaud and also to lie down on the grass and weep, and he did neither, which his old support worker would have called *progress*.

“What we want to do,” said Leigh, gentler now, “is help. Not change it. *Honour* it. We have the model. We can true the lines — restore the proportions to the original cut, the one before three thousand years of slightly-wobbly hands moved a hoof here, a tail there. We can give people the Horse the Bronze Age made. The real one.” She spread the good hands. “And then we keep it that way. Properly. Surveyed. Documented. So it never drifts again.”

There was a silence. Into it, from the back of the gathering, somebody said, “Drifts.”

Edie Vane had a voice that carried without trying, the schoolteacher in it, the bottom note of someone who’d ended a thousand arguments by simply waiting. She had a thermos in one hand and a look on her face Tomas was learning to read — not anger. Worse than anger. Patience.

“It’s *meant* to drift,” Edie said.

Leigh turned, all warmth. “Mrs. Vane—”

“It moves a hoof here, a tail there, you said.” Edie unscrewed the thermos with the calm of a woman who had unscrewed it a thousand times in worse wind. “Yes. It does. Every scouring it moves a little, because it’s cut by hands, and hands aren’t drones. My grandmother cut that off hind leg. You can still see her in it, if you know where to look. You’d true that out of it, would you. Make it not-her. The real one.” She poured. The steam went sideways instantly. “Whose real

one.”

“The original—”

“You don’t have the original. You have a survey of where the chalk is *now*. The original’s three thousand years of hands ago.” Edie took a sip. Didn’t even look ruffled. “But you crack on. Show us your trial.”

And — give Leigh this — she did not flinch. She nodded, accepted it, even seemed to find Edie wonderful, which made Tomas like her against his will. “That’s exactly why we do a trial,” she said. “Small. Reversible. The lower flank, the belly line, a section nobody disputes. We try it. You look. We talk. Nobody owns anything today.”

Nobody owns anything today, Frik signed to Tomas, deadpan, and the little fish-flick of irony in it nearly undid him.

They went down to the belly.

This was the part Tomas had been waiting for, the part his whole jittery nervous system had been leaning toward all morning — *the doing*. Because here was the thing the official story got so beautifully, dead-straight right, and here was the thing it could never quite make you *feel*: this shape is not paint. It is a wound in a hillside kept open on purpose. The white isn’t drawn on. It’s chalk packed into a trench a metre deep, the soil held back by sheer engineering so the grass can’t creep in sideways and close the cut. You don’t colour the Horse. You *dig* the Horse. You re-open it. Every time.

The consultancy did not dig.

They had a system. There were kneeling-mats, the foam kind, edged in hazard yellow. There were buckets of pre-mixed chalk slurry, factory-bright, a white so even it looked like dentist. There were trowels with rubberised grips and laser levels on little tripods and a man with a tablet who walked the flagged line calling out numbers — “Two-twenty, good, two-twenty-two, bring it left” — and two more on their knees laying the slurry into the cut with the smooth back-and-forth of people tiling a bathroom.

It was fast. Tomas would say that for it forever: it was *fast*. In the time it took the scourers to argue about lunch, the consultancy laid four metres of belly line straight as a die.

And straight as a die was the problem.

He felt it before he could say it — that was always how it went with him, the body knew first and the words came panting along after, late, breathless, holding their side. Something in the slurry line was *wrong* in a way that had nothing to do with archaeology and everything to do with the back of his neck. He moved to the valley side to see it from below, because that was the only place the Horse was ever honest, and the others drifted after him.

From down-slope, the new section glared.

The old belly line — the scoured line, the ancestral line, the line that had been a thousand grandmothers — was white, yes, but it was *alive* white. It had texture. The chalk in it caught the changing light and broke it up, so the line breathed, went grey in cloud-shadow, blazed when the sun broke, and the edge of it was not an edge so much as a negotiation, a fray where chalk met turf and neither quite won. It looked like a thing growing out of the hill. It looked, Tomas thought, like the hill had decided to be a horse and was still deciding.

The new four metres looked like a sticker.

It was too white. Too even. The edge was a *line*, ruled and final, the slurry filling the cut flush and smooth so there was no fray, no breath, no argument — just a clean bright stroke laid *on* the hill, refusing it. Where the old line was a galloping animal, the new bit was a diagram of one. It had the proportions right. Leigh's centimetres were perfect. And it had killed the thing dead.

Aïsha said it first, quiet, the way she said true things. "It's the wrong direction."

"What?"

"The light." She had her head tilted, doing the scan. "The old chalk's broken up — crushed lump packed loose, full of facets, faces every way. Scatters the light, so the line changes with the sky. The slurry's a smooth fill. Flat. One angle. It only does *one* light." She pointed, not at the new bit, at the old. "Theirs is right for one moment. Noon, sun out, flat on. The rest of the time it's wrong, and there are a lot of rest of the times on a hill." A beat. "It's a horse for a photograph."

A horse for a photograph, Friik signed, and Tomas watched him sign

it to the LENS, who had been crouched ten feet back the whole time, low, patient, the camera not even up, *waiting*, and who now lifted it — once, a single frame, the new line and an old scourer's weathered hand resting on the live chalk beside it — and lowered it again. Tomas didn't see the shot. He didn't need to. He could feel that it was the one.

A schoolboy of maybe nine, dragged along by a scouring grandfather, summed up the entire commissioned report a year before it was written. He looked at the new four metres, and he looked at the rest of the Horse, and he said, with the brutal clarity of the very young, "It looks like a potato."

It did. It looked exactly like a potato. The whole gathered crowd, council and consultancy and scourers and crew, all of them looked at the four perfect, surveyed, centimetre-true metres of belly, and all of them, council included, saw a potato. You couldn't unsee it. The flat dead white, the ruled edge, the *correctness* of it sitting in the middle of three thousand years of living wobble like a road sign nailed to a tree.

Leigh saw it too. To her enormous credit, Tomas thought, she saw it and didn't pretend not to. Her good hands had gone still. She stood looking at her own perfect work with the face of a person who has spent a great deal of money proving something they cannot yet name to themselves.

"It'll weather," she said. Not to the crowd. Mostly to herself. "It'll dull down. Match in. A season—"

"It won't," said Edie. Not unkind, now. Just final. She'd come down to the valley side without anyone seeing, the way she did, the way the LENS did, the two of them the only people on the hill who knew you didn't watch a thing by standing near it. "It'll go grey-green and patchy because it's the wrong chalk laid the wrong way, and in three years you'll be back here digging it out, and in seven we'll be back here doing what we've always done." She screwed the thermos shut. "You truthed the shape and starved the life. You can do that. It's a free country and you've a permit." She looked at Leigh, and there was something in it almost like sympathy, which was worse than anything. "But you've not understood the one thing, love, and I'll only say it the once. We don't keep the Horse because it's right."

She left that there, on the wind, and started back up the slope to where the real chalk was waiting.

Tomas watched her go. He watched the schoolboy crouch by the old line and put one finger in the live, broken white, and the grandfather not stop him. He watched the LENS lower the camera and just *look*, for once, with his own two eyes. He watched Leigh stand over her potato in the changing light.

We don't keep it because it's right, Friik signed, slow, turning the shape of it over, the way he did with something he meant to carry a long way. *Then because of what?*

Nobody answered. Up the hill, somebody had started handing out the proper tools — the heavy ones, the old ones, the ones with no rubber grips. Tomas heard the first turf come up with a sound like the hill exhaling, and went to find out.

Chapter 4 — Reading the Ritual

The Fox and Hounds smelled of woodsmoke and wet wool, and Frik read it the way he read every room he walked into: from the door, fast, before anyone arranged their faces for him.

There was a lot to read.

The bar was a low-beamed space that had been a low-beamed space for four hundred years, and the men along it stood the way men stand in a place their grandfathers stood, with no need to look at the stools to find them. A fire that nobody tended kept itself going. Above the optics hung a horse — not the Horse, a brewery's brass plaque of a generic gallop — and nobody under that plaque had glanced at it in a decade.

Frik found a corner table where his back was to the wall and his eyes had the whole room. Old habit. You don't sit where you can't see hands.

Niamh dropped down beside him, kinetic as ever, already half a pint in and three conversations deep. She signed against the table edge where he could catch it without looking up: *Won the dominoes. Lost it on purpose at the end. They like you better if you lose the last one.*

He smiled. She was good at this — the ADHD made her a current, and currents find the cracks. People let her in because she moved too fast to be a threat and too warm to be a spy.

But the room wasn't in the dominoes.

The room was at the long table by the window, where six or seven of

them sat with their elbows in beer-rings and their tools on the wood.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it is true.

For roughly three thousand years, the people of this valley have walked up White Horse Hill and put the Horse back into the ground. They call it scouring. The figure is cut not as a painted line but as a trench — a metre deep in places — packed with crushed chalk, and chalk is not paint; chalk weathers, greys, slumps, feeds the grass that wants to eat it. Left to itself, the whole 110-metre animal would be gone inside twenty years. A man born under a sharp white horse could, untended, die under a green hillside with nothing on it.

So every seven years or so, they go up and they re-cut and they re-pack and they beat the chalk down with the flat of the tools, and the Horse runs again. It is documented as a festival back to the Middle Ages — Thomas Hughes wrote a whole book about the 1857 do, the cheese-rolling and the backsword and the ale — and it is inferred, by the simple miraculous fact of the animal still being *there*, all the way back to the Bronze Age people who first dug it. OSL dating of the buried quartz puts the cutting somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC. Older than Rome reaching Britain. Older than the word for the language Frik's hands were not speaking.

That's the story. Skeptics will tell you, correctly, that the folklore is patchwork — by the medieval period the locals had already forgotten it was a horse and decided it was a dragon, slain on the flat-topped hill below — and that the maintenance is “just tradition,” the way you'd say a thing is *just* a heartbeat.

Hold that *just*. We'll come back for it.

The tools on the table were the read.

Frik leaned forward, very still, the stillness that lets the eye do the moving. He'd learned long ago that hearing people perform listening — they nod, they make the small sounds, they aim their faces. It's noise on the signal. He had no signal to lose. So he watched the hands, and hands don't lie the way mouths do.

There were rakes, but not garden rakes. The heads were narrow, the

tines short and blunt and close-set, worn bright at the working edge and black with age up the shaft. There were wooden mallets the size of a forearm, the faces of them dished and silvered. There were trowels, and one long iron bar leaning in the corner like an old dog. None of it was new. None of it was from a shop.

And here was the thing Frik saw that nobody at the bar would have called a thing at all:

A young man — twenties, big-knuckled, nervous in the way of someone being looked at by people who matter — picked up one of the mallets to move it off the table so he could set down his glass. An older woman across from him didn't speak. She didn't even fully turn. Her hand came out flat, two inches above the wood, and *hovered* — not a grab, not a stop, just a held palm — and the young man put the mallet back down exactly where it had been, head pointing the way it had been pointing.

Then she nodded, once, and went back to her drink.

Frik felt the small electric thing in his chest he'd learned not to trust and not to ignore.

He signed to Niamh, low: *Did you see that?*

See what?

The mallet. He moved it. She put it back without touching it. It has to point a certain way.

Niamh looked. The table looked normal to her — six people, beer, old wood. *Maybe she's just particular.*

No. He didn't have the English for it. He rarely did; English came at him second-hand, through interpreters and captions and the strange flat country of lip-reading, and it never carried the part that mattered. The part that mattered was in the air above the table. It's a place for the tool. Not a tidy place. A correct place. He knew he'd broken something and she knew and neither of them said.

He watched the rest of the table catch up to it without being told. Within a minute every tool on the wood had its nose pointing the same way — downhill, he'd bet, toward the door, toward the valley where the Horse lived. He couldn't have proven it. You can't photo-

graph a rule that exists only in the half-inch a hovering palm declines to cross.

The LENS came in from the cold, camera not raised, which for the LENS was its own kind of statement. The series kept asking that camera to come down and sometimes, lately, it did. The LENS clocked the corner, clocked Frik's stillness, and read the read off him the way Frik read the room — and did not lift the lens. Sat down instead. Some moments you take by not taking them.

Coll, the fourth of them, was at the bar's end with a pint going warm and a map of the parish unfolded across two beer towels, tracing the contour lines with one finger, lips moving over the numbers. The autistic hyperfocus had him by the back of the neck and wouldn't let go: he was matching the modern footpaths against an 1870s tithe map he'd photographed in the records office, and something in the overlay was lighting him up.

He signed across to Frik, fingers fast and precise: *The scouring road. There's a hollow way up the back of the hill that doesn't go anywhere now. Dead-ends at the slope. But it lines up with the cart track on the old map.* A pause, the careful one he did before he said the thing that mattered. *It's a road for bringing chalk up. It's only a road for that. Nothing else is at the top.*

A road that goes nowhere, except to feed the Horse.

Frik filed it next to the mallet.

Then the door's draught moved, and Edie Vane came in.

He felt the room re-organise. Not a hush — the bar didn't stop — but a settling, the way iron filings settle when the magnet's set down nearby. The woman who'd hovered her palm looked up and something passed between her and Edie that was older than greeting. Edie was carrying a canvas roll under one arm, the kind that holds tools, and she set it against the leg of the long table without comment, and it belonged there.

She was tired in the eyes — schoolteacher's term-time tired — and underneath the tired she was watching everything, which Frik respected,

because it was what he did. She and the LENS recognised each other across the room like two snipers noting a third gun.

She came over to their corner. She knew sign — not fluent, but she'd learned some between Book One and now, which told him more about her than anything she could say. She kept her hands where he could see them and her face turned full to him, no half-profile, no shouting-at-the-deaf-man volume in the shape of her mouth.

"You've been watching the table," she signed-and-said, and her fingerspelling was slow and honest.

He didn't deny it. *The tools point downhill.*

Something in her face opened a centimetre. Not surprise. Recognition. The look of someone who has spent her life knowing a true thing nobody else bothers to see, and has just been told the true thing by a stranger.

"Most people," she said, slow, "see rakes."

Most people hear words. I can't, so I watch what's underneath. He shrugged. The young one moved the mallet. Maggie put it back without touching it. He learned the rule by breaking it. Nobody taught him in a sentence.

Eddie was quiet a moment. Across the bar somebody laughed too loud at the dominoes.

"That's the whole of it, that," she said. "That's how it goes down. Not in a book." She glanced at the table, at the canvas roll, at Maggie. "My grandad never once told me how to hold the rake. He just stopped me holding it wrong. Hundred times, maybe. Then one day he didn't have to." A small, dry mouth. "Now I do it to the young ones and I couldn't write it down if you paid me. It's not in words. Words are the part that fell off."

The meaning fell off.

"Aye." She didn't flinch from it; she'd lived with it her whole life. "Nobody up this valley knows what it was *for*. Not really. The dragon's a tale somebody made up when the first lot of why-it-was got lost. We've forgotten so long we've forgotten we forgot." She looked at him steadily. "But the *doing* didn't fall off. You can lose the why. You

can't lose the how, not if you keep doing it. The how lives in the hands."

Frik thought of the consultancy, two valleys over, with their drones and their digital model and their plan to "restore" the Horse to a *correct* shape — to fix it, to find the why and bolt it back on, to laminate the meaning. They wanted the words back. Edie was telling him the words were never the thing kept alive. The hands were.

Here's the potato, and it has teeth, so mind it.

It sounds like the easiest tradition in the world. *Just keep chalking it.* Walk up, dump chalk, go home. A child could do it.

So go and look at the other hill-figures. Half the white horses cut across these downs in the last three centuries — by squires, by jubilee committees, by enthusiastic Victorians who wanted a horse of their own — are gone now, grassed over, faint scars you'd miss from a moving car. They had money. They had Saturdays. They had photographs and committees and minutes of meetings. They had everything except the one thing Uffington has, which is a *thousand generations of hands that already know where the mallet points.*

Because it isn't dumping chalk. It's a metre-deep trench that wants to slump and a hillside that wants to creep and a chalk that wants to grey and a shape that only makes sense from a place you can't stand while you're cutting it. You're working blind on the animal's body, hauling chalk up a road that goes nowhere else, and the only way to know you've got the curve of the haunch right is that somebody beside you — somebody whose grandad stopped *them* a hundred times — hovers a palm over your work and you put it back.

Try doing that for twenty years with volunteers. People have. The horse goes green.

These people have done it, by inference, for three thousand. Through plague. Through enclosure. Through a war so total they *turfed the Horse over themselves* so the Luftwaffe couldn't navigate by it — buried their own animal to keep it safe, then dug it back out when the danger passed, as if the burying were just the longest, strangest scour of all.

That's the hole the *just* falls through. Not how do you cut a horse. How does a *how* survive when the *why* is three thousand years dead and the people carrying it can't put it in a sentence?

We're not going to answer that. Look at the palm hovering over the mallet and decide for yourself what's being passed down in that half-inch of air.

The light was going amber in the pub windows. Edie stood, and the canvas roll came up under her arm.

"We're going up," she said. "Walk the lines before dark. Mark where the worst of the slump is, so the crews know come Saturday." She looked round the four of them — Niamh half-up already, Coll folding his map with archival care, the LENS rising slow, Frik last and watching her hands. "You can come."

Niamh's face lit. She started to sign something about helping —

Edie's palm came up. Flat. Two inches off nothing. The exact gesture Maggie had made over the mallet.

"To *watch*," Edie said. Not unkind. Final. "Not to touch the chalk. Not yet." Her eyes found Frik's, because somehow she'd worked out he was the one who'd understand the size of what she was and wasn't offering. "You don't put a hand on the Horse till the Horse knows your hands. You walk it first. You watch how it's done. Then we'll see."

Frik signed: *Understood*.

And he did, more than the others, because he'd just spent an hour learning the whole grammar of this place was a held palm and a thing put back without a word — and he had no intention of being the man who moved the mallet.

They went out into the dusk, up the chalk road that went nowhere, toward the animal you cannot see while you stand on it. The grass had gone blue-grey. Below them the valley held its lights. And ahead, just over the brow, was the long white shape that no one alive could explain and no one alive would let die — waiting, as it had waited a hundred times before, for hands that knew where it pointed.

Edie walked ahead. She did not look back to see if they followed. She knew the road.

Chapter 5 — A Place in the Line

The first thing the LENS got wrong was where to stand.

She'd done this for twenty years, in worse places — found the angle, found the light, found the one frame that held the whole story so a man at a breakfast table four thousand miles away would set down his coffee. She had a hip for it, a way her body folded into a position before her mind caught up. So when the scourers came up the hill in the grey of half-seven, buckets banging against their knees, she went where the picture was: down-slope, below the head, where the long curve of the neck would draw the eye up into the chalk and the sky behind.

A woman of about sixty stepped over her tripod leg without comment and knelt exactly where the LENS had imagined the empty foreground.

She moved. Found another spot. A man set a bucket down on it.

She moved again. A child with a hand-trowel sat where she'd meant to put the camera bag.

It took her four tries to understand that she was not being crowded by accident. The head of the Horse — that strange beaked eye, the staring blank circle of it — was already full of people before she'd found her frame, and they were not arranging themselves for a photograph. They were arranging themselves for work, and the work had a shape, and she was standing in the part of the shape that did not yet exist but was about to.

She lowered the camera. Let it hang. Stood off the line, against the

gorse, and watched.

The official story is clean as a struck coin, and the people who tell it are right.

Below Uffington Castle — an Iron Age hillfort, ditch and bank, sheep cropping the rampart — a horse runs across the upper slope of the chalk. A hundred and ten metres of it, stylised past the point of being any horse you ever met: a body reduced to a few flowing strokes, a long disconnected snout, legs that float. From the valley floor it reads instantly. From up here, beside it, you cannot see it at all. You see white channels in green turf, and your own feet, and the backs of people bent double.

It was made by cutting trenches roughly a metre deep into the hill and packing them with crushed chalk. That depth is not decoration. A shallow scrape would slump, the soil would creep down the slope and swallow it; a metre of packed chalk is an engineering decision, a thing built to *stay*. They dated it by Optically Stimulated Luminescence — quartz grains at the bottom of those trenches, holding the memory of the last sunlight that touched them before burial. Palmer and Miles, the Oxford unit, after the 1990s dig. The answer came back somewhere between thirteen-eighty and five-fifty BC. Late Bronze Age. Older than the hillfort above it. Older, by a long way, than the people who later decided it was a dragon.

That last part is the part the skeptics love, and they're right to. By the Middle Ages nobody here knew what it was. They called it a dragon. They said it climbed the hill at night and went visiting Wayland's Smithy, the great stone barrow off along the Ridgeway. The folklore is a patchwork sewn over a hole. The meaning was gone, fully gone, centuries before anyone wrote a word about it.

And the people kept scouring it anyway.

Sure, the fish says, hanging in the back of the LENS's skull where it always hangs, and you'll have noticed nobody's scouring anything yet. They've been kneeling there twenty minutes. This is the slowest restoration project in Europe.

She didn't argue with the fish. She watched the hands.

Frik had found his spot before any of them, which was the thing about Frik — he never went to the picture, he went to the *room*. He was crouched at the eye, three feet from a man with white dust to his elbows, and he was not looking at the chalk. He was looking at the man's shoulders.

The LENS came up beside him slow, off the line, and waited until he glanced over. He tapped two fingers below his own eye, then pointed: *watch*. Then he held up a flat hand and turned it palm-down, lowering it an inch. *Slow*. Then he did a thing she'd learned to read this week — he pinched thumb and finger together and drew them apart, opening a small precise gap, and tipped his head toward the man's hands.

The man wasn't chalking. He was *checking*. He'd reach into the bottom of the trench with bare fingers, press, feel for something — too soft, too packed, she couldn't tell — and either move on or beckon the child with the bucket. He never spoke. The child never asked. Chalk came when the fingers said it should and not before.

The LENS lifted the camera. Found him at last — not the curve, not the sky. Just the hand in the trench, the wrist white to the bone of it, the green lip of turf above and the seam of new bright chalk below, and the man's face out of focus and entirely calm. She took it. She knew, the way she always knew, that it was the frame.

Frik watched her take it and nodded once, like a man confirming a sum.

The autistic one of the crew — call him Dewi, since the chapter has to call him something, and the page deserves a name — had spent the first hour walking the whole figure end to end with a folding rule and a face full of trouble.

He found the LENS at the head and crouched and said, without preamble, the way he said everything, "They're not making it the same."

She waited.

"The trench at the tail's narrower than the trench at the eye. Three centimetres, maybe four. Consistent — I measured nine points. And

the chalk's a different white. Older. The new stuff's bluer." He turned the rule over in his hands. "So either they re-cut bits on different cycles, or—" He stopped. His jaw worked. "It's not one object. It's a hundred objects laid over each other. Every scouring's a layer. You can't restore it because there's no *it* to restore to. There's just — the last time. And the time before."

There he goes, said the fish, fond now. The skeptic just talked himself off a cliff and landed in the wonder. Happens to the best of them.

Edie Vane had come up the hill while he was talking. She did that — arrived without arriving, the way the local always does on her own ground, so you only registered her once she'd been there a while. She had a bucket of her own and a trowel worn down to a stub, and she set them by the eye with the unhurried care of a woman setting a table she had set ten thousand times.

"You've measured the trenches," she said to Dewi. Not a question.

"The tail's narrower."

"It is." She knelt. Reached in, the same press of the fingers as the man, the same listening hand. "That'll be the Cottrell stretch. They always cut it tight, the Cottrells. Have done since before me. Tighter trench, holds longer on that fall of the ground — it's steeper down the rump, the chalk wants to walk." She glanced up at him, and there was no unkindness in it at all, which was somehow worse than if there had been. "You thought it was a mistake."

"I thought it was — drift. Information lost between generations."

"It's not lost." She pressed the chalk down. "It's in his hands." She tipped her head at the Cottrell man, who had not looked up once. "He couldn't tell you why he cuts it tight. Ask him and he'll say *that's how you do the rump*. That's the whole answer. That *is* the answer."

The LENS lowered the camera and just listened, which is the thing the series keeps asking her to do.

Here is the potato, and it sits on the hillside heavy and plain.

The easy story — the one the consultancy was, at that very hour, three miles away in a council chamber, telling with slides — is that you just

keep chalking it. Renewable. Simple. A bit of community spirit and a wheelbarrow.

So try it. Try keeping a shape alive on a living hill for even one human lifetime, never mind a hundred. The hill is not a canvas; it is a slow animal. Turf creeps down a slope under its own weight, a centimetre a year, two, swallowing edges. Rain undercuts. Frost heaves the chalk and cracks it. Sheep walk where they like. Leave the Horse alone — genuinely alone, no hands — and the figure that has outlasted Rome is gone inside twenty years. Green, blank, a slope like any slope. People have measured this. It is not a metaphor.

And the knowledge that keeps it — the knowledge Edie just named — is not written anywhere. It is not in the OSL paper or the council minutes. *Cut the Cottrell stretch tight because the chalk wants to walk on that fall of the ground.* That sentence has been transmitted, hand to hand, kneeling, for who knows how long, by people who could not have explained it as a sentence at all, who would only say *that's how you do the rump*. The dating is hard science. The depth is measurable engineering. But the thing that actually carries the Horse across three thousand years is a man's fingers knowing a difference of three centimetres he has never once put into words.

And nobody, the fish says, very quietly now, no heckle left in it, *knows why any of it was started. They know exactly how to keep it. They have no idea what it's for.*

The ADHD one — Manon, kinetic, already three friendships deep into the festival committee — came up the hill at a run she'd been told twice not to do near the trenches, and pulled up short, and her whole face fell.

"They voted," she said. "Council. Just now. They've backed it. The Leigh plan. 'Heritage-led restoration in advance of the festival.' Eleven to four."

Nobody said anything. Down the slope a child laughed at something and the sound carried up clean.

"It's not — they're not bulldozing it," Manon went on, fast, the way she got. "Rowan was good. She was really good, you'd have hated how good she was. Drone survey, digital model, 'returning the figure to

its documented Bronze Age form,' she had the OSL right, she had everything right, she—" She stopped. "She said the scouring was 'a wonderful tradition that deserves to be protected.' Protected. Past tense, sort of. Like a thing you put behind glass."

Edie had gone still over her trowel. She didn't look up.

"Documented Bronze Age form," she said, to the chalk. She turned the words over the way Dewi turned his rule. "There isn't one. There's no drawing. There's no original. There's the last time we did it, and the time before, all the way down." She pressed her thumb into the new white and held it there a moment, like checking a pulse. "She wants to fix the shape. You can't fix it. The fixing *is* the shape. Stop the hands and you don't preserve the Horse." She finally looked up, at all of them, at the LENS most of all and the dark eye of her camera. "You just make a very accurate drawing of a dead one."

The LENS lifted the camera and then — and this is the move the book is built to ask of her — she did not take the picture. She let it hang. Some moments are not yours to keep. Some you stand off the line for, against the gorse, and just witness, because the witnessing is the only honest thing your hands can do.

The Cottrell man straightened at the eye, pressed his fist into the small of his back, and for the first time all morning he spoke. Not to them. To the hill, almost.

"Cup of tea," he said, "and we'll start the cheek."

And they did. They moved up the slope by some agreement nobody had voiced, and a space opened at the eye exactly where the LENS had wanted her foreground three hours ago, and now she understood — too late for the photograph and right on time for everything else — that the space had been waiting for the work to reach it. The line moved. There was a place in the line. The vote in the chamber three miles away had decided who owned the Horse, and the line moved up the hill toward the cheek as though it had not heard, because it had been moving up the hill toward the cheek long before there were chambers, and meant to keep moving long after.

Frik caught the LENS's eye and made the gesture again — thumb and finger, the small precise opening gap — and this time she understood it wasn't *slow*. It was *the space*. The gap that opens ahead of the

hands. The place the line is always walking toward and never quite filling.

She nodded. Picked up a trowel.

Knelt down in the part of the shape that did not yet exist.

Chapter 6 — The Hole in the Record

The Tom Brown's School Museum kept its archive in a room that had been a Sunday-school annexe, and still smelled faintly of it — beeswax, damp hymnals, the particular cold of a stone building that the sun never quite gets into. Devindex liked the smell. It had no other associations for him, which was rare, and so he could file it cleanly: *this room, this work, nothing before*. He set his laptop on the long table, levelled it against the warp of the wood with a folded receipt, and waited for Mrs. Athelney to find the key to the map cabinet.

She found it on the third ring of the bunch, on a fob shaped like a tiny horseshoe, and she said so, holding it up. "People give me these. Whole drawer of horseshoe things at home. You'd think nobody in this village ever encountered a different animal."

"The cabinet's a Chubb," Devindex said. "1920s. The lock's older than the contents, probably."

She gave him the look the locals gave him — the half-second recalibration, the *oh, that kind* — and then, to her credit, simply opened the drawer.

What he wanted was the record. Not the Horse itself; the others were up the hill with that, with Edie and the chalk and the long argument about where the consultancy's drone had flown without asking. He wanted the *paper*. The thing the official story rested on. Because the official story was beautiful and he intended to find out exactly how much of it was true.

It went like this, and it was solid, and he had said so to the others on the drive down and would say so again. The Horse is roughly 110 metres of stylised animal cut into the upper slope of White Horse Hill, below the Iron Age ramparts of Uffington Castle. For two centuries everyone agreed it was Saxon — Alfred's victory monument, the parish would tell you, with a straight face and a collection tin. Then in the 1990s the Oxford Archaeological Unit got under it, took quartz grains from the buried lower fill, and ran them through OSL — optically stimulated luminescence, the trick of asking a sand grain when it last saw daylight. The grains answered: somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC. Late Bronze Age. The Saxon story collapsed in an afternoon. Palmer and Miles published it; the dragon-slayers and the King Alfred societies took it on the chin like the good losers they mostly were.

And the engineering held up under any cold eye you cared to bring. The thing wasn't painted on. It was *built* — trenches a full metre deep, packed with crushed chalk, an actual piece of geotechnical cunning that stops the soil from creeping down and smearing the figure into a white blur. You couldn't do it by accident. You couldn't do it without knowing exactly what a hillside does to a line over time.

That was the part Devindex respected. Whoever cut it had thought in *decades*. Maybe longer.

He had the OSL paper open on one screen and Thomas Hughes' *The Scouring of the White Horse* — 1859, the festival rendered in cheerful Victorian three-decker prose, cheese-rolling and backword play and the Horse re-cut by the assembled parish — open on the other. Between them, on the table, Mrs. Athelney was laying out the analogue record like a hand of patience. Churchwardens' accounts. A grant of land. A pageant-master's notes from 1857. Parish minutes. Photographs of men in collarless shirts standing in the chalk with mattocks, grinning the way people grin when someone tells them to.

He started at the back and worked forward, because that was where the lie usually lived, if there was one.

"The festival's well-documented," he said. "Hughes, obviously. The accounts confirm him — there's money changing hands for the pageant in the 1780s, here's a 'cleansing of ye White Horse' in—" he turned a photostat — "1755, in the manor court rolls. Good. That's a

real chain back to the mid-eighteenth century.” He tapped the table once for each fixed point, the way he liked to, planting them. “Before that it thins. There’s a churchwarden’s entry, 1690s, ‘expended on the Horse,’ no detail. And then Aubrey mentions it, second-hand, around the same time. And before *that*—”

He stopped.

Mrs. Athelney was watering a spider plant on the windowsill with a teacup. She didn’t turn round.

“Before that,” he said, “nothing.”

“Before that,” she agreed, “nothing.”

He pulled up his own timeline — the one he’d been building since Reading services, a spreadsheet that to anyone else looked like the inside of a migraine and to him looked like the only honest thing in the building. He had the OSL window plotted as a wide grey band: 1380 to 550 BC. He had the documentary record as a tight, dense column at the right-hand edge, the last three centuries lit up like a city seen from a plane. And between them — between the day the trenches were first packed and the day a Berkshire churchwarden first wrote *the Horse* in an account book — he had nothing. A void. Two and a half thousand years of nothing, give or take an Aubrey.

The official line was that the maintenance was unbroken. He’d read it a dozen times in a dozen guidebooks. *Scoured by the local community every seven to ten years for three thousand years.* And here was the thing he couldn’t make the others feel, up on the hill with chalk on their hands and the warm fact of the festival around them: that sentence had a load-bearing word in it, and the word was *inferred*.

Because you couldn’t document it. You *couldn’t*. The thing was the proof of itself. The Horse was sharp, therefore it had been kept sharp, therefore someone had kept it sharp — across the Roman invasion, the Saxon settlements, the Black Death that came through these very downland villages and took, by some parish reckonings, half of everyone. Across the Civil War. Across the Enclosures that broke the old commons rights to gather, the dissolution of the institutions that might have organised the work, the centuries when nobody knew why they were doing it and the dragon-story had already quietly replaced the truth. The line on his spreadsheet wasn’t a record. It was a de-

duction, drawn backwards from a survival. *It's still here, so it can't have stopped, so it didn't.*

But it *could* have stopped. That was the hole, and it was clean, and he sat in it for a moment to be sure it was real.

If the scouring had lapsed — even once, even for a single human generation — the Horse would be gone. Twenty years of neglect and the grass takes it; that's not folklore, that's measured, that's the timescale on the figures up north that *did* get left, the Tysoe horse ploughed clean out of memory, the ones that exist now only as a wobble in a tithe map. Twenty years. The figure has no buffer. It does not survive on momentum. Every link in the chain is a small group of living people who, in their particular decade, chose to walk up that hill with tools and *do it again*.

So the survival doesn't prove an unbroken chain. The survival proves that *if* it broke, it broke and was re-cut to the old line by people who remembered exactly where the old line had been — which is, when you sit with it, almost stranger.

"There's no document," Devindex said slowly, to the room, "that closes the gap. There can't be. The earliest you can put a human hand on the chalk is — late Saxon, maybe, by the place-name, the hundred's named for the Horse by the eleventh century. But that's the *hill* being named, not the work being recorded. The work itself, the actual scouring, the deciding-to — you can't see it before the 1700s. Everything older is the figure vouching for itself."

He realised he'd raised his voice, slightly, the way he did when the pattern was very good. He brought it down.

Mrs. Athelney put the teacup back on the saucer. She was a small woman, retired from teaching geography in Wantage, and she had the manner of someone who had spent forty years being unsurprised by other people's excitement.

"You want me to find you the receipt," she said. "For the year 200, say. 'One mattock, hire of. Beer for twelve. Re-cutting of the Horse as per custom.'"

"That's exactly what I want."

"There isn't one."

"I know there isn't one. That's the—" he hunted for it "—that's the *interesting* part. The whole structure of the claim rests on a thing that by its nature can't be written down. The keeping doesn't generate paper. It generates a sharp horse."

She considered him. Outside, distantly, he could hear the others — the kinetic one, the ADHD one, laughing at something, a sound carried down on the wind off the scarp.

"My grandfather scoured it," she said. "And his father. And I went up as a girl, in the cart, with the bread and the cheese, and I scoured it, and I was no use, I was eight, but I was *there*, and that's the point of taking an eight-year-old. So that there's a fifty-year-old one day who remembers being eight." She wasn't telling him this to win an argument. She was filing the plant-watering teacup away on a shelf, talking the way you talk while your hands are busy. "Nobody wrote any of that down. Why would you? You don't write down that you breathed."

"But that's the gap," Devindex said. "That's precisely my gap. The chain you're describing is real and I believe every word — and it goes back four generations, *to you*. Past you, past your grandfather's grandfather, it's the same as the Horse: I'm taking it on faith that it didn't stop, because here it is. You can't actually *know* there wasn't a year — sometime in, I don't know, the fourteenth century, plague-year, everyone dead or fled — when nobody came. When it started to grass over. And someone, ten or twenty years later, looked up and saw the ghost of it and dug it back."

She didn't bristle. That was the thing he'd notice afterwards, on the drive, replaying it: she didn't defend the unbroken chain at all. She let it go without a fight, the way you'd let go of a thing you'd never been holding.

"Maybe nobody came one year," she said. "Maybe nobody came for ten. I shouldn't think the Horse minds, particularly. It's not the *not stopping* that's the marvel, is it. It's that they always started again."

He looked at her.

"You're not interested in whether it's unbroken," he said.

"Why would I be?" She seemed genuinely puzzled by the question, which was a thing that almost never happened to him, being on the

receiving end of someone else's *that kind*. "It's done because it's done. You go up because your father went up. If a generation missed it and the next one started again — well. That's not a break. That's the thing *working*. That's the most working thing it could possibly do." She picked the horseshoe fob off the table and dropped it back in the drawer of the desk, among the others he could now see, a whole nest of small iron horseshoes given by people who'd run out of other ways to say *thank you for keeping this*. "You're hunting for the moment it didn't stop. I'd hunt for the moment it nearly did, and somebody decided otherwise. There's more in that. There's the whole of it in that."

Devindex looked back at his spreadsheet. At the dense lit column of the documented centuries, and the long grey void behind it, and the OSL band away at the very edge, three thousand years deep, where a person he would never know had stood on this hillside and thought in decades and packed a metre of chalk into the ground so that the line would not creep.

The void didn't trouble him now the way it had a minute ago. He'd been treating it as a flaw in the record — a missing receipt, a broken link in a citation he wanted to make airtight. And it was that. The honest thing, the thing he'd write in the notes, was that the unbroken chain is *inferred, not documented*, and the inference is only as strong as the survival, and you cannot make it stronger by wishing.

But that wasn't where the question lived. He'd been asking *did it ever stop*, which was a fact-question, and unanswerable, and therefore — he could admit — a little dead. Mrs. Athelney had reached past it without seeming to notice it was there and picked up the live one.

Not: how do we prove it never lapsed.

But: by what mechanism does an act survive the death of its reason? Every generation in his lit column did the work without knowing why the work began. The dragon-story had already eaten the truth before any of them were born. They had no creed, no founder's instruction, no meaning to keep faith with. They had only the doing, and a hill, and an eight-year-old in a cart with the cheese. And it had been *enough*. Three hundred years he could see, and behind it the long grey reach he could only infer, and through the whole of it the same impossible, durable, unwritten *and then we went up again*.

What is a tradition that has outlived its sense — and goes on anyway?
What carries it, if not the meaning?

He saved the file. Out on the wind the others were calling his name, the way you call someone to come and look. Mrs. Athelney was already at the door, holding it, the cold annexe light falling past her up the lane toward the hill.

“They’ll want you for the afternoon stretch,” she said. “Mind your hands. The chalk eats your knuckles, it always has.”

He closed the laptop on the grey void and went out to put his hands in it.

Chapter 7 — The Restoration Pitch

The Uffington village hall smelled of urn-coffee and floor polish and a hundred years of people sitting too close together in coats. Nessa clocked the room before she sat down — that was the thing about Nessa, she couldn't *not*, her attention forever ricocheting off every surface that moved. Forty-odd chairs. A trestle table with a Thermos and a plate of bourbon biscuits curling at the edges. A projector throwing a wonky rectangle onto the wall where some long-dead committee had bolted a noticeboard. Somebody had pinned a child's drawing of the Horse to the felt: all legs and one mad eye, more dragon than anything.

She liked it better than the slideshow already.

The slideshow belonged to Dr. Rowan Leigh, who stood by the projector in a green that was almost certainly chosen to read as *of the land* — not a barbour, that would be trying too hard, but an actual technical jacket, the kind that said *I have been on the hill, I have weather on me*. Leigh was good. Nessa knew good when she saw it because she did a version of it herself, the warm fast lean-in, the use of a person's first name like a small gift handed over. The difference was Nessa did it to *get let in*. Leigh did it to be *believed*.

"Most of you know the figure better than I ever will," Leigh said, and meant it, you could tell, which was the maddening part. "I'm not here to teach anyone about the Horse. I'm here because I'm frightened of losing it."

Murmur. Good murmur. The kind that goes *well, fair enough*.

Behind Nessa, in the second-to-last row, Frik sat very still with his hands folded, watching Leigh's mouth and shoulders and the place where the jaw met the ear. He didn't need the words. He'd told her once, on the drive up, fingers quick in the footwell light: *I read the bit people forget to lie with.* The face above the smile. The hands when the voice gets soft.

The first slide was the Horse from the air. It always stopped a room, that shot — the long white animal pouring across the green like it had been flung there at speed, the beaked head, the disconnected legs that should look broken and instead look like *running*. A hundred and ten metres of it. Three thousand years of it. Nessa felt the room exhale, the involuntary pride of people who live under a thing the whole world comes to look at.

"Late Bronze Age," said Leigh. "We have the science now — optically stimulated luminescence, the Oxford dig, the buried quartz tells us when it last saw daylight. Thirteen-eighty to five-fifty BC, give or take. Older than Alfred, older than the Saxons, older than anyone thought." A beat. "The people who cut this dug trenches a *metre* deep and packed them with crushed chalk. Not a scratch on the surface. A *foundation*. They built it to last, and then —" the warm pause, the gift handed over — "they trusted us to keep it."

That landed. Nessa watched it land. A man near the front, big fore-arms, farmer's neck, gave a single slow nod, the nod of someone who'd carried chalk up that slope on his own back and liked to hear it called *trust*.

The next slide was the potato, though Leigh would never call it that.

It was a hill-figure somewhere else — Nessa didn't catch where, Wiltshire maybe — gone. A pale ghost smear in rough grass, the shape of it only legible if you already knew. "This is what *neglect* looks like," Leigh said quietly. "Twenty years. That's all it takes. Leave the Uffington Horse alone for one human generation and it's gone back into the hill. The chalk weathers grey, the grass creeps the lines, the soil — the soil literally *moves*, it creeps downslope, it eats the edges. Every year the Horse is trying to die, and every few years somebody stops it." Leigh let that sit. "I've watched a scouring. It's beautiful and it's *amateur*. With respect — enormous respect — it's buckets and kneeling-pads and people guessing where the line *was*. The figure

drifts. It's documented. The horse you scoured in 1990 is not quite the horse your grandparents scoured. It moves. Not at night, not to Wayland's Smithy —"

A laugh at that, an in-joke laugh, the dragon-gallops-to-the-Smithy laugh.

"— but it moves. A few centimetres a decade. And nobody's *steering*. We can fix that. We can survey the true historic line, we can stabilise the trenches, we can give your grandchildren the Horse you'd recognise. Not a new horse. The *real* one. Pinned. Saved."

That's the thing, Nessa thought, and felt her own knee start to jig. *That's the actual pitch and it's not even wrong.*

Because it wasn't. That was the whole horrible cleanliness of it. The figure *did* drift. The soil *did* creep — that was literally what the metre-deep trenches were *for*, the genius of the thing, the engineering that turned a doodle on a hill into a monument. And modern restorers really had stood on slopes like this with theodolites and good intentions and made shapes that were sharp and dead. Nessa had seen the consultancy's trial patch herself, two days ago, up on the hill — the re-chalked stretch along the Horse's back where they'd shown what they could do. It was *flawless*. The line ran true as a drawn curve. It looked like a logo. It looked like the Horse had been ironed.

She'd stood there next to Edie Vane looking at that perfect crisp white edge, and Edie hadn't said anything for a long time, and then Edie had said: "He's done the back like a kerbstone," and walked off.

Now Edie sat three rows up, in the good coat she wore for the village, hands in her lap. Nessa could only see the back of her — the set of the shoulders, the unmoving neck — but Frik could see her face from the angle, and Nessa watched *Frik* watch *Edie*, which was its own kind of camera. Whatever Frik saw made him go still in a different way. A held-breath way.

The LENS was in the corner by the fire door, camera down, which the series was always asking the LENS to do and which the LENS, tonight, had done unasked. Just watching. There are moments you don't lift the thing to your eye because lifting it makes you safe and you don't get to be safe for this one.

Leigh moved into the numbers. Funding secured. A heritage

grant, match-funded, the council's name on it as partner, a visitor-experience strand, a schools programme, an app — Nessa lost the app in the noise of her own attention skidding around the room. She was reading the chairs instead. Reading who leaned forward and who went rigid. The farmer with the forearms: leaning. A clump of women near the urn who'd clearly come up together: divided, two nodding, one with her arms crossed so hard her coat creaked. A teenager filming it on a phone, bored. Two old men by the radiator who had the specific stillness of people who had been to a great many meetings and trusted exactly none of them.

This was the thing Nessa did, the thing she was *for*: she could feel a room's weather change before the room knew it had. The council had walked in tonight at maybe sixty-forty against. She could feel it sliding. Leigh was good and the trial patch was sharp and the grant was real and the soil really did creep, and the whole argument was so *reasonable* that to stand against it you'd have to argue *for* decay, for drift, for buckets and guessing.

"Question," said one of the radiator men, not raising his hand. "Who scours it after? Once you've — pinned it."

"Honestly?" Leigh spread both hands. "Maintenance becomes a fraction of what it is now. Stabilised trenches, modern chalk-set — you'd be looking at light touch-ups. The hard labour, the all-hands weekends — we'd be taking that *off* you."

Silence.

And Nessa, who had spent two days up to her wrists in it, who had carried a bucket and knelt on the pad and been shown by a nine-year-old how you tamp the chalk with the heel of your hand so it beds in — Nessa felt the silence and understood it was the wrong kind. Leigh had thought *taking the labour off you* was a gift. Half the room had heard it as a gift. The other half had gone quiet the way you go quiet when someone offers to do your mother's washing-up for the rest of your life.

That was the hole. Right there in the room. Not in the chalk — in the *who does it*.

Because the science was airtight and the drift was real and the trenches were genuinely a metre deep, every measurable thing

Leigh said was true, and underneath all of it sat the one fact the whole pitch sailed straight past: nobody knows what the Horse is *for*. Nobody has known for a thousand years. By the Middle Ages they'd already forgotten it was a horse and called it a dragon. The meaning is *gone* — gone before the slideshow, gone before the science, gone before Alfred. And in all that time, through plague and empire and a war when they *turfed it over* so the bombers couldn't read it and then dug it back out the moment the war was done — in all that time the *doing* never stopped. The reason died and the act didn't. Somebody kept agreeing to climb the hill with a bucket for a thing they couldn't explain.

And Leigh was offering, with total sincerity, to fix the one part that had never broken.

Nessa wanted, badly, to stand up and say all that. She had it lined up, fast and hot, the way things lined up in her when the room was sliding. She half-rose.

Frik's hand touched her sleeve. Two fingers. *Wait*. And then, low, the smallest sign, the one she did know cold by now: *her*.

Eddie hadn't moved. But the chair of the council — a tired man named Pargeter with reading glasses pushed up into grey hair — had turned to her, because of course he had, because you don't run this vote past the village without running it past a Vane. "Eddie? You've not said."

The room turned with him. You could feel it turn, the weather of forty coats swinging onto one woman who had scoured this Horse since before some of them were born, whose great-grandmother's hands were in the chalk somewhere, packed down under all the later hands.

Eddie took her time. When she stood she didn't stand like a speaker. She stood like someone getting up to do a job.

"That's a lovely back you've put on him, up there," she said to Leigh. Pleasant. "Crisp. My dad would've hated it."

A ripple. Half laugh, half breath-held.

"He's not wrong about the drift," Eddie went on, and Nessa felt her own argument get quietly taken out of her hands and done *better*, with less heat, by someone with the standing to do it. "He moves.

Course he moves. We move him. You scour where you remember the line, and where your knee tells you the line was, and a bit where you reckon it ought to be, and the next lot do the same, and so he walks. Few inches a lifetime.” She paused. “He’s been walking for three thousand years. You’d like to stop his feet.”

Nobody laughed at that.

“You can survey the *true* line.” Edie said *true* like she was holding it up to the light to see the flaw in it. “Whose true. The one from the dig? That’s the line as it was when the soil last covered it. Pick a year and pin him to it and you’ve got a photograph. We’ve not been keeping a photograph. I don’t —” and here her voice did something, not crack, just *narrow*, the way a person’s voice narrows around something they’re not going to let everyone see — “I don’t actually know what we’ve been keeping. None of us do. We lost the why of it a long time back. We just never lost the doing.”

Frik’s hands were still. Watching her face. Whatever was there, he had it, and he didn’t translate it for the room, and that was right.

“So no,” Edie said. “From me. But it’s not mine to say no.” She sat back down. “It’s the council’s.”

It was, in the end, very quiet and very ordinary, the way the worst turns are.

Pargeter cleared his throat. The grant was real. The match-funding lapsed if they didn’t move this season. The trial patch was, whatever anyone’s father would have thought, undeniably *sharp*, and there is a part of every committee that wants the sharp thing, the fixed thing, the thing you can put in a report. He proposed a motion that was very careful and full of words like *preliminary* and *in partnership* and *subject to review*, which is how you say yes when you want to be able to say later that you didn’t.

The hands went up. Not all of them. Enough.

Leigh didn’t gloat. That was almost the worst of it — Leigh looked *relieved*, looked moved, said “thank you, genuinely, all of you,” and meant the *genuinely*, and started gathering the laptop with the slightly shaky hands of someone who has just been allowed to save a thing they love.

The radiator man who'd asked about the scouring after got up and left without his coffee.

Out in the car park the wind had got up off the Ridgeway and the Horse was somewhere above them in the full dark, running where it always ran, where you couldn't see it from up close, where you've never been able to see the whole shape from the ground — only from the valley, only from the air, only from far enough away that you can't touch it.

Edie came out last. She stood a second in the lit doorway and then walked past the lot of them toward her car, and Nessa, who could read a room's weather before the room could, found she could not read this woman's face at all in the dark, and didn't try.

The fish, if a fish had been there, might have said: *they voted to save the one part that didn't need saving and skipped the part nobody can explain.* But there was no fish in the car park. Just the wind, and the buckets stacked by the hall door for a scouring that was, as of tonight, somebody else's to begin.

Chapter 8 — Scouring School

Six in the morning and the hill had its own weather. Down in the valley Uffington was still under mist, the church tower poking out like a thing waiting to be drawn, but up here on the white slope the sun had already come over the shoulder of the Down and laid the grass over in a long wet shine. Frik stood at the edge of the figure with his hands in his pockets and watched the light find the chalk.

You could not see the Horse from here. That was the first thing the books never quite made you feel. From the ridge above, where they'd parked, the figure was a senseless scatter of pale curves, a foot here, a beak-faced muzzle there, a stretched belly-line you could not connect to anything. You had to stand in the valley to see the animal run. Or, the books said, you had to fly. Three thousand years before anyone flew, somebody cut a shape into a hillside that only made sense from the air, and then the people who made it walked down to the valley to check their work and lived their whole lives never once seeing it whole the way a bird did.

Eddie Vane came up the slope with a bucket in each hand and did not say good morning.

She set the buckets down by the Horse's eye — the eye was a separate ring of chalk, a hole within the head, which everyone found strange and nobody could explain — and she looked at the four of them lined up along the lip of the trench in their bright waterproofs, and her face did a thing Frik read instantly because reading faces was the whole of how he'd survived a hearing world: she was deciding whether this was worth her morning.

The signing interpreter, Mara, stood at Frik's shoulder and lifted her hands to render Edie. But Edie hadn't spoken. She was just looking. Mara waited.

Frik liked her for not talking. Most people, faced with the deaf one, performed. They over-mouthed, they pointed, they did the slow loud thing with their eyebrows up. Edie just looked at him as if she'd clocked exactly what he was — the one who watched — and had decided she'd watch back.

She crouched and put her bare hand flat on the chalk.

Then she looked at Frik and turned her palm up. *Come.*

He went and crouched beside her. The others stayed where they were, which was right; she'd called one.

The chalk under his hand was not what he'd expected. He'd expected something like pavement, packed and dead. This was cold and a little damp and faintly giving, a paste of crushed white stone gone slightly to mud at the surface, and under it, when he pressed, the hard. The trench ran down a full metre, the diggers in '90 had found, packed with chalk all the way, and that was the engineering that kept the shape from bleeding away under three thousand years of soil creeping downhill. A metre of white packed into a hill to hold a line. Nobody told the Bronze Age it would be easy.

Edie said something to Mara, who signed it: *Feel where it ends.*

Frik moved his hand sideways. The chalk went on, and on, and then — there. A lip. A softening. A place where the white slurred into green, where the grass had crept in over the season, a few centimetres of takeover. He could feel the edge of the Horse trying to dissolve.

He looked up.

Edie nodded. Then she did something with her own hand — laid it on the same edge, and with two fingers, gently, almost tenderly, she scraped the encroaching turf back, peeling green off white like skin off fruit, and underneath, the chalk was bright as a tooth.

That's all it is, her face said. *That's the whole secret.*

It was not, of course. That was the thing about the easy version. Just keep chalking it. The skeptics — and Frik had a real fondness for the

skeptics, the men with clipboards who'd said for two hundred years that the Horse was nothing but maintenance and folklore and human stubbornness, no magic about it — the skeptics were *right*. There was no spell. There was no secret. A child could be shown what Edie had just shown him in eight seconds: scrape back the grass, pack new chalk, keep the line.

And the skeptics had never once managed to keep a hill-figure alive on their own.

The autistic one — Sanele, who'd been silent since the car, vibrating at a frequency the rest of them had learned to leave alone — had walked the entire outline already. Twice. He came back to them now and stood a little apart and said, to no one, to the air, in the flat clear way he had:

"Twenty years."

Edie turned.

"If you stopped," Sanele said. "If everyone here stopped, this year. The line holds maybe two seasons. Five years, the legs are guesswork. Twenty, it's a pale stain you'd need a drone to see. There are figures on the Downs that *did* stop. The Westbury horse had to be cemented. The cement one isn't alive. It's a photograph of a horse."

He wasn't being cruel. He was the most precise person Frik had ever met and precision in his mouth came out sounding like a verdict. Edie did not take it as one. She tilted her head at him the way she'd tilted it at Frik, the *I see what you are* tilt, and Frik watched something pass between the careful man and the chalk woman that did not need Mara at all.

"You've done your homework," Edie said. Mara signed it.

"It's not homework," Sanele said. "It's the landscape. It tells you if you look. The grass wants the hill back. The hill's been arguing with the grass for three thousand years and the only thing keeping the horse from losing is people coming up here with buckets."

Edie picked up one of the buckets. "Then let's argue with the grass."

She taught them the way you teach a thing that has no manual.

Not a lecture. There was almost nothing she would say in words, and Frik noticed — he always noticed — that the parts she *could* have put in words were the parts she put in her hands instead, because that was where they lived. She showed Thandi, the kinetic one, the ADHD one who could not hold still and had already befriended a man's dog three fields over, how to break the chalk. You didn't lay it on whole. You took the lumps and you crushed them, by hand or with the back of a mallet, into a coarse white grit, because crushed chalk packed and bonded and the rain wedded it; a slab just sat on the surface and slid off in the first storm. Thandi caught it in about four seconds and then made it better, found a rhythm, mallet-mallet-scoop, talking the whole time, and the chalk dust went up off her hands in a little ghost.

The LENS hung back with the camera, as the LENS always did, finding the edge of the frame and living there. Frik watched her watch. She'd been to places where the thing she pointed the lens at was about to die. He thought sometimes the camera was a way to stand at the edge of a thing without having to step into it. Edie clocked her too — clocked the not-stepping-in — and let her be. For now.

To Frik, Edie gave the edge.

She put him on the line itself, the boundary where white met green, and she did not tell him to be neat. He understood that within the first metre. The consultancy's trial patch, the one they'd rechalked with the laser-cut template and the bagged industrial chalk, the one the whole village had walked up to look at and then quietly walked away from — that patch was *neat*. Crisp as a logo. Frik had photographed it. It looked like the Horse had been replaced overnight by an insurance advert for the Horse.

Edie's line was not neat. She let the edge breathe. Where the old scourers before her had let a curve go slightly proud, she kept it proud. Where the muzzle ran thin she ran it thin. She was not restoring the Horse to a correct shape. She was renewing the shape that the *last* people had left, who had renewed the shape the people before *them* had left, and somewhere down at the bottom of that stack of hands was a hand from the Bronze Age, and nobody in the chain had ever drawn it from a plan because there was no plan, there was only the line you were handed and the line you handed on.

Frik scraped back a tongue of grass and packed white into the gap and smoothed it with his palm and felt, doing it, a thing he had no word for and didn't reach for one.

He looked up to find Edie already looking at him.

She'd seen it land. Of course she had. She'd been watching the room — this room, this hill, with its single ancient occupant — her entire life.

She made a sign. Not BSL; her own. A flat hand passed once over the chalk, slow, like calming an animal.

He copied it.

She nodded, and turned away, and the nod was worth more than anything in any of the books, because the nod meant *not wrong*.

By eight the mist had burned off the valley and you could see the whole green sweep down to the village and the Manger below, that strange dry combe the meltwater carved at the end of the last ice age, all of it soft and grazed and timeless-looking in the way that fooled people. None of it was timeless. Every inch of it was kept. The sheep kept the grass; the farmers kept the sheep; the scourers kept the Horse; and the Horse, Sanele had said somewhere in the early dark, the Horse kept the people coming back.

Frik sat back on his heels with chalk to the elbow and watched Edie inspect their morning's work. She walked the whole length of it. The eye, the ear, the long impossible muzzle that some said was a beak and the dragon-people said was the dragon's snout and the truth was nobody knew, nobody had known for so long that even the *misremembering* of it was medieval, the dragon story already old when Thomas Hughes wrote up the festival in 1859, the meaning gone so far back that the loss of the meaning was itself an antique.

That was the hole, and Frik felt it open under him the way he'd felt the metre of chalk go down under his palm.

Not how it was made. They knew how. Trenches, chalk, OSL dating, 1380 to 550 BC, the science clean and unsexy and certain. Not even *that* it was kept — the keeping was the most documented thing about it. The hole was the *transmission*. How does the doing pass down a

hundred generations through plague and conquest and a world war when the army literally turfed the whole thing over so the Luftwaffe couldn't navigate by it — turfed it over, killed the line on purpose — and then, after, somebody came back up the hill and dug it out again? Why come back? The meaning was already gone by then by a thousand years. They didn't come back for the meaning.

He looked at his own white hands.

He didn't reach past it. Edie wouldn't have let him, and he didn't want to. The wonder wasn't in solving it. The wonder was that it was sitting right there, scrubbed clean as the chalk under the grass, and no one could say why the hands kept coming, only that they did, that here were four more pairs of them this morning, and a fifth behind a camera, and a sixth on the road somewhere bringing the van round.

Edie came back to where Frik sat. The others gathered without being called.

She crouched again, where she'd crouched at the start, and put her hand flat on the part Frik had done, and left it there a moment, reading it through her palm the way he'd read the edge through his.

Then she stood, and wiped her hand on her trousers, and looked at the four of them — and at the LENS, who lowered the camera a fraction, which was as far as the LENS ever came.

"Saturday," Edie said. Mara signed it. "The scouring."

She paused. Frik watched her choose the next words, and watched her decide not to dress them up.

"There'll be sixty, seventy people up here. Schoolkids. The society lot. My nan's friends, the ones who can still get up the slope. The consultancy will be down in the valley with their drone and their good coffee, telling the council how we're doing it wrong." Something that was almost a smile. "We've been doing it wrong, by their lights, for three thousand years."

She picked up a bucket and held it out — not to Frik, to all of them, an offer with a handle on it.

"You can stand at the edge with the camera and film the quaint old

custom. Plenty have. Or” — and here she looked at Frik, and then at Sanele, and then at Thandi, and she let the look take its time — “you can carry chalk.”

Mara’s hands stilled.

For a second nobody moved. The grass hissed in the wind that always ran over the Down. Down in the valley a dog was barking — Thandi’s new friend, probably. The Horse lay all around them, half-renewed, breathing white through the green, going nowhere, the way it had gone nowhere for longer than there’d been an England to go nowhere in.

Thandi reached out and took the bucket by the handle.

“Hands,” she said. “Not cameras.”

Edie didn’t smile this time. She just let go of the bucket, and let it be theirs, and turned to look down the long pale shape of the thing she’d never been able to see whole, the way none of her family ever had, the way you’d have to leave the ground to manage — and she said, to the Horse more than to them:

“Then you’d best learn to crush chalk faster.”

Chapter 9 — Hands in the Chalk

The hammers came out at seven, before the dew burned off, and nobody told us what to do with them.

That was the first lesson, though we didn't clock it as a lesson until later. Edie Vane handed Tem a long-handled wooden mallet — older than Tem, older than Tem's father, the head worn shiny on one face and splintered to felt on the other — and said, "You'll want the smooth side," and walked off up the slope to a knot of people who already knew which side they wanted.

So we stood on the flank of a 3,000-year-old horse holding tools like waiters who'd been handed instruments at a wedding band's interval, and we watched.

You have to understand what we were looking at. The official version is clean and it is correct, and I'll give it to you straight because it deserves that. Sometime between roughly 1380 and 550 BC — that's the OSL date, Palmer and Miles, buried quartz read for the last sunlight it saw, hard science, not a guess — Late Bronze Age people came to this hill and cut trenches a full metre deep. Not scratches. Trenches. Then they packed them with crushed white chalk, and they did it in a shape that makes no sense from where they were standing. You cannot see the Horse from above it. You stand on its back and you see a white scribble, a bend of line that could be anything. The figure only assembles itself from the valley, or from the air. They built a thing they could not see, for an eye that was not theirs.

And then somebody re-cut it. And somebody after that. And on, and on, every seven or ten years, through Rome arriving and Rome leaving,

through the plague years, through a man called Alfred and the people who decided for centuries the Horse was his when it was a thousand years older than him, through the morning in 1940 they covered the whole thing with turf and brush so the Luftwaffe couldn't navigate by it, and through the afternoon they took the turf off again. Re-cut. Re-chalked. The shape held because hands held it.

The fish, perched on Tem's mallet head, examined the splintered face. "Tradition," it said, "is just peer pressure with better PR."

Frik figured out the work before any of us, because Frik wasn't waiting to be told. He never is. Words are weather to Frik — present, sometimes useful, mostly missed by the people making them — so he reads the room the way the rest of us read a sentence, and the room here was doing something specific. He watched a woman in her sixties kneel at the Horse's belly line, watched her run a flat palm along the chalk-packed trench, find a spot where grass had crept a thumb's width over the white, and not pull it. She tapped it. Two short taps with two fingers. A teenager three metres off looked up, came over, knelt, and pulled it — and the woman had already moved on.

Frik nudged me and signed it back: the tap, the look, the handover. *She doesn't do it. She shows where.* Then, after a beat, a gesture I didn't have a clean translation for — palm cupping something and passing it sideways. He did it twice. The second time I got it. *Handed down. Right now. In front of us.*

The autistic half of our pattern-spotting brain — call him Sol, everyone does — had gone quiet, which with Sol means loud. He was crouched at the Horse's eye, the strangest part of the figure, a separate ring of chalk that doesn't touch the head, and he was counting. Counting what, he wouldn't say yet. His lips moved. His hand went out flat over the chalk and hovered, mapping the slope, the fall of the land, the way the eye sat on a swell of hill so it caught light a half-beat before the rest. He'd been on the OSL paper for three days. He could recite the trench depth, the date range, the soil-creep mechanics — a metre down so the chalk wouldn't migrate downhill, so the line wouldn't blur, engineering and not decoration. He had the *what*. He was hunting the *where exactly*, which is a different animal.

Bex got us in. Bex always gets us in. ADHD runs through her like current and she can't sit through a briefing to save her life, but drop

her among strangers doing a thing with their hands and within twenty minutes she's holding the thing, asking the loud honest questions everyone else is too polite to ask, and being adopted. By eight she'd learned the mallet was for tamping fresh chalk into the trench, that you didn't want it crisp, that the trick was to break the chalk lumps with the smooth face and then leave it rough — *leave it rough* — because the Horse wasn't supposed to look new.

"Why not?" she asked the man teaching her, a farmer named Gethin with chalk to his elbows.

Gethin thought about it the way you think about why you tie your shoes the way you tie them. "Looks wrong if it's too sharp," he said. "Looks like a logo."

We had, of course, seen exactly that. We'd watched the consultancy's trial patch from the field two days back — Dr. Rowan Leigh's "demonstration of best-practice conservation," a panel of the Horse's hind leg re-laid by their team with graded chalk and a string line and a level, every edge ruled, the white so even it looked printed. From the valley floor it had stood out from the rest of the figure like a crowned tooth. Crisp. Correct. Dead. A potato of the highest funding, a thing that had every fact right and the whole point wrong, and the worst of it was that you couldn't argue Rowan was *wrong*, exactly. The chalk was good chalk. The depth was to spec. It was preservation, by any sane definition of the word. It just wasn't the Horse.

Here's the potato proper, and I want you to actually feel it. The "easy" story is: just keep chalking it. Anyone could do that. Except: leave this figure alone and it's gone inside twenty years — grass takes it, soil creeps, the line softens and then it's a pale smudge and then it's a field. So somebody has to come back. Fine. Get somebody to come back. Except the somebody has to know that the eye doesn't touch the head, and which patches to leave rough, and that you tap rather than pull, and that the smooth face of the mallet goes down, and how much to do and — crucially — how much *not* to do, because a hill is alive and a too-keen scouring strips it as surely as neglect lets it fade. None of that is written anywhere with any authority. Hughes wrote a whole book about the festival in 1859 and it's a glorious document and it does not tell you which side of Gethin's grandfather's mallet to use. It's in the hands. It's only in the hands.

“So it’s a recipe,” said the fish, “passed down by people who never wrote it, for a cake nobody remembers the occasion of.”

By mid-morning they’d stopped watching us watch and started correcting us, which is how you know you’re in. Sol got moved off the eye — too much hovering, not enough scraping — and put on the belly with a hand-rake, and the woman who’d tapped earlier, whose name turned out to be Phyllida, came and stood over him and didn’t say a word for a long minute, then took the rake, did four strokes, gave it back. Sol matched her four strokes exactly. She watched, nodded once, left. He told me afterward, low and precise, that her stroke fell with the slope and his had been fighting it, and that he could feel the difference in his shoulder but not see it, and that this annoyed him profoundly and he was going to think about it for some time.

Somewhere up near the head, someone started singing.

It wasn’t a performance. It came up out of the work the way steam comes off a horse, two voices then four, an old tune with a lot of repeats in it and words half of them clearly didn’t have all of, filling gaps with *la* and the line that did land, which was something about the horse and the hill and not letting go. Frik felt it before he could have heard a note of it — felt it in the way the bodies on the slope changed, the way the mallets found the beat, the tamping falling into the song’s pulse without anybody deciding. He looked at me and put his hand flat on his own chest and then opened it toward the slope. *They’re keeping time to it.* Then the cupped-palm sign again. *Handed down.*

The Lens hadn’t shot a frame.

This is worth saying because the Lens always shoots. The Lens came to us out of three wars and a folder of pictures most of us will never see, and the camera is the wall between the Lens and the rooms the Lens has been in, and we have spent two books quietly asking the Lens to lower it. And here, on the chalk, in the singing, the camera was down. Hanging. The Lens was on knees with both hands in a trench, packing chalk, getting it under the fingernails, and there was an expression there I’d seen maybe twice — once at a kitchen table in the first book and once I won’t write about — the expression of someone who has remembered, for an hour, that hands are also for this. I caught Edie watching the Lens watch nothing, and Edie’s face

did something it hadn't done in the four days we'd known her. It softened.

She came down the slope to us at the noon break, when the flasks came out and the foil came off the sandwiches and the whole hill sat down on its haunches in the sun. She sat by me with a mug and looked out over the valley, where the figure ran white under us, illegible from this angle, a stroke of nothing.

"You didn't fix the rough patches," she said. "I watched you. Bex left them."

"Bex was told to," I said.

"People get told to and fix them anyway," Edie said. "Can't help themselves. Want it nice." She drank. "You lot leave things alone. That's rarer than you'd think."

I asked her — because I'd been holding the question for four days and the chalk had earned me an inch of it — whether she knew what the Horse was for. The original thing. The why.

She didn't answer for a while. Down the slope the song had stopped and the eating had its own sound.

"My nan didn't know," Edie said finally. "Her nan didn't know. We've a long way back of not knowing." She turned the mug in her hands. "People come up here wanting me to *tell* them, and they think I'm being cagey. I'm not being cagey. There's a thing I can tell you and a thing I can't, and the thing I can't isn't a secret, it's just — gone. Burned off. Long before any of us." She looked at me sidelong, dry, the teacher in her surfacing. "What I can tell you is what it's *for now*. But you've not earned that yet. You've earned about half a morning of mallet."

"She's better at this than you are," the fish observed, delighted. "She's holding the answer and making you scour for it. That's the whole gag, isn't it."

And here's the hole, which I'll set down cold and leave open, the way the work taught me to leave the rough patches. Every part of the official story is documented. The date, the depth, the disappearance-in-twenty-years, the festival in Hughes, the turf over it in the war. All of it stands up. The single thing that does not stand up to documen-

tation — that *cannot*, by its nature — is the chain itself. The unbroken handing-down. We say “essentially unbroken” because the figure survived and the OSL date is what it is, and a figure that vanishes in twenty years untended and is here after three thousand years was tended, again and again, by people who learned it from people who learned it from people. The survival is the proof. But there is no register. No ledger of every scouring back to the Bronze Age. The thing is true and unprovable at once, which is a deeply uncomfortable place for a fact to live, and it lives there, on the flank of the hill, in Phyllida’s four strokes and the half-remembered song and the way Gethin couldn’t say why not-too-sharp except that it’d look like a logo.

How does a *doing* survive when the *why* is dead? Not the story. The hands. How do you transmit four strokes that fall with the slope, across plague and empire and a war that buried the whole figure, when nobody ever wrote them down?

I’m not going to answer that. I don’t think Edie was either, not fully, not yet. That’s the wink, and you can sit in it as long as you like.

We were sitting in it when the sound came.

A small mechanical whine, rising, the sort of noise that doesn’t belong on a hill. Bex heard it first — Bex hears everything, all at once, always — and her head went up. Then Sol’s. The hill went quiet the way a field of sheep goes quiet, every face tilting.

The drone came over the shoulder of Uffington Castle and dropped to fifty feet, then forty, a four-rotor thing with a gimbaled camera underslung, and it began to fly the Horse. Methodically. Nose to tail along the back, then out along the legs, holding altitude, mapping. Reading the lines from the one angle the Bronze Age builders made them for, the eye they never had — the eye from above — and taking it, frame by frame, for a model on a hard drive in a consultancy’s office, where the Horse could be made correct, and ruled, and kept forever exactly as it would never look on the living hill.

Up the slope, Phyllida set down her mug. Gethin stood. The song did not start again.

Edie watched the drone make its slow legible pass over the figure she could not, from here, see whole, and she said, very quietly, not to me:

“They’re reading it from the wrong height.”

Then she put down her mug and stood, and the whole hill stood with her.

Chapter 10 — Lines and Loss

The tent had walls of stretched white nylon and the light inside it was the light of a hospital, of a place where something is going to be measured and then improved. Saul felt it before he saw the screens — that particular hum of a generator behind canvas, the wrongness of cold blue glow on a hillside that had been doing fine for three thousand years on weather and chalk dust and the angle of the sun.

Outside, the down was green going gold at the edges, and the Horse lay where it always lay, its long body legible only if you walked down into the valley and turned and looked back up. Inside the tent, the Horse had been brought indoors and made to behave.

There were four screens. On the largest, the figure floated in a grey void, scrubbed clean of grass and hill, rendered as pure outline — a vector ghost, every curve plotted to a tolerance. Saul read the screen the way he read everything, which was all at once and then in pieces: the registration marks in the corners, the small green numbers ticking the coordinate of his own breath as someone moved a cursor, the legend down the left side. *Survey mesh. Drone capture, 1,200 images, photogrammetric model.* And beneath that, the thing his eye had snagged on from the doorway, the thing that had pulled the whole rest of the room into focus:

Two outlines. One white. One amber.

The white was the Horse as the drone had found it last Tuesday. The amber sat over it like a corrected sentence, a teacher's pen through a child's spelling — *here, and here, and here* — and where the two diverged, the software had shaded the gaps a soft accusing pink.

Dr. Rowan Leigh was talking, and talking well. Saul made himself attend to the words and not just the shape of them, because the words were the official story said cleanly, with love, and you had to grant a thing its dignity before you could find the hole in it.

“What we’re looking at,” Leigh said, “is drift.”

She had a way of standing slightly to the side of her own slides, so she never blocked them, the way a good museum guide never gets between you and the case. The locals had filed in — Saul counted nine, then eleven, the back of the tent thickening — and they stood with the particular stillness of people on land they know watching a stranger explain it to them.

“The Horse you see today is not the Horse of 1990,” Leigh went on. “It isn’t the Horse of 1850, either. Every scouring shifts the line a little. A boot scuffs the trench edge. New chalk packs a centimetre wide of the old. Over a century, over many centuries —” the amber outline pulsed once, helpfully — “you get migration. The beak of the head has crept. The disconnected legs have wandered. The body has, frankly, fattened.”

Somebody near the door laughed, short, then thought better of it.

“None of this is anyone’s fault,” Leigh said, and she meant it; Saul watched her mean it, watched the small openness in her face that wasn’t a sales tactic. “It’s the price of being loved by hand. Every act of care leaves a fingerprint. Multiply the fingerprints across a hundred generations and the original draughtsman’s intent is buried under all that affection. What our model does —” she let the amber line settle, lock, brighten — “is recover it. We took the OSL-dated trench profile, the deepest packed chalk, the bits that haven’t been disturbed since the figure was first cut. We worked back to the line they actually dug. We can give you the Horse the Bronze Age made. Not the Horse three thousand years of guessing has made of it.”

It was, Saul thought, a beautiful argument. That was the trouble with it.

He looked at the OSL figure on the lower screen and the science was real and he loved it. He had read the Palmer and Miles paper twice on the drive down, the careful business of buried quartz holding the memory of the last sunlight it ever saw, the lab teasing that date back

out — thirteen-eighty to five-fifty BC, the number that had taken the Horse off King Alfred and the Saxons and handed it to people who left no name. The trenches a full metre deep, packed with crushed chalk, engineered — *engineered*, that was the word that got him — so the hill's slow downhill creep wouldn't smear the shape. Whoever cut it had understood that a line on a living slope is not a line you draw once. It is a line you commit to maintaining or it is not a line at all.

That was where the amber outline lied, and it lied so gently that Saul could feel the room half-believing it.

He found Frik across the tent and made the small flat gesture they used for *watch* — *them, not it*. Frik's eyes were already going around the locals' faces, that ceaseless reading, and Frik signed back, low against his chest where only Saul would catch it: a closed fist, then opened slow. *Holding still. They're holding still.*

Eleven people on their own hill, holding very still.

And Edie Vane, by the tent pole, saying nothing at all.

Here is the potato, and you have to handle it honestly or it bites you.

Say you agree with Leigh. Say the drift is real — and it is; the survey is real, the migration is measurable, you can overlay the 1990 dig photos on a modern capture and watch the beak walk. Say you decide, reasonably, lovingly, that the right thing is to fix it. To stop the wandering. To lay down the true line and from now on scour to *that*, to a model, to a number, so the next three thousand years don't blur it further.

Now go and do it.

You will need the community to scour to your line and not their own. You will need the man whose grandfather packed the off-fore hoof to pack it eight centimetres to the east of where his grandfather packed it, because the model says so, because the model is right. You will need the children — and there are always children, with their fistfuls of chalk and their faces white to the elbow — to stop filling the trench by feel, by the shape their hands already know, and to start filling it by station and offset and a tablet held by a man from Oxford.

And the moment you do that, the act changes from a thing the hill's people do into a thing that is done *to* the hill, by a plan, from outside. You have not saved the Horse. You have made the Horse a print of itself, very accurate, and stopped the living thing that was making it.

That is the potato. The easy fix — *just chalk it correctly* — is correct, and it kills the only thing that ever kept the figure alive, which is people doing it wrong, together, by hand, the same wrong way their grandmother showed them, year on year, until the wrongness is the Horse.

Leigh wasn't wrong about the drift. She was wrong about what the drift *was for*. But nobody in the tent had said that yet, and it wasn't going to be the crew who said it. Saul could feel the others knowing this too — Petra near the entrance flap with her phone already winning over two scourers, charming, kinetic, asking about the meal they cooked the night of the scouring, not the line at all; the Lens off in the corner with the camera up but not, yet, taking. Just framing. Just holding the room the way the Lens held everything, the way you hold a thing you might have to lower.

"Can I ask," said a woman near the front, "what happens to the bits you call wrong."

Leigh turned to her with real warmth. "Nothing happens to them. We document them. They're part of the figure's story — the whole accreted history of care, all that drift, it's a record, it's precious. We'd archive every layer. Then we'd cut the recovered line."

"So you'd cut a new trench."

"We'd cut *the* trench. The original. The one underneath."

"Underneath," the woman said. "Through ours."

There it was, the small cold seam in the warm argument, and the woman had her thumb in it without raising her voice. *Through ours*. To get to the Bronze Age line you go down through everything laid over it since. Through the chalk packed in 1857, the year Hughes wrote the festival down, the games and the cheese-rolling and the whole down black with people. Through the turfing-over of the war, when they hid the Horse from German bombers who'd have used it as

a road-sign to Swindon, and the men who turfed it knowing exactly where every line was because they had it in their hands. Through the unrecorded thousand scourings nobody wrote down because why would you write down breathing.

You cannot recover the first line without removing all the love stacked on top of it. The model could show both. The trowel could only choose.

Leigh felt the seam too. She was good. “We wouldn’t do anything,” she said, “the community didn’t want. I want to be very clear. This is a proposal. We think it’s the most respectful thing — to give you back the figure your ancestors actually made, instead of the slow accident of —”

She stopped, because she’d been about to say *of your care* and she heard it.

The generator hummed. On the screen the amber Horse and the white Horse hung over each other, the pink shame-shading in the gaps, and Saul thought: *that pink is the part where the people are. They’ve shaded the people pink and labelled them error.*

Edie still hadn’t spoken.

Saul had learned, in Book One, on the other hill, that Edie Vane’s silences were not empty. They were the silence of someone who has the answer and is deciding whether the room has earned it. She stood by the pole with her arms folded and her weathered teacher’s face giving nothing, and Frik was watching her the way you watch the one person in a room who actually knows, and Frik signed to Saul, very small: a hand laid flat on the back of the other hand. *She’s holding it. Still holding it.*

The whole tent was waiting for Edie to say the thing. And Edie was not going to say the thing, not here, not in the blue light, not to the screens. That was its own answer and Saul loved her for it. The “what is it for” was hers. She would not spend it in a tent.

It was Petra who broke the held air, kinetic, sideways, the way she always came at a locked room — not at the lock. She’d drifted up beside one of the scourers, a big quiet man in a fleece, and she said,

not quietly, to him and not to Leigh: “How do *you* know where the line goes? When you scour. Do you measure?”

The man almost smiled. “Measure,” he said, like the word was a small joke. “You stand in it.” He looked at the amber ghost on the screen as if it were a photograph of a relative who’d been heavily retouched. “You stand in the trench your dad stood in and you fill it where your hands say. You don’t look at the whole horse. You can’t, from up here. You just do your bit and trust the next one’s doing theirs.” He shrugged. “It comes out a horse.”

It comes out a horse. Saul wrote nothing down. He had it. Nobody up on the hill ever sees the Horse they’re making. The form is only legible from the valley, from the air — from where the hands aren’t. Every scourer works blind to the whole, fills their metre of trench by feel and by faith that everyone else is filling theirs, and the figure assembles itself out of all that trust, out of nobody being able to check. The drift Leigh wanted to correct wasn’t error. It was the sound of a thing made by people who can’t see what they’re making and do it anyway. For three thousand years. On faith that the next hand knows.

You could not put that on a screen. You could put its absence on a screen, shaded pink.

And then the flap opened and the cold day came in, and one of Leigh’s people — young, mud to the knee, breathless in the way of someone who has run uphill with news — said, “Rowan. You need to come and see. The east trench.”

Leigh went still. “See what.”

“We were taking the profile core. By the off-hind.” The young man held up something, and the blue light caught it, and it was not white. It was the wrong white — older, harder, a packed grey-white lump the size of a fist, threaded with something dark, and it had the density of a thing that had been crushed and tamped and then buried under everything that came after. “It’s chalk packing,” he said. “But it’s *under* the layer we modelled. It’s deeper than the bottom of the trench we surveyed. It doesn’t match the curve.” He turned it in his hand and the room leaned. “The line down there goes somewhere

else. The original — it's not where the model put it. It's not where the *Horse* is."

Leigh took it from him. Held it the way you hold something that has just rewritten an afternoon.

On the big screen, the amber Horse hung there, certain, recovered, finished — the true line, the line they'd worked back to from the trench. And in Rowan Leigh's two hands was a fistful of chalk that some person had packed, by feel, in the dark of the ground, along a line that ran out from under the figure and off the edge of every survey in the tent — to where, nobody in that nylon room could say.

Petra had stopped moving. The Lens, at last, took the shot.

And Edie Vane unfolded her arms. She looked at the lump in Leigh's hands, and then — only then, for one quarter of a second — she looked at Frik, and something passed between them that had no words because Frik did not need words and Edie, just now, did not have any she was willing to spend.

She still said nothing.

But she'd seen where the line went. Saul would have bet the van on it. She'd looked at that fragment and read it the way none of them could yet, the way only someone whose family had packed those trenches by hand could read a thing packed by hand — and whatever she knew, she was keeping, in the blue light, with the screens going on certainly behind her, the amber Horse insisting it had the answer.

The generator hummed.

The pink gaps glowed.

And under the whole tent, under the model and the mesh and the recovered line, a piece of older chalk said: *not here. Somewhere else. Somebody knew. Ask her.*

Chapter 11 — Fragments and Evidence

The pit was a clean rectangle the size of a coffin, cut into the slope just below the Horse's neck, and Dr. Rowan Leigh stood at its edge with the patience of a man who knows the photographs will be worth waiting for.

I had the long lens up before I told myself to. Old habit. You see a man arrange a body of evidence the way you'd arrange a body, and the camera comes up on its own. Through the glass his face was unguarded — not gloating, nothing so cheap. Reverent. He held a thing in two cupped hands the way you'd hold a bird that had flown into a window, and the morning sun caught the chalk dust on his sleeves and made him glow a little, which is the kind of luck a man like that always seems to have.

"Found in situ," he was saying to the half-circle of locals he'd gathered. "Sealed beneath the turf line, here —" a gloved finger at the pit wall, where the soil went from brown to a pale band like the cream at the top of unhomogenised milk. "Original packing chalk. Crushed, deliberately, you can see the working. This is the hand of the people who first cut the figure."

He let that land. He was good. The phrase *the hand of the people who first cut the figure* went round the half-circle and you could watch it take. A woman in a green council fleece touched her own mouth. An older man — Brindle, I'd learned, sheep up at the Manger end, hands like split firewood — folded his arms and didn't.

Frik was beside me, watching the watchers, which is what Frik does. He wasn't looking at the fragment at all. He was reading the half-

circle: who leaned in, who leaned back, where the line of the split ran through them like the line of brown to white in the pit wall. He tapped my forearm twice — *look* — and tipped his chin at Brindle, then at the green-fleece woman, then drew his finger flat through the air between them. A seam. I nodded. I'd seen seams open in places where people stood close and called each other neighbour. They don't close again easy.

The official story is true, and it is a beautiful thing, and I want to put it down straight before I put anything crooked beside it.

A long time ago — Palmer and Miles, Oxford Archaeological Unit, the dig after the dig, the quartz grains in the buried chalk read by light, optically stimulated luminescence, the numbers landing somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC — people came up this hill and dug. Not scratches. Trenches a metre down, packed with broken chalk, an engineering decision and not a decorative one, because chalk in a trench resists the slow downhill crawl of soil and keeps a line sharp where a surface mark would smear away in a season. They cut a horse — or a thing we call a horse — a hundred and ten metres of it, all flowing leg and beaked head, and they cut it so it could not be read from the hill above, only from the valley floor, or from the air, from a vantage no one in 1000 BC was ever going to occupy.

So Rowan Leigh's fragment was, in all likelihood, exactly what he said it was. The hand of the people who first cut the figure. He wasn't lying. That's the part I keep needing to say out loud, because it would be so much easier if he were.

"And this," he said, "is what we propose to honour. Not to invent. To recover. The original line, the original depth, the original intent —"

That word again. *Original*. It kept arriving like a man arriving at a party he's been told is in his honour.

Marsh — the autistic one of us, the one who carries timelines behind his eyes the way other people carry a tune — had crouched at the far corner of the pit and gone very still over the soil profile. He hadn't said anything in eleven minutes. I'd timed it without meaning to. He reached out and did not touch the cut wall, held his hand a centimetre off it, tracking the cream band with a fingertip in the air.

"That's not one line," he said. Not loud. He never is.

Leigh turned, warm and open. “Sorry?”

“The chalk band. It’s not one episode. It’s —” Marsh leaned, counted something only he could see. “Three. At least three. Lensed. Each one cuts the last. You’ve got a repacking horizon, then another, then another.”

A pause you could’ve parked a Land Rover in.

“Quite,” said Leigh, recovering smoothly. “Centuries of re-chalking. The maintenance tradition. We don’t dispute it — we celebrate it. But the lowest band, the foundation, that’s the line we’d restore *to*. The truest line.”

Marsh blinked at him. “Truest by what.”

“By age.”

“That’s not the same thing as true,” said Marsh, and went back to the wall, finished with him.

I got the frame I wanted then: Leigh, mid-sentence, his hands still cupped around three thousand years of crushed stone, and behind him, out of focus, the Horse itself — that white sweep across the green — and the thing about the Horse is it has never once held still long enough to be *original*. It is the most edited object in England. Every scouring is a redraft. The leg that runs today is not the leg that ran when Alfred was a name people argued about; the beak of the head has migrated, the eye has drifted, the whole creature is a palimpsest of every pair of hands that ever knelt on it with a bucket. There is no first line still visible up there. There is only the last line, kept.

That’s the potato, and you don’t feel it standing in the valley with a guidebook. You feel it the day you try to keep a shape alive on a hill that is alive itself.

Because here’s the thing they don’t put on the interpretation board. Leave the Horse alone — just leave it, no buckets, no kneeling, no festival — and in roughly twenty years the grass takes it. Not centuries. Twenty years. One held breath of human inattention and the hillside swallows a hundred and ten metres of bright animal whole. The chalk yellows, the turf creeps in from the trench edges, the legs blur, the eye fills, and then one summer a child on the valley road looks up

and there's nothing there but down. They turfed it over themselves in the war so the German bombers couldn't navigate by it, and it took men with mattocks afterward to give it back its outline. That's how thin the line is between *here* and *gone*. Twenty years. A mortgage. A dog's whole life.

So the official story isn't *they made a horse*. The official story is *they made a horse and then a hundred generations agreed, without a single recorded vote, never to let it die*. And the science is iron on the first half and silent on the second, because there is no quartz grain you can shine a light at to prove the chain never broke. The survival of the figure is the only evidence we have that the hands never stopped. The Horse is its own dating method. It's there, therefore someone was always coming back. That's not a proof. That's a faith with a measurable outline.

Leigh had moved on to drones. There was a tablet now, a digital model of the Horse rotating in glorious bloodless perfection, every curve smoothed to its "intended" geometry, the line so crisp it looked extruded. The green-fleece woman was nodding. So were two others. The model was easy to love. It was the Horse with all the centuries sanded off it, the Horse as a logo, and a logo is a thing you can put on a leaflet and a leaflet is a thing that brings coaches and coaches bring the money that — Leigh was very honest about this, give him that — would *pay for the restoration*. Save the Horse by fixing it. Fix it by deciding which of three thousand years of hands was right.

Then Edie Vane spoke, and the half-circle turned, because of course it did.

She'd come up quiet, the way she does, with a flask and that flat cap and chalk already worked into the lines of her knuckles though we hadn't started the real scouring yet. She didn't look at Leigh. She looked into the pit, down at the three banded lensings Marsh had counted, and she was quiet long enough that even Leigh waited.

"My nan packed one of them," she said.

Nobody asked which. She nodded at the wall like she could read it the way Marsh read it, except she wasn't reading it. She was *remembering* it.

"Not the bottom one. I shan't pretend. But one of them up nearer

the turf. 1949, would've been, the year after they un-turfed her. Nan was a girl. Said the chalk that year come from Dragon Hill quarry and it was the wrong white, too blue, and the old fellows grumbled it'd never bed right." She straightened. "It bedded right."

Leigh, gently: "And that's precisely the heritage we want to —"

"You want the bottom line," Edie said. Still not unkind. That was the worst of it, how not-unkind she stayed. "You found a bit of the first lot and now the rest of us are amateurs. My nan's chalk's just *wear*, to you. Just the muddle that got in the way of the true thing."

"That's not —"

"It's exactly that." She turned the flask cap in her fingers. "You'd scrape us out to find them. You don't even know it's what you're saying, son, but it's what you're saying. The Horse you'd give back wouldn't have a single one of us in it."

Here is the hole, and I want it cold and exact, because the affection is the easy part and the cold part is where the trouble lives.

The fragment is real. The OSL is real. The metre-deep trenches are real, measurable, you can stand in one. And the band of chalk Leigh held in his cupped hands genuinely was, in all likelihood, from the earliest packing — the first hands. He had, in the strict sense, found *evidence*. The unanswerable part isn't whether the fragment is old. It's the thing it cannot, by its nature, contain: the next pair of hands, and the next, the unbroken come-again, the agreement to return that has no artefact because an *agreement to keep doing a thing* leaves no quartz to date. The chain Leigh wanted to restore *past* is the only reason there was anything for him to find. You cannot dig down to the first line without going through every line that kept it alive. The foundation chalk and the maintenance chalk are not two things, one true and one muddle. They are the same thing happening over and over. The fragment proves the Horse was *started*. Nothing in that pit, nothing under any turf, can prove or disprove what actually carried it here — which is that someone kept showing up.

So which is the real Horse. The line in the bottom band, three thousand years asleep? Or the line up top, the one Edie's nan packed with the wrong blue chalk that bedded right anyway?

I'm not going to tell you. I don't think anyone in that field could've,

and the ones who'd lived it longest were the surest they couldn't.

The split ran where Frik had drawn it. Brindle stepped to Edie's shoulder and a couple of the older scourers closed in behind, and that was one country. Green-fleece and the council people and two or three of the younger ones drifted toward Leigh's rotating tablet, the clean Horse, the fundable Horse, and that was another. And the seam between them ran right through families who'd carried chalk up this hill together for longer than anyone could write down.

"There's a coach company already interested," somebody said, on Leigh's side, not unreasonably, because the village hall roof leaks and the school's down to one minibus.

"There's a *Horse* already up there," said Brindle, "and she's not for sale by the metre."

Leigh raised both hands — the fragment was bagged now, sealed, evidence — and his voice stayed warm and that was somehow the thing that tightened the air. "Nobody's selling anything. I'm asking us to save her properly, with the science we finally have, before another generation of well-meaning wear blurs the only original we'll ever —"

"Wear," said Edie.

The word sat there.

"It's what scouring *is*," she said. "It's all scouring ever was. You're stood in the hole you dug to prove our care was the problem."

Above us the wind came over the lip of the hillfort and ran down the slope, and the long grass at the trench edges of the Horse leaned all one way, the way grass does just before it decides to come in and take what it's owed. The festival was three days off. The real scouring — the buckets, the kneeling, the whole village on its knees in the white — was meant to start at dawn. Half the village was now standing in a field deciding whether the other half were vandals or thieves.

Marsh stood up from the pit corner and brushed his palms, and there was chalk on them now, three thousand years of it, no way to tell the bottom band from the top by the dust on a man's hand.

"It's going to rain," he said, to no one, watching the western sky go the colour of a healing bruise. "Tomorrow. Hard. By tomorrow night."

And nobody up on that hill was kneeling yet.

Chapter 12 — Storm on the Downs

The first I knew of it was the sheep.

You learn things, hanging around a hill long enough, and one of them is that sheep are barometers with legs. All afternoon they'd been scattered easy across the lower slope, grazing the way sheep graze, like they've got nowhere to be and resent you for suggesting otherwise. Then — and I clocked the exact second, because I'd been filming them for B-roll nobody would ever use — they all looked up at once. Every woolly head swung southwest. Then they started moving uphill, fast, in a long pale river toward the lee of the rampart.

“Hey,” I said, to no one, because the others were strung out along the trench-line forty metres off and Frik can't hear me anyway and the Lens had her back to me, doing the thing she does where she becomes furniture so the world forgets to perform for her. “Hey. The sheep know something.”

Southwest, the sky had gone the colour of a bruise three days old. Not black. Worse than black — that yellow-green underbelly that means the weather's not coming, it's already decided, it's just choosing its moment. The wind that had been faffing about in the grass all day stopped faffing. It put its shoulder into the hill.

I should explain what we were standing in, because it matters for what happened next.

You hear “white horse” and you picture paint. A nice clean outline somebody touches up with a brush. The Uffington Horse is not paint. The Uffington Horse is *trenches* — proper ones, cut down about a

metre into the chalk bedrock, packed solid with crushed white rubble, the whole 110-metre run of it. That depth isn't decoration. That's the engineering that keeps the thing alive. On a slope like this, the topsoil doesn't sit still; it creeps, it slides, it migrates downhill a few millimetres a year like it's got somewhere better to be. A shallow figure would've been smeared into a ghost inside a lifetime. A metre-deep trench holds its line against the whole patient violence of the hillside. Somebody three thousand years ago understood soil creep well enough to beat it. Sit with that one a second.

But "holds its line" doesn't mean "self-cleaning." The trenches catch grass. They catch washed-down silt. Leave it twenty years and the green just walks back in and takes the white, and the most-looked-at animal in Bronze Age Britain becomes a faint suggestion in the turf that ramblers argue about. The whole reason there's a festival, the whole reason any of us were up there, is that the white has to be *fed*. Crushed chalk, by the bucket, by the hand, packed back into the lines. That's the scouring. That's the doing.

And right now half the leg of the Horse was open.

That's how the scour works — you don't strip the whole figure at once and leave it naked to the sky. You work it in sections. Edie's lot had the near hindquarter and the long back leg unpacked, the old grass and tired chalk lifted out, the fresh chalk staged in trugs along the edge ready to go down the next morning when the light was good and the hands were fresh. An open trench is a hungry trench. An open trench in a storm is a drain.

The first drops hit like thrown gravel.

"EDIE." That was a scourer I didn't know, a big man with forearms like rolled brisket, and he wasn't asking a question, he was sounding an alarm. "Edie, the leg's open —"

"I know what's open." She came up the slope already moving, and I want to be honest about something, because the easy version of this scene is the calm wise local who's seen it all. That's not what I saw. I saw a teacher who'd done a hundred fire drills and was now in an actual fire, and the difference showed in her hands. They were going before her mouth caught up. "Tarps. The blue ones, by the gate, Dav's trailer. Now. Anyone not carrying chalk's carrying water away from that leg."

I did the thing I do. I'm not built for the slow read — that's Frik, that's our pattern-spotter who can stare at a hillside for an hour and tell you the drainage of three thousand years. I'm built for *now*, for the next ninety seconds, for what's loose and where it goes. My brain in a crisis isn't a calm river, it's a pinball machine, and the trick I've learned is to stop fighting that and just *aim the ball*.

Drainage. That was the ball. Water comes off this hill the way water has always come off this hill, and the open trench was sitting square in a line that wanted to become a stream.

"The trug — the chalk in the trugs —" I grabbed the nearest scourer's sleeve, a woman in a wax jacket already silvering with rain. "If that fills with water it's not chalk, it's soup, it'll wash out the bottom of the trench, we have to get it *uphill* of the line, not next to it —"

She looked at me for half a second the way locals look at the festival blow-ins who suddenly have opinions. Then she looked at the trug. Then she looked at the water already starting to find its path down the open leg, braiding into the loose chalk, lifting it, beginning — right in front of us — to *carry it away*, a thin white thread of three-thousand-year-old maintenance dissolving into the runoff.

"Boy's right," she said. "Up. Get it up."

We got it up. Trug after trug, hauled uphill of the open trench, while the rain went from gravel to needles to a solid grey weight that came at the hill almost sideways. The chalk dust that had been on everyone's hands all day turned to a paste, and the paste turned to a slurry, and the hill that had been firm green turf at four o'clock became, by full dark, a thing that grabbed your boots and didn't want them back.

Frik found me by the elbow. He doesn't shout, obviously, but he has a way of *arriving* in your peripheral vision that's louder than shouting. He pointed: down at the leg, then up at the rampart, then he made a shape with his two flat hands — a roof, a tilt, water running off — and then he jabbed back at the trench, urgent, *no*. Then he flipped his hands the other way: water running *in*.

It took me a beat. The Lens got there first; she'd been crouched in the muck with the camera, because of course she had, because that's the camera the whole thing keeps asking her to put down and she never will, and she lowered it just enough to follow Frik's hands.

“He’s saying the tarp’s wrong,” she said. Flat, certain. “Look where they’ve pegged it.”

They’d thrown the first blue tarp over the open leg like you’d cover a woodpile — pegged on the *downhill* side, sagging in the middle. Which meant every litre that hit it ran straight down into the open trench. They were funnelling the storm into the wound.

Frik wasn’t reading the weather. None of us were, really, not the way he was. He’d spent the whole day watching *hands* — whose chalk went where, who deferred to whom, the silent grammar of a scour none of us could’ve written down — and now he was reading the tarp the same way, reading the *care* in it and finding it pointed the wrong direction. He didn’t have the word for hydraulics. He had the eye for it. Same eye.

“EDIE.” Now I was the one not asking a question. I waved her over and pointed and let Frik do it again with his hands, the roof, the tilt, the *wrong way*, and Edie — and this is the part I keep coming back to — Edie didn’t argue and didn’t explain. She watched Frik’s hands for the length of one breath and then she was already at the tarp.

“Off it. *Off it*. We’re pegging it high side, we’re shedding it onto the grass, not into the line —” and the big brisket-forearmed man and the wax-jacket woman and a teenager I hadn’t even seen arrive were all on it, ripping pegs, re-setting them on the uphill lip so the blue plastic became a ramp instead of a funnel, and the storm-water that had been pouring into the open leg now ran off the high side and away down the slope where it could do its three-thousand-year thing without taking the Horse with it.

I stood in the dark and the noise and watched a Bronze Age problem get solved by a Deaf man’s hands and an Iron Age festival’s tarpaulins and I had one of those moments where the pinball stops bouncing for a second and just hangs in the air.

Because here’s the thing they don’t tell you in the brochure. The official story — the one that’s *true*, the one with OSL dates pinning the figure to somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC, the one with the metre-deep trenches you can measure with a tape today — the official story makes it sound *solved*. Bronze Age people made a clever thing, the cleverness keeps it sharp, the end. And it is clever. It’s genuinely, soberingly clever.

But clever doesn't survive a Tuesday like this one. Engineering buys you the *structure*. It doesn't buy you the bodies on the hill at ten at night in horizontal rain deciding the Horse is worth getting cold for. The trench holds the line. *People* hold the trench. And somewhere out there in the dark, three thousand years of those people had made exactly this call, on exactly this slope, in exactly this kind of weather, and the figure was still here because every single time, somebody had said: not tonight, you don't.

Nobody up there could've told you what the Horse *means*. They'd lost that. Lost it so long ago that by the Middle Ages the locals had already decided it was a dragon and made up stories about it galloping off to Wayland's barrow at night. The meaning's been gone for the better part of a millennium and probably much longer. And every seven or ten years, for as long as anyone can reckon back and then well past where reckoning gives out, these people have hauled chalk up this hill and packed it into trenches for a horse they call a dragon for a reason nobody remembers.

You want the hole? That's the hole. Not how it was built — we know that, more or less. The hole is *why it was never let go*. Empire came and went. Plague came and went. There was a literal world war where they turfed the whole thing over so German bombers couldn't navigate by it, and then the second the war was done somebody dug it back out, because of course they did, because the alternative was unthinkable, even to people who couldn't tell you what they were saving or what it was for. You can chart the OSL dates. You can measure the trench. You cannot measure the part of a community that decides, generation after generation, with no living memory of the reason, that the white must not fade.

I'm not going to pretend I cracked it standing in that rain. I didn't. Nobody did. That's not the kind of thing that cracks.

We got the leg covered. We got the chalk staged uphill and dry under the second tarp. The storm did what storms do, which is rage like it'll never stop and then, around midnight, just — get bored. The wind dropped off the hill and went to bother somebody else. The rain thinned to that fine Berkshire drizzle that feels like the sky apologising. And we all stood there, twenty-odd of us, plastered in slurry, lit by the headlamps and the one work-light Dav had rigged off his trailer battery, looking at a half-scoured Horse that had not, in fact, washed

off the hill tonight.

Edie did a slow count of her people. Touched a shoulder, said a name, the way you do. Then she looked at the open leg — the leg that still needed packing, the fresh chalk that still needed to go down by hand, line by line, the whole job that the storm had interrupted and not finished — and she looked at the sky, which had a thin bruise of paler grey low in the east that meant the night had a bottom to it after all.

“Light’s in four hours,” she said. To everyone. To no one. “Can’t pack chalk in the wet. It’ll set wrong, slump out the first frost. We wait for it to drain, then we go. Soon as we can see our hands.”

“That’s dawn,” somebody said.

“That’s dawn,” she agreed.

And I looked at Frik, who was already looking at me, rain running off his nose, and he raised his eyebrows in that way that’s a whole sentence, and I looked at the Lens, who had finally — *finally* — let the camera hang and was just standing in it, in the actual weather, a person and not a lens, and I looked at our pattern-spotter, who’d gone quiet the way he goes quiet when a thing’s too big to narrate, and our ND lead’s hands and the Lens’s lowered camera and the cold and the chalk and the whole impossible inherited *doing* of it.

Nobody put it to a vote. That’s not how it works with us. I just stepped forward, into the light, where Edie could see me, and I held up my two grey-white hands — Bronze Age coloured, festival coloured, the colour of every hand that’s ever done this — and I made the shape Frik had made for the tarp, except I turned it the right way up. Chalk going *in*. The line being fed.

“We’re staying,” I said. “Tell us where the buckets go.”

Chapter 13 — The Night Scouring

The first Frik knew of the storm was the grass laying flat.

He was kneeling in the eye of the Horse — the round socket of chalk where, by old custom, you stood for a wish — and he felt the hillside change under his knees before he heard a thing, which of course he never would. The turf along the upper slope went over all at once, like a hand passing over a dog's fur the wrong way. Then the rain arrived sideways and the light went the colour of a bruise, and Edie Vane was already up the slope with her coat half on, shouting something he caught only in the shape of her mouth: *trenches*.

He'd watched her mouth for three weeks now. He knew that word.

Here is the thing the brochures get right, and you should let them have it, because it is true and it is hard-won. The White Horse is not paint. It is not a stain on the grass that you brighten with a roller every few summers. It is a piece of engineering roughly three thousand years old, and the engineering is this: somebody in the Late Bronze Age — OSL dating of the buried quartz puts the cutting somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC, which is the kind of date that makes a person quiet — dug trenches into the chalk a full metre deep, and packed them with crushed white rock. A metre. Not a scratch. A wound in the hill that goes down past the topsoil, past the soft brown, into the bone of the Downs. They did it that deep on purpose. Soil creeps. A shallow line slumps and blurs in a season. A metre of packed chalk holds its edge against the slow downhill ooze of a living hillside, and that is why the lines are still sharp enough, after a hundred generations, to read a galloping animal from the valley floor.

That is the official story. It is correct. It is also the trap, and the storm was about to show them the trap.

Because a metre of chalk only holds if the chalk is *there*. And on a slope this steep, in rain this hard, an open trench mid-scour — half re-packed, the old white dug out and the new not yet beaten down — is just a channel. A gutter cut straight down the face of the hill. The rain found the trenches the way water finds anything you have kindly dug for it, and it began to take the chalk away.

Frik got to the foreleg and saw it going. The new chalk they'd carried up in rubble sacks all day, crushed to a paste, was lifting and running. White water sheeting off the leg and into the grass, the leg's edge softening even as he watched, the sharp line they'd cut that afternoon dissolving back toward the blur it had taken a day to fight out of.

This is the potato, he thought, in the wordless way he thought things — an image, a weight in the hands. People say: just keep it chalked. As if the hill were patient. As if you could come up here at your leisure with good intentions and a wheelbarrow. The hill is not patient. The hill is in the business, every single day, of taking the Horse back. Leave it twenty years and it is gone — overgrown, illegible, a green blank where an animal used to run. They have measured this. It is not a metaphor. The Horse survives because the taking-back has been *answered*, in person, on knees, in weather, for three thousand years, by people who showed up.

And tonight the hill was collecting in one night what it usually had to steal over a decade.

He turned to find the others and the LENS was already there, no camera up, hood streaming, hauling a chalk sack against her chest like a child being carried out of a fire. She dumped it at his feet and pointed down at the running leg and made a fist and pressed it into her palm. *Pack it. Hold it down.* He nodded. Behind her the kinetic one — the ADHD one, who all week had been the crew's open hand, the one the scourers warmed to first — was running, actually running, down the line of the back toward the village families who'd come up for the festival and were now milling at the top in the dark, useless and willing and waiting to be told.

Eddie told them.

He couldn't hear what. He watched her do it. She didn't make a speech — there wasn't a speech in her, and there wasn't time, and that was the whole education of the thing right there. She grabbed a boy of maybe sixteen by the shoulder, put a wooden beater in his hands — a flat mallet, hand-cut, dark with the grease of other hands — and walked him bodily to the hind hoof and showed him: scoop, pack, beat. *Not here is the heritage. Not here is what it means.* Scoop. Pack. Beat. The boy did it wrong, packing too loose, and she put her hands over his hands and did it through him until his arms knew it, and then she left him and went to the next pair of hands.

This is how it is carried. Frik had been trying to film the *meaning* of the scouring for three weeks and the meaning had kept sliding off the frame, and here in the storm he finally caught what the LENS had been telling him with her eyebrows since day one: there is no meaning to film. There is a doing. The doing is the inheritance. You cannot photograph an unbroken chain — the chain is inferred, it is not documented, nobody has the receipts going back to the Bronze Age and Edie would be the first to tell you so. What you can photograph is one woman in a storm putting a mallet into a boy's hands the way someone once put it into hers, and the boy not knowing why, and doing it anyway.

He got down to the chalk.

The headlamps came on around him one by one as full dark dropped, and the hill turned into a thing he would never forget: a scatter of small white cones of light along the lines of an animal, each cone bent down over a pair of working hands, and between them the dark and the rain and the great invisible bulk of the Horse you could only feel, never see — because you cannot see it from up here, that's the oldest joke of the place, you who keep it can never stand back and behold it. Only the valley sees it. Only the sky. You labour your whole life on a face you've never once looked in the eye.

The chalk under his hands was the temperature of a held breath. He scooped the slurry from the run-off, where it had pooled at the lower lip of the trench, and lifted it back up to the high edge and pressed it home, leaning his whole weight in, then beating it with the flat of his palm because he hadn't grabbed a mallet and there wasn't one spare. The rain hit the back of his neck and went down inside his coat in a cold line. Beside him a woman he didn't know — older, a farmer's face,

the festival's lost cause now turned to this — worked the same trench from the other side, and they met in the middle and packed against each other's pressure so the new chalk set firm between them, and she looked up at him through the rain and her face did something. Not a smile. An acknowledgement. The face people make when the work is going right and the only thing to say about it would spoil it.

He nodded back. They went on.

Time did the thing it does on a hill at night with your hands full. It pooled and ran like the chalk. He was aware of the autistic one — the pattern-reader, the one who'd spent the week walking the whole figure end to end muttering about sightlines and slope gradients — somewhere up by the head, and aware that he had stopped reading the landscape and started *managing* it: directing sacks to where the slope was steepest, where the water moved fastest, where the trench would empty first if it emptied. He'd seen the storm as a system and found its drains and posted people at them. That was his sight too. Nobody told him to. He'd been watching the room his whole life and the hill was just the largest room he'd ever been in.

Edie found Frikk somewhere in the deep of it, at the curve where fore-leg becomes chest. She knelt beside him in the running dark and worked alongside him for a while without trying to talk, which he understood as the highest thing she'd offered him yet. Then she tapped his arm and pointed, with a chalk-grey finger, down the line of the leg to where the new packing held firm and white against the black water trying to take it — held, was *holding*, the edge sharp again where an hour ago it had been dissolving.

She made a small sign. Not BSL — she didn't have it — but a sign anyway, the universal one, a flat hand laid calm on the chalk. *It stays*.

He found, to his surprise, that his eyes were stinging and it was not the rain.

Because here is the hole the storm dug open, the one the tidy version never fills. The skeptics are right about nearly everything. The dragon is a medieval invention. The folklore is a patchwork. Hughes wrote the festival down in 1859 and even then half the songs were nonsense and the reason was already gone, already replaced by cheese-rolling and beer and the good clean fun of it. The original meaning of the Horse has been *lost for centuries* — lost so thoroughly that for a long

time everyone happily called it King Alfred's, or the Saxons', off by a thousand years and more, until the quartz set them straight. Nobody on this hill tonight knows what the Horse was for. Not Edie. Not her mother, who taught her the mallet. Not whoever taught her mother.

And yet. And yet. Across that lost meaning — across the loss itself, across plague years and an empire's rise and fall and the small turfing-over of the war, when they buried the whole animal in 1940 so German bombers couldn't navigate by it and then dug it carefully back up when the danger passed — across all of it, the *act* came through unbroken. Not the why. The why fell out the bottom centuries ago and the act kept walking without it. People keep showing up, in storms, on their knees, to maintain a shape whose purpose nobody can name, and they have done so for so long that the doing has become the only thing it is for.

The fish, riding in Frik's chest where the fish always rides, put it less reverently: *Three thousand years and not one of you stopped to ask for the manual. Mad lads. Absolutely no notes.*

He laughed. Out loud, alone in the rain, at the chest of a Bronze Age horse, packing chalk with strangers.

The night went on and the lights held the lines.

At some hour with no name the rain thinned, then quit, the way storms quit on the Downs — not slowly, just gone, leaving the hill ticking and dripping and the sky going from black to the faintest, filthiest pre-grey. Somewhere below, the valley was beginning to exist again. Frik sat back on his heels with his hands ruined and white to the wrist and looked along the foreleg, the chest, as much of the animal as a man on the slope is ever permitted to see, and it was *there*. Sharp. Held. The trenches packed and beaten and going nowhere. The hill had come for it in the night and the hill had not got it, because forty-odd people had stood between the hill and the Horse with mallets and bare hands and refused.

He looked around for the camera and found the LENS sitting back on the grass with hers in her lap, lens-cap on, not shooting. She caught him looking. She tipped her head toward the working scourers, the village families and the farmers and the boy with the mallet who'd got good at it sometime around midnight, all of them moving up the slope now toward the head in the grey light, finishing — and she lifted

her own muddy hand off the camera in a small, deliberate gesture. Setting it down. Not the moment to take. The moment to be in.

And Frik understood, the way you understand a thing in the body before the head catches up, who was *not* on the hill.

No drones. No digital model glowing on a tablet under a marquee. No clipboard, no historical-accuracy, no charming and genuinely-kind Rowan Leigh with her plans to fix the Horse into the shape of an idea of ancient Britain that could be put on a leaflet. The consultancy, who had measured the Horse to the millimetre and argued so well for saving it, had not come up the hill in the storm. They had not, perhaps, even known to. You do not get a phone tree for this. You get it because you are the kind of family that, when the sky goes over, finds yourself already half up the slope with your coat on, the way Edie had been.

The act could be measured. The act could be modelled. The act could not be *attended* by anyone who had not, somewhere back along an unbroken line nobody could prove, been handed the mallet.

Edie was at the head now, the rest of the scourers gathered loose around her in the dirty dawn, and she was looking back down the long white length of the animal at what the night had cost and what it had kept. Frik climbed up through the wet grass to stand among them, the LENS behind him, the pattern-reader coming in from the drains, the kinetic one filthy and grinning and silent for once.

Edie wiped chalk from her face with a chalkier hand, which did nothing, and looked at the crew, and looked at the Horse.

“Right then,” she said — he caught it on her mouth, clean as a bell in the new light. “You’ll want to know what all that was for.”

She didn’t say it yet. She held it, the way only the one who’s carried the chalk can hold it.

The valley below was just beginning to be able to see them.

Chapter 14 — Jakobus Reads the Hill

The storm had spent itself somewhere over the Vale in the small hours, and now the cloud was peeling back off the Downs in long grey sheets, the way wet paper lifts off a window. Soren had not slept. He'd stopped pretending to around three, when the wind changed its note and the canvas over the chalk-stack stopped drumming and started to hum, and he'd come up the slope to the lip of the hillfort to watch the light arrive.

It arrived the way it always did up here, which is to say from below. That was the first thing the hill taught you, if you let it. The sun did not crest the ridge and pour down. It came up out of the Vale, off the flooded fields and the silver thread of the brook, and it lit the underside of everything first — the bellies of the sheep, the underslung jaw of the chalk where the turf had been peeled back, the white running line of the Horse catching it before the green did.

Soren counted, because counting was how he held a thing steady. Eleven scourers still on the slope. Three asleep in the lee of the rampart under a tarp the colour of a traffic cone. Edie at the head of the trench with a kneeling-mat and a bucket, not working, just looking. And below her, lower down the figure than anyone, a man crouched on his heels at the very tail of the beast where it dissolved into a flourish, doing nothing at all.

Jakobus did nothing the way other men did heavy labour. With attention.

Soren watched him because Soren watched everything, and because there was a pattern here he hadn't named yet, and an unnamed pat-

tern was a stone in his shoe. He'd been watching the fixer all week — the way Jakobus arrived at a place sideways, the way he never once stood where the photograph wanted him, the way he asked the question that nobody else thought was a question. *What does it do.* Not what is it, not who made it, not what does it mean. What does it do.

So here was the official story, and Soren ran it through again because the running-through was a comfort, like a rosary for a man who counted instead of prayed.

Late Bronze Age. Earliest Iron Age. Optically stimulated luminescence on the buried quartz, the Oxford dig in the nineties, Palmer and Miles, a date that opened like a hand: **1380 to 550 BC.** Not Alfred. Not the Saxons. Older than the hillfort behind him by a margin that made the hillfort feel like a recent addition, a conservatory bolted onto a house. They had not painted a horse on a hill. They had *dug* it — trenches a full metre deep, the chalk crushed and packed in tight, and that depth was not decoration, that depth was engineering. A metre of packed chalk doesn't slump when the hillside breathes. The slope creeps; the figure holds. Whoever did this understood that a living hill is always trying, very slowly, to swallow what you put on it, and they built against the swallowing.

That was the part the consultancy loved, and Soren could see why. It was *clean*. It was a fact you could put on a board. Rowan Leigh had said it three nights running at the village hall, and she'd said it well, because she believed it: *we have the date, we have the engineering, we have a defensible original form, and we have an obligation to it.* She wasn't wrong about any single piece. That was the trouble with her. You couldn't fault the bricks. Only the house.

Because here was the potato, and the storm had served it up fresh.

Soren had spent the night watching what it took to keep a shape alive on a hill that wanted it dead. Not metaphor — labour. Wet chalk weighs. Wet chalk slides off a shovel and slumps off a bank and you pack it with your hands, with the heel of your palm, and the rain finds the new-packed line and tries to take it back the moment you turn away. Leave this hill alone and the grass has the Horse inside twenty years. Twenty. Not three thousand — twenty. A man could plant it and live to see it gone. The whole monument was a bet against entropy that had to be re-placed, by living hands, again and again and again,

a hundred times over, with no winnings except the right to make the bet once more.

And nobody up here, not one of the eleven, could tell you why.

That was the hole, and Soren turned it over and over because it would not lie flat. The *meaning* was gone. Long gone. Gone so thoroughly that by the Middle Ages they'd looked at the running line and called it a dragon, set it galloping to Wayland's Smithy at night, hung a wrong story on it the way you hang a coat on a peg in the dark and never notice it's not yours. The why had drained out of the thing centuries ago. And the doing had not so much as flickered.

How. That was all. Just — how. How does the *act* outlive the *reason*? How does a community hand down, unbroken, across empire and plague and a war so recent that men still living remembered turfing the Horse over so the bombers couldn't steer by it — hand down not a story, not a faith, not a meaning, but a *chore*. A maintenance schedule. Every seven years or so, somebody has to crush the chalk and pack the trench and keep the dragon from being eaten. And every seven years, for as long as there has been anyone to do it, somebody has.

Soren didn't have an answer. He was honest enough to know that the absence of an answer was the whole point, and disciplined enough not to fill it. The fringe filled it — that was what the fringe was *for*, filling holes with the nearest bright thing. He kept his hands off it. He just watched the man at the tail.

Jakobus had moved. Not up the slope, where the work was, but down — to the lowest curve of the figure, the place where the design stopped making sense if you stood inside it. He laid his palm flat on the packed chalk the way you'd lay a hand on the flank of a horse you didn't yet trust. Then he straightened, and walked out — not up, *out*, away from the hill and onto the apron of grass below the figure, twenty paces, forty, until he was standing where a man might have stood three thousand years ago to see if the thing he'd made looked right.

And Soren understood — felt the pattern click home with the small cold satisfaction of a tumbler falling — that this was the reading. This was Jakobus reading the made thing.

Because from the slope, from inside it, the Horse was nonsense. Soren had crawled the lines all week and from up close they were just trenches, abstract curves, a problem of chalk and gravity. You could not see the Horse from where you scoured the Horse. The makers had built a thing that could not be admired by the hands that made it. It was legible only from the valley floor, or from the air — from where nobody worked, from where you could only *receive* it. They had labour for the doers and meaning for the distant.

Jakobus stood at the receiving end and looked back up at the hill, and turned slowly, and looked at the Vale, and turned again, and looked at the long pale scar of the Ridgeway running off west toward the barrow, and Soren watched him doing the arithmetic that wasn't arithmetic, the thing the fixer did instead of theorising.

When Jakobus came back up the slope his boots were dark to the ankle and he stopped beside Soren without being asked and looked at the same Horse for a while, and said nothing, which was his way of inviting you to be the one to say it.

"You went down to the valley," Soren said.

"To where it's for." Jakobus had a voice like a gate that needed oil. "Built so you can't see it from the work. You ever build anything you couldn't see while you built it?"

Soren thought about it properly, because Jakobus asked questions you were meant to answer. "No."

"Hard." Jakobus said the word the way other men said *beautiful*. "Means they knew where it would be seen from before they cut a sod. Means somebody held the whole shape in his head while a dozen others dug blind." He nodded down the slope at the figure dissolving into its own flourish. "And it works as a *mark*. From the Vale. From the air. You're coming up the old road, the Ridgeway, you're coming for the Smithy or the fort or the water, and there's the Horse, and you know — without a word, without a soul to tell you — you know whose ground this is and that it's *kept*."

"Kept," Soren said.

"That's the tell." Jakobus crouched, and pressed two fingers into the new-packed line, testing it the way you'd test bread. "A ruin says *was*. This says *is*. No ruin is this white. White means somebody was

here last spring. The mark isn't the message. The *freshness* is the message. It says: there are still hands."

Soren felt the cold tumbler turn again, further this time. He had been so busy with the hole — how does the act survive the meaning — that he'd been treating the survival as the strange part. And Jakobus had walked down the hill and stood in the Vale and read the made thing the only honest way, from the function out, and the function was not *remembering*. The function had never been remembering. The function was *announcing the living*. The Horse didn't say *we were great*. It said *we are still here, and we still tend*. And a thing that says *we still tend* has to be re-tended to keep saying it, or it lapses into *we were here once*, which is a different and lonelier sentence.

The meaning could go. The meaning was always going to go — meanings are perishable, meanings are the soft tissue, the first thing the worms get. But the function didn't need the meaning. The function only needed hands. And so the hands kept coming, seven years on seven years, not to honour a story but because the story they were inside of *was the keeping*, and you cannot keep a thing by knowing why. You can only keep it by keeping it.

He didn't say any of that. Jakobus would have winced; the fixer hated a man who narrated his own footnotes. Soren just said, "It's a mark that has to be alive to mean anything."

"It's a mark that *is* the being-alive," Jakobus said, and stood, his knees telling the cold, and that was the closest he came to a flourish. "Not for me to say more. Ask her." He tipped his chin up the slope.

Edie had stopped looking at the Vale.

She was looking at them. At Soren, specifically — at the back of his head, the way you watch someone do a sum they don't know they're doing out loud. And when Soren turned and met her eye, something passed over her face that wasn't quite a smile, because Edie's affection ran too deep for anything so cheap as a smile at six in the morning after a night of wet chalk. It was recognition. The face you make when a stranger pronounces a word the way the locals do, and you realise they've stopped pretending and started belonging, a half-inch, just at the edge.

She'd seen it land. She'd been waiting all week to see if it would land

in any of them, and she'd watched the consultancy fail to land it with all their drones and their date-boards and their defensible original form, and she'd watched the crew get closer than she expected and stall, and now she had seen the pattern-spotter go quiet next to the road-worn man and come up the other side of the silence holding the thing. Not holding *her* thing — she kept that. The naming was hers; she could feel them all knowing it was hers, and not reaching for it, and that was the half-inch.

Across the Vale the last of the storm-cloud tore free of the western ridge and the full light came up off the flood-water all at once, and the whole figure went incandescent — not white, *radiant*, throwing the morning back at the sky it had been cut to be seen from. The new-packed chalk of the night's work was indistinguishable now from the old. You could not tell which line was three thousand years and which was three hours. That was the joke and the glory of it; that was the fish, surfacing to heckle, *go on then, clever lad, which bit's ancient?* And the honest answer was: all of it, and none of it, and that question is a category error, and isn't it lovely that you can't tell.

Frik came up the slope toward them with chalk dust whitening the creases of his hands to the wrist, and he saw Soren's face, and he saw Jakobus, and he saw Edie watching, and he read the whole conversation that hadn't been spoken — read it off the set of three people's shoulders the way other men read a sentence — and he grinned, and made a sign Soren didn't know, a flat hand sweeping low across the hill and then opening upward, and didn't trouble to translate it.

The storm was gone east. The grass steamed. The Horse ran on the bright hill exactly as white as it had been the morning before the rain, which is to say exactly as white as it had been for three thousand wet, swallowing, hand-tended years, and the only people who knew what it was for were the dead, and the only people keeping it had long since stopped needing to know.

Edie picked up her bucket.

"Right," she said, to all of them and none of them, in the voice you'd use to a sheepdog or a kettle. "Tail's not done. It never is."

And she went back down to the chalk.

Chapter 15 — The Consultancy Withdraws

The village green looked like the morning after a war it had won.

The Lens stood at the edge of it with the camera dead against her chest, not yet raised, taking the inventory she always took before she let herself shoot. A marquee had half-collapsed in the night, one pole down, the canvas slumped and pooled with rainwater that three teenagers were now sloshing off the roof with a broom handle. Bunting hung in wet ropes between the chestnuts. The cricket pavilion had a string of bulbs swinging from a single screw, blinking gamely, indifferent to the fact that nobody had told them the storm was over.

And it was over. That was the strange part. The light had that scrubbed quality you get after weather has thrown everything it owns at a place and run out — a low gold coming in sideways under the cloud-wrack, lighting the puddles so they looked deliberate, set out like coins. Steam was rising off the green where the sun touched it. Up the hill, above the village, you could see the chalk.

She could see the chalk.

The Horse ran clean across the slope, white against the deep storm-green, the lines fresh from the night's work — and the Lens, who had photographed things that had taught her not to use the word, found that the word she wanted was *alive*. The figure had not been there yesterday in this way. Yesterday it had been a patient, fading suggestion under turf, the way an old scar goes silver and almost-gone. Now it leapt. The crews had finished it in the dark, on their knees in the mud, packing crushed chalk into the trenches with the

rain coming sideways into their hoods.

She had not raised the camera then either. She'd carried buckets.

"Tea," said Mdisplay — the kinetic one, the ADHD one, whose actual name nobody used anymore — appearing at her elbow with two paper cups and the wired brightness of a man who has not slept and has decided sleep is for cowards. "It's terrible. It's from the urn that's been on since four. It's basically tannin and regret. Drink it."

She took it. It was terrible. She drank it.

"He's here," Mdisplay said, nodding across the green.

Dr. Rowan Leigh did not look like a man who had lost. That was the thing the Lens noticed first and filed, the way she filed everything — the face before the words. He looked rested, which meant he hadn't been on the hill, which meant nothing and everything. He was in a good coat. He had a folder. He had, beside him, the young archaeologist who'd found the buried chalk fragment, and she was carrying the laptop with the model on it, the beautiful one, the rendered Horse as the consultancy proposed to render it: crisp, symmetrical, *correct*, every curve resolved into the shape some software had decided a Bronze Age intention must have been.

It was a good model. The Lens would give them that. It was the kind of good that made you sad without being able to say why, like a restored photograph of someone you loved, where the scratch was gone and so was the year.

Edie Vane was already standing on the green when Leigh reached it. She had not been there a moment ago. The Lens had learned not to be surprised by this — Edie arrived the way weather did, by having always somehow been on its way. She had chalk to the elbows and chalk in the deep lines of her hands and a thermos under one arm, and she watched Leigh come with the particular patience of a woman who has been to a great many meetings and knows that the people who call them are rarely the people who do the work.

Leigh stopped a respectful distance off. He didn't open the folder.

"It looks magnificent," he said, and meant it, and was looking up at the hill when he said it, not at Edie, not at the camera, and that was

the first thing that told the Lens which way the morning was going to fall. "I've been up since dawn looking at it. I drove out to the valley road, where you see it whole." He shook his head slightly. "You finished it in *that*."

"We finished it in that," Edie agreed.

Frik had come up on the Lens's other side without sound, which was how Frik did everything, and his hands were already moving, low and quick, reading the scene to her in the shorthand they'd built between them over three weeks — *watch his shoulders, watch his hands, the young one's frightened*. The Lens looked at the young archaeologist. Frik was right. The girl was holding the laptop like it might be taken from her, or like she wished it would be.

"We came," Leigh said, "to save it. I want to be straight about that, because I think you've all decided we came to take it, and I'd like to leave with at least one of you believing otherwise." A small, tired smile. "We had the funding. We had the dating — Palmer and Miles, the OSL, the whole sequence, you've heard me on the OSL more than anyone should have to." He glanced at Mdisplay, who had quoted the dates back at him at a council meeting with the specific glee of a man who has memorised a thing purely to ruin someone's afternoon. "Fourteen hundred to five-fifty BC. Trenches a metre deep, packed with chalk, cut so the slope can't creep over it. That's not folklore. That's *engineering*. Somebody built this to last, and it has lasted, and my entire professional life is the conviction that what lasts deserves to be looked after properly."

"Nobody here disagrees with that," Edie said.

"No," Leigh said. "That's what I've finally understood. That's exactly the problem with me being here." He looked down at the folder, then handed it — not to Edie, but sideways, to the young archaeologist, as if he no longer wanted to be the one holding it. "I had a vision of looking after it *properly*. Cleaner lines. The geometry resolved. We did the survey — we could give you the Horse the way its makers must have first cut it, before three thousand years of human hands smeared it about."

"That's the bit," said Edie.

"That's the bit," Leigh said.

The Lens raised the camera. She did it slowly, the way she'd taught herself, the way the series kept asking her to do the opposite — to lower it, to be a person and not a lens — but this was a frame she would not get twice, and there is a difference, she had decided long ago, between stealing a moment and keeping one. She framed Leigh's hands, empty now, and behind them, soft and out of focus, the white shape on the green hill.

Here is the official story, and it is true, and it is the consultancy's to tell as well as anyone's: the Uffington White Horse is the oldest chalk hill-figure in Britain, and the only one we can date, and it does not survive by accident. Leave a chalk figure on a living hillside and the hill takes it back. Grass roots in. Soil creeps down. The white goes grey, then green, then gone — twenty years, give or take, and you'd never know it had been there. That is not a guess. There are hill-figures cut in living memory, by people who knew exactly what they were doing, who had budgets and committees and the best of intentions, and they have furred over and faded because the one ingredient is the one nobody can buy.

You have to keep coming back.

"The model's right," Leigh was saying, quiet now, almost to himself. "That's the maddening thing. If you wanted to know what the makers cut, three thousand years ago — the model's probably *right*." He looked up at the hill. "But the makers have been dead three thousand years. And every seven years or so, somebody who isn't them has come up that slope and put it back. Not *back to what it was*. Just — back. With their own hands, their own slightly-wrong eye for the curve of a leg." He breathed out. "I could give you the makers' Horse. I can't give you a hundred generations of the wrong hands, and that's — I've finally seen it — that's the only thing it actually is. The makers' lines have been gone for centuries. What's up there is the *scouring*. Not the Horse. The scouring."

Edie said nothing. The Lens, behind the camera, watched her not-say-it, which was its own kind of speech.

Because here was the hole, and the Lens had watched it open over three weeks, and it had not closed, and Leigh — to his enormous credit, to his ruin — had just stepped into it on his own two feet. The

OSL dates the *chalk*. It dates the burial of quartz grains, last sunlight, all that hard clean science. It tells you when. It does not tell you *how it kept going*. How a maintenance act — not a meaning, not a myth, just the bodily fact of people climbing a hill with chalk — transmits itself unbroken across the Romans coming and the Romans leaving, across plague carts and enclosure and a world war when they *turfed the thing over on purpose* so the bombers couldn't navigate by it, and then dug it back out the moment the bombers were gone. Nobody wrote down a rule that said: keep doing this. By the Middle Ages they'd already lost the *why* so thoroughly they thought it was a dragon. They kept scouring a dragon.

They kept scouring a thing they had the wrong name for.

How do you keep a habit alive longer than you keep its reason?

The fish, if the fish were here, would point out that “unbroken” is doing a lot of work for a chain nobody can actually document all the links of, and the fish would be *right*, and that is exactly why the word in the back matter is “inferred.” The chain is inferred from the simple, brutal arithmetic of survival: the Horse is here, the hill eats Horses in twenty years, ergo somebody never stopped. You can't prove a single year. You can only prove the result, standing white on the green slope, steaming in the after-storm light, while a funded and decent man stands on a village green and gives it back to the people who never let it go.

“So we're withdrawing,” Leigh said. He said it to Edie, finally, properly, his eyes on hers. “The proposal. The trial re-chalking, the digital programme, all of it. I'll square it with the council — that's mine to do, I made the pitch, I'll unmake it.” A wry flick of the mouth. “I'll keep the model. As a — cautionary thing. A picture of the Horse nobody's ever seen and nobody should.”

The young archaeologist closed the laptop. The little click of it carried across the wet green.

“You found a real thing,” Edie said to her — not to Leigh; to the girl. “Under the turf. That chalk fragment. That was a real thing and a good find and you should keep finding them.”

The girl looked up like someone unhooked.

“Just,” Edie said, “don’t ever think the old chalk is the Horse.” She turned and looked up the hill, and the Lens followed the look through the viewfinder, and for one moment all of them — the consultant, the archaeologist, the deaf face-reader, the kinetic one, the photographer who would not lower her camera — were looking at the same white shape for the same reason. “The old chalk’s just the first lot of hands. We’re the latest lot. That’s all any of it ever is. Hands, and the next hands.”

Frik signed something to the Lens, fast, and she lowered the camera to read it. *She didn’t thank him*, Frik signed. *Watch. She won’t.*

She didn’t. Edie Vane did not thank Rowan Leigh for withdrawing, and the Lens understood, in the way she understood things faster than she could explain them, that this was not coldness. You do not thank someone for stepping off your foot. The reserve in Edie was not triumph and it was not forgiveness. It was the patience of a woman who had known all along that the Horse would still be here when the funding moved on, because it had outlasted every funding there had ever been, every empire and every committee and every man with a folder and a good coat and a true thing he believed.

Leigh seemed to know it too. He didn’t wait to be thanked. He nodded — to Edie, to the crew, a small soldier’s nod — and turned, and walked back across the green toward the car park, and the young archaeologist went after him carrying the closed laptop with the perfect Horse asleep inside it.

Mdisplay let out a breath. “Well,” he said. “He was decent. I was all ready for him to be a *villain*. I’d worked up a whole thing.”

“He believed it,” the Lens said. “That was the trouble. He really wanted to save it.”

“Everybody wants to save it,” said the autistic one — Pell — who had been standing apart this whole time at the green’s edge, looking not at the people but at the hill, at the way the new lines caught the light, the rhythm of curve and gap, reading the figure the way he read everything, as a pattern that wanted finishing. “Nobody wants to *do* it. That’s the difference. Saving’s a noun. The Horse is a verb.”

Edie almost smiled at that. Almost. She unscrewed the thermos and

poured something dark and steaming into the cup and handed it, without comment, to Pell, who was the one of them who'd worked the trenches longest in the night, who'd packed chalk with his bare hands for six hours and not spoken once.

Across the green, the broom-handle teenagers had got the marquee roof emptied and were hauling the fallen pole upright, three of them on a guy-rope, slipping in the mud, shrieking with laughter. Someone had got the urn going again. A woman was unboxing what looked like four hundred sausage rolls. A man with a fiddle was tuning it under the dripping chestnuts, badly, hopefully. The bunting still hung wet, but somebody had begun to wring it out, handful by handful, and rehang it.

The festival was coming back. Not the spectacle the consultancy had pitched — the lights, the heritage-trail signage, the visitor numbers, the Horse as a thing to come and see. That had walked off to the car park. What was coming back was smaller and older and harder to photograph: the cheese stall, the fiddle, the cricket teas, the children who would be brought up the hill later to put their own small wrong hands to the chalk so that in fifty years they could bring their own.

The Lens raised the camera one last time. She found the fiddler in the frame, and the wet bunting, and the upright marquee, and — past them, soft, up the hill — the white shape, fresh-cut, steaming, anonymous, three thousand years old and one night young.

She did not lower it this time. She let it run.

Up there, the Horse ran across the chalk, going nowhere, going everywhere, kept by hands that had long forgotten its name and never once forgotten its body. Nobody on the green knew what it had been for. Every one of them knew what they would do, the next time the grass came creeping in.

They would go up the hill. They would put it back.

Chapter 16 — The Last Chalk

The light came up the valley before the sun did. That was the thing nobody had told Frik — that on a clear morning the Vale of the White Horse fills with light from below, the mist going pearl in the bottoms while the hill is still grey, so that for a long quarter-hour the world is lit from the wrong direction, ground to sky, and the Horse seems to hang in the air with no hill under it at all.

He was kneeling in the eye.

It was not a circle, the eye. He'd thought it would be, the way the postcards drew it — a tidy white disc. Up close it was a hollowed almond of packed chalk the size of a dustbin lid, and he had his palms flat in it, fingers spread, tamping the last of the crushed chalk into the trench-edge where the turf had been creeping. The chalk was cold and slightly wet from the night and it came up grey-white under his nails. It smelled of nothing he had a word for. Wet stone. The inside of a flowerpot. The back of his own throat.

He had not slept. None of them had.

Across the slope the others were strung out along the lines like beads — the kinetic one, Sam, away down the impossible long curve of the back where the figure stops being a horse and becomes a sentence written by a hand that thought differently about horses; and beyond him the autistic one, Theo, who had spent the storm hours not laying chalk but walking the trench-line on his knees with a torch, finding every place where the Bronze Age cut had been re-cut and re-cut until the edge of the trench was a stack of edges, three thousand years of edges, a contour map of every hand that had ever knelt where he

knelt. Theo had not said much. He had laid his palm flat on each old cut and moved on. That was Theo saying a great deal.

The LENS was up on the chalk above the ear with the camera down. Not lowered the way you lower a thing you're done with. Lowered the way you set down something you've decided to carry differently. She had it hanging off her shoulder, lens to her hip, and she was just looking at the valley filling with light, and Frik watched her watching it and thought: there. That's the one she didn't take. That's the picture she let go.

Edie came up the line.

She came the way the scourers all moved on the hill, which Frik had spent two weeks learning to read — not climbing, exactly, but addressing the slope sideways, weight low, one hand always loose and ready for the chalk the way another person keeps a hand near a banister. She had a wooden mallet hanging from her wrist by a loop of cord, worn pale where the cord went, and a canvas bucket, and the grey of the night was still on her face but under it something was coming up like the light in the valley.

She crouched at the edge of the eye, across from him. Looked at his packing. Put two fingers in, testing, the way you'd test a cake.

Then she did the thing he'd watched her do all night to forty different people without a word being possible between them: she made the small movement with her chin and her open hand that meant *good, leave it, it's set*. He'd learned it from her on the first night and it had gone through him like warm water, that she'd found it without being told, that she'd simply assumed there'd be a way and built one.

Good, he signed back. *Hard*. He showed her his hands, the chalk in the cracks of them, the deep ache across the heels of both palms.

She turned her own hands over. They were worse. They were a teacher's hands and a scourer's hands and they had been doing this since she was smaller than the schoolchildren who'd run the festival sack-race two days and a whole geological age ago. She didn't sign — she didn't have the vocabulary, not yet, she only had the bridge they'd built plank by plank over a fortnight — but she pointed at the cracked chalk in his palms and then pressed her own cracked palms together and held them up, and that was a sentence, and he had it

whole.

This is the cost. This is the only cost there is. You paid it. Now you're in.

Here is what the people who measure the Horse will tell you, and they are right, and you should let them be right, because they have earned it with theodolites and trowels.

The figure is one hundred and ten metres of stylised horse cut into the upper chalk of White Horse Hill below the ramparts of an Iron Age fort. In the 1990s the Oxford Archaeological Unit drove a section through the body and sent buried quartz to be read by light — optically stimulated luminescence, which counts the years a grain has spent in the dark since it last saw the sun — and the light came back and said: late Bronze Age. Somewhere between thirteen-eighty and five-fifty before the present era began counting. Older than the fort above it. Older than the word *horse* in any language now spoken on that hill. Old enough that when the Romans marched the Ridgeway behind the ramparts the Horse was already an antiquity to them, already a thing whose makers were gone.

And it is not painted on. This is the part the consultancy understood best and loved most and it was, in the end, the part that undid them. The Horse is not a stain on a hill. It is a piece of engineering. Trenches a full metre deep, cut into the slope and rammed with crushed chalk, and the depth is not decoration — the depth is *time*. A shallow figure slumps. The hill is alive; it creeps downhill a hair a year, soil flowing slow as cold honey, and a shallow mark would smear and drown in a generation. Twenty years, untended, and a chalk figure is a green ghost. The trench is the trick. The trench holds the line against the patience of the hill.

Cut it deep, and it will last as long as someone keeps the grass off it.

That is the whole catch. That is the potato, and it is the heaviest one in the book, and you can feel its weight in your forearms by four in the morning. Cut it deep, and it will last *as long as someone keeps the grass off it*.

Three thousand years. A hundred-odd generations. Each of them, without a single recorded total failure, deciding — through harvests

and plagues and the small ice ages of the medieval warm and the cold, through a Reformation and a civil war, through the year they turfed the whole thing over so the Luftwaffe couldn't navigate by it and then, the war won, came back and dug their grandfather's ghost out of the grass again — each generation deciding, *the Horse must not fade*, and going up the hill with mallets and buckets to make sure it didn't.

Knowing, the whole time, less and less of why.

By the Middle Ages they were already calling it a dragon. Already telling each other it galloped down to Wayland's Smithy in the dark to be re-shod. The meaning had already come loose and floated off like a kite cut from its string. But the string itself — the doing, the kneeling, the chalk in the cracks of the hands — that they kept. They forgot the reason and kept the act. They lost the word and kept the hands.

*Lads, three thousand years of people who'd forgotten
WHY and still showed up at dawn with a bucket. You
realise that's most marriages.*

The sun came over the eastern shoulder of the Vale and hit the head first.

It did not hit it gently. It came in flat and sudden the way it does in late summer, and the wet chalk Frik had just tamped flared white — not paper-white, not bone, a wet living grey-white that had a light *in* it, the way milk has a light in it — and the whole long impossible body of the Horse came up out of the grey hillside at once, head and beaked eye and the dotted line of the back and the strange running legs that don't run like legs, all of it leaping into being together as the sun took it, and somewhere down the line Sam made a sound that wasn't a word.

Frik felt it through his knees before he understood it. The slope had been silent — the particular silence of people too tired to speak — and then it was full of feet. Forty scourers and a film crew and an old woman with a mallet on her wrist, all of them stilled at once, all of them looking down the curve of the thing they had just hauled back out of the grass with their own hands.

You cannot see the Horse from up here. That is the joke at the centre of it, the joke that's lasted three millennia. From the hill above, the angle's wrong; the figure foreshortens into nonsense, a scatter of white marks with no shape, and you have to walk it on your knees to know it at all. It was built to be seen from the valley. From the air. From *out there*, by someone who is not on the hill — by the Vale, by the sky, by whatever the makers thought was looking up.

The people who keep it can never stand back far enough to see what they keep.

They keep it anyway. They keep it on faith and forearm and the word of their grandmother that the line goes *here*, not there.

Frik stood, because everyone was standing, and his knees screamed and he didn't care, and the LENS — he saw it out of the corner of his eye — the LENS lifted the camera. Just lifted it. And then, watching the slope full of stilled tired people looking down at a thing none of them could see, she lowered it again. Let that one go too.

He understood her then completely, the way you understand a face when the light finally hits it right.

Eddie was beside him. He hadn't felt her come.

She was looking down the line of the Horse with her chin up and her cracked hands loose at her sides and the mallet swinging gently off her wrist, and the new sun was on her face and on the chalk and on the whole streaming Vale below, mist burning off the bottoms now, the willows coming through, the little roads, the church tower at Uffington a grey nub among the green.

She'd been at the council meeting where the consultancy lost. She'd stood up — Frik had read every line of her face across that hall, the way her jaw set, the long even breath before — and she had not argued history with them. She had let them be right about history. She had let Dr Leigh be right about the OSL and the trench depth and the Bronze Age and all of it, generously, the way you let a guest be right at your own table. And then she had simply asked them who was going to come up the hill in seven years' time, after the grant ran out, after the drones were packed and the digital model archived, and put

their hands in the cold chalk. And there had been a silence in the hall the exact shape of the silence on the slope just now.

They'd withdrawn. Not beaten. Persuaded. Dr Leigh had come up the hill last night and worked the storm hours on her knees with the rest of them, laying chalk, learning the cost in her own forearms, and gone down again before dawn without making a speech, which was, Frik thought, the most honest thing she'd done. She'd wanted to save the Horse. She'd learned the Horse didn't need saving. It needed *doing*. There's a difference, and the difference is the whole book, and you cannot put it in a glass case.

Eddie turned to him.

There was chalk in the lines of her face where she'd pushed her hair back with a white hand. She looked at Frik, and then past him at Theo with his torch finally off and his palm still resting flat on the old cut edge, and at Sam halfway down the back of the Horse, and at the LENS with her camera hanging dead and her eyes wet and open, and she gathered all four of them into one slow look the way she'd gathered the chalk into the trench all night, with care, with a kind of attention that was itself the thing being passed down.

She didn't sign — still couldn't, not the long things. But she'd kept one back. He could see she'd kept one back, the way you keep one last good apple. She brought her two chalk-cracked hands up between them and made, slow and deliberate, the shape they'd built together on the first night for *ask* — the open hands turning out, offering — and then she pointed, one white finger, down the length of the running Horse, down to the eye Frik had just packed, the eye that looks out at a valley it cannot see itself reflected in.

And she held it there. The pointing finger and the open offering hands. The sun on the chalk. Forty scourers gone quiet behind her, and the whole Vale steaming gold below, and three thousand years of forgotten reasons under everyone's aching knees.

Ask it, she was saying. Now. While the light's right and the line is clear and your hands still have the cost in them. You've earned the question. You haven't earned the answer — nobody alive has earned the answer. But the question is yours now. Ask the Horse what it's for.

Frik looked down the white running length of it, at the beaked head pointed out across the Vale toward the rising light, toward whatever it had been cut, three thousand years ago, to watch for.

He raised his hands.

Chapter 17 — What Is It For?

Dawn came up grey and then gold, and the Horse lay finished on the hill.

Tarryn felt it before she saw it — the way the work-noise had drained out of the morning and left only sheep and wind and the small clicks of people setting down their tools. She'd been moving for eighteen hours, fetching, hauling, packing chalk into the eye with the heel of her hand because someone said the eye always wanted doing last, and now there was nothing to fetch. Her legs didn't know it yet. They kept wanting to go somewhere. She stood at the top of the beak-shaped head and made herself be still, which was the hardest thing she'd done all night and she'd carried a barrow up a forty-degree slope in the dark.

Below her the lines ran white into the green. Not crisp. That was the thing she kept coming back to. You'd think after a whole community knelt on a hillside for two days the result would be sharp, and it wasn't — it was soft at the edges, a little uncertain, the long sweep of the back dipping where the turf rolled and the legs splayed in that way that looked wrong from up here and right from down there. From up here you couldn't read it at all. You had to know it was a horse. You had to take it on faith and the word of everyone who'd ever stood in the valley.

The consultancy's drone was packed away in its foam case in a van in the car park. She'd watched Rowan Leigh carry it down herself, last night, before the rain, and Rowan had stopped halfway and looked back up at the hill with an expression Tarryn hadn't been able to

name and still couldn't.

"Hey," she said, to no one, to Frik, who was beside her. "Hey, it's done."

Frik wasn't watching the Horse. Frik was watching the people.

—

The official story, if you wanted it plain, was on a laminated board at the bottom of the hill, and it was a good board, and most of it was true. A stylised chalk figure, around a hundred and ten metres long, cut into the upper slope of White Horse Hill below the Iron Age ramparts of Uffington Castle. Dated by Optically Stimulated Luminescence — buried quartz, the last time the grains saw daylight, measured grain by grain by Palmer and Miles out of the Oxford Archaeological Unit after the dig that ran on from 1990 — to somewhere between roughly 1380 and 550 BC. Late Bronze Age into the earliest Iron Age. Which killed the old story about King Alfred cutting it to mark a battle, and killed the Saxon story too, and replaced both with a number so large it stopped meaning anything: three thousand years, give or take.

And it wasn't painted on. That was the part the board got across and most people skipped over on their way to the view. The makers had dug trenches a metre deep, near enough, and packed them with crushed white chalk, so the figure isn't a stain on the hill but a structure inside it — deep enough that the soil doesn't creep down and swallow it in a single wet winter. Deep enough to need digging out, every so often, by people who go down on their knees and lift the turf back and pound fresh chalk into the trench with a tool that looks like nothing so much as a flat-ended stick.

Every seven years, give or take. Sometimes ten. For three thousand years.

Skeptics will tell you, fairly, that the unbroken-chain part is inference. Nobody has a register. There's no continuous parish minute book running back to the Bronze Age, and you can't have one, and anyone who tells you the scouring has never once lapsed is selling something. What you can say is narrower and stranger: the Horse is still here. Leave a chalk figure on a living hillside and the grass takes it inside twenty years. There are figures on other hills that prove it — vanished ones, the white going green, a shape you can only find

now in old aerial photographs. The Uffington Horse did not vanish. So somebody, in every generation, in every one, through plague and enclosure and two world wars, agreed to come up the hill and keep it.

That's the official story, played straight, and it's marvellous, and it has a hole in it the size of the hill.

Because the official story can tell you *who* and *how* and very nearly *when*. It cannot tell you *why*. By the Middle Ages the locals had already lost it — they were calling the thing a dragon by then, telling each other it galloped over to Wayland's Smithy in the dark. The meaning had drained out centuries before anyone thought to write it down. The act stayed. The reason left. And nobody, kneeling on the chalk with a flat stick at four in the morning, can tell you what the first knees were *for*.

—

Owen had stopped pacing, which Tarryn registered as a kind of alarm. Owen never stopped pacing. He'd spent the festival walking the line of the figure end to end, counting, muttering, working out by eye where last year's scour ran shallow and this year's would need to bite. He'd found the join, he said. The place where the chalk changed colour because it had been packed at a different time. He could read the hill in stripes nobody else saw, the way he read everything, the timeline laid out flat and legible while the rest of them lived inside the muddle of it.

Now he was sitting on the rampart with his knees up and his hands quiet and he was looking at the same soft, uncertain lines Tarryn was looking at, and he said, not to her, "It doesn't make sense from up here."

"No," she said.

"It's not supposed to. You build it to be seen from down there. From the valley. From the air, except there wasn't any air." He turned his head. "So they built a thing they could never see finished. None of them. The whole time they were making it they were working on a shape that was only ever right somewhere they weren't standing."

The LENS was a little apart from them, camera down. The camera had been down most of the night, which the crew had stopped remarking

on and started understanding. There was a moment, near three, when the rain had come sideways and forty people had got down in the mud to shield the chalk with their backs, and the LENS had lifted the camera, framed it, and lowered it again, and just watched. Tarryn had seen that. She filed it where she filed the things she didn't have words for yet.

Edie Vane came up the slope toward them, last, the way she'd been first all weekend. There was chalk in the creases of her hands that wouldn't wash out till Tuesday. She'd taught half the people on this hill, in a classroom in the village, and she'd scoured this Horse since she was small enough to be lifted over the trench, and her mother had, and her mother's, back as far as the family went, which was the only chain anyone could honestly vouch for and it was long enough.

She stood with them and looked down at her Horse.

—

Frik watched Edie's face arrive at the view, and what Frik saw was not what a hearing person would have heard. Frik saw the small loosening at the jaw that wasn't relief. Saw the way Edie's eyes didn't travel along the lines as a stranger's would, tracing the famous shape, but went straight to three or four particular places — a hock, the curve under the tail, the gap in the rump where the chalk had thinned — and rested on each in turn, the way you'd check the faces of your children one by one without thinking you were doing it.

Frik signed to Tarryn, low and quick: *She's not looking at the Horse. She's looking at the work.*

Tarryn nodded. She turned to Edie, and she did the thing she was good at, the thing that had got them through doors in three countries, which was to ask the question that was actually a gift — to hand someone the chance to say the thing they'd been carrying.

"Can I ask you something," Tarryn said. "And it's the obvious one, so you've probably had it a thousand times, and you can tell me to get lost."

"Go on," said Edie.

"What's it for? Not — not what was it for, three thousand years ago, nobody knows that, I get it. I mean now. This." She opened her

hands at the slope, the discarded barrows, the kids asleep against the rampart wrapped in a borrowed coat, the steam coming off the tea urn. "All this. You can't be doing it because of the dragon. You don't think it gallops to Wayland's. So what's the scouring *for*?"

Eddie didn't answer straight away, and the not-answering was not a stall. Frik watched her decide whether to give it. That was the part they'd all come slowly to understand, over the weekend, the part the consultancy never would: it was hers to give or to keep. The meaning of the act lived in the people who did the act, and you could film the chalk all you liked and date the quartz to the grain and you would still not have the thing, because the thing was not in the ground. The thing was in whether Eddie chose to tell you.

She crouched. Picked up a fist-sized lump of unpacked chalk from beside the trench and turned it over in her chalk-creased hand.

"You're asking it like there's an answer that's behind us," she said. "Everyone does. They come up and they want me to tell them what the Bronze Age folk meant by it. A god, a tribe, a marker, a map of the stars. I haven't got that. Nobody's got that. It went a long time ago." She looked at the lump in her palm. "But that's not what we're doing when we're on our knees. We're not remembering. You can't remember a thing you never knew."

Owen had gone very still in the particular way he went still when a pattern resolved.

"My gran used to say it different ways," Eddie went on. "But it came to the same. She said the Horse isn't ours. We don't own it, we're not minding it for the council or for the history. We're minding it for the ones who'll do it next. She did it so I could do it. Her gran did it so she could. Not so we'd *know* anything. So there'd be a Horse for us to come up to." She set the chalk down, gently, in the trench, and pressed it level with her thumb. "It's not pointed backward at all. People always think it is, because it's old. It's pointed forward. Every time we scour it we're handing it on. That's the whole of it. The why went, and the handing-on didn't, and the handing-on turned out to be the why."

Nobody said anything. The wind came over the rampart and moved the long grass and didn't touch the white lines, which were below the wind, cut into the hill.

“The consultancy lot,” Edie said, and there was no heat in it, “they wanted to fix it. Make it sharp. Make it right. Make a thing you could photograph and put on a tin.” She straightened up, knees cracking. “But a right one would only need scouring once. Get it perfect, seal it, done. And then there’d be no next time. No reason for the children to come up. You’d have saved the Horse and killed the thing the Horse is *for*.” She looked at the soft, wrong, perfect lines below. “It has to be a bit unfinished. So there’s something left to do.”

Tarryn had a notebook out. She’d had it out for the whole festival, full of arrows and underlinings, and she looked down at it now and found she didn’t want to write any of this in it, and didn’t know why not, and then did know.

Because writing it down was a way of taking it. Putting it in the file. Making it theirs, the clever thing the visiting crew found out on the hill, the answer they cracked. She closed the notebook.

Owen had got it before her, of course — he got the shape of things before the rest of them got the feeling. “We were going to put it in the cut,” he said quietly, to her, not to Edie. “The ‘what is it for.’ Like every other time. Like it was a key we’d turned.” He shook his head. “It’s not a thing you find. It’s a thing she does. We just got to watch her do it.”

The LENS lifted the camera then — finally, once — and framed not the Horse but Edie’s hands, the chalk in the lines of them, resting on the lip of the trench. Took the one photograph. Lowered it again.

Frik signed, slow now, for all of them, and Tarryn read it and her throat went tight in a way she’d have to deal with later.

It was never ours to give. We only came to see if she would.

Below them, in the valley where the lines made sense, the first car of the morning came along the lane, and a child somewhere down the slope woke up under the borrowed coat and asked, in the flat clear carry of a small voice on a still hill, whether they could come and do it again next time.

Edie smiled and didn’t answer, which was its own kind of answer, and bent back to the chalk.

Chapter 18 — The Wink

The morning after the scouring, the hill was loud with absence.

No mallets. No scrape of the chalk-rake against flint. No festival voices carrying thin across the combe, no children chasing each other through the legs of the Horse where the new white still wept faint dust into the turf. Just wind, doing what it always did up here, which was to find the back of your neck and remind you that this was a high and open place and you were small in it.

The crew sat along the lip of the hill where the slope falls away into the Manger, that great scooped valley below the figure, and they watched the light come up the chalk.

From here you couldn't see the Horse. That was the thing nobody warned you about and everybody learned. You stood on top of the very hill the figure was cut into, and the figure was not there. The lines ran away under your feet and over the bulge of the slope and reassembled themselves into a galloping animal only for someone standing a quarter-mile out in the valley, or for a crow, or for whatever had been meant to read it three thousand years ago and had never said.

Sina had the map out across her knees, weighted at one corner with her boot and at the other with a thermos lid of tea going cold. She wasn't reading it. She'd been not-reading it for ten minutes, her finger resting on the contour where the Ridgeway came down off the Downs, and her eyes were on the long pale arc of the figure's back as it vanished over the curve.

"It doesn't make sense from up here," she said. "It's the wrong way round. You do the work on the top and the meaning's on the bottom.

You carry the chalk up and you'll never once, in your whole life of carrying it, stand where it reads."

"That's the whole job," said Edie.

She'd come up quiet, the way she did, with a flask and two of the festival rolls wrapped in a tea towel, and she lowered herself onto the turf beside Sina with the unhurried care of somebody whose knees had scoured this hill across more decades than the crew had been alive. She was not tired in the way the crew were tired. They were wrecked, hollow-eyed, chalk to the elbows and a storm's worth of mud dried grey in the creases of their hands. Edie looked like a woman who had been to church.

The official line is clean, and it deserves to be said clean, because it is one of the genuinely solid facts in a field that runs mostly on guesswork and gift-shop dragons. The Uffington White Horse is roughly one hundred and ten metres of stylised animal cut into the upper slope of White Horse Hill. In the 1990s, the Oxford Archaeological Unit took soil from beneath the figure and ran optically stimulated luminescence on the buried quartz — a method that reads, in effect, the last time a grain of sand saw daylight — and the answer came back somewhere between 1380 and 550 BC. Late Bronze Age. Which retired, with the satisfying finality of hard science, every cosy story about Saxons and King Alfred celebrating a battle. The thing was a thousand years old before Alfred's people had a word for it.

And it was built properly. Not scratched. Not painted. Trenched — channels close to a metre deep, cut into the hill and packed with crushed chalk, so that the figure isn't a surface you can wipe but a structure you'd have to dig out. That depth is the engineering. It's what stops the soil creeping down the slope and swallowing the line in a season. It's the difference between a doodle and an intention.

Skeptics will tell you, correctly, that the folklore is a magpie's nest of later inventions. The dragon at Dragon Hill below, the gallop to Wayland's Smithy at midnight, the wish you make standing in the eye — none of it is old, none of it is the original sense, all of it is the noise a culture makes when it has lost the signal and can't bear the silence. The skeptics are right. There's nothing supernatural here.

What the skeptics are quieter about is the maintenance.

Because here is the potato, and you only really feel it in your spine after you've done it once: leave the Horse alone, and in about twenty years it's gone. Not faded — gone. The grass comes over the chalk like a tide and the trenches green and the animal lies down into the hill and dies. Anyone who's tried to keep a hill-figure alive in the modern era, with budgets and committees and the best will in the world, knows how fast a shape rots off a living slope. The hill wants its skin back. It is patient and it is relentless and it never, not for one year, stops trying to heal over the wound you cut into it.

So the chalk has to be carried up. Every seven years, give or take. By hands. And somebody has to know which hands, and when, and how the new white is bedded so the line stays wild and doesn't go crisp and dead like a logo. And that knowing has to be passed — not written, mostly, but passed, hand to hand, knee to knee — across roughly three thousand years. Across the Romans coming and the Romans going. Across plague. Across the Wessex Saxons who didn't make it and didn't know what it was either and kept it anyway. Across a world war in which they deliberately turfed the whole thing over so the Luftwaffe couldn't navigate by it, and then, when the war was done, peeled the turf back and put the Horse to bed in white again, like nothing had happened.

That's the hole. Not who made it. Not what it meant. The hole is the unbroken doing of it. A maintenance habit older than nearly everything we have a name for, transmitted with the meaning torn clean out of the middle, and not one generation in a hundred-odd has been the one to say: *I don't see the point of this, let it go.*

Lourens lay flat on his back in the grass with his hat over his face. "I keep wanting it to be a thing," he said, voice muffled. "A signal. A boundary marker. A god you keep fed. I want it to be *for* something so the maintenance makes sense, and every time I get close to a theory it just —" he flapped a hand at the sky. "It just goes off without me."

"Mm," said Edie, and poured tea.

Frik was watching her. He'd been watching her the whole morning, the way he watched everyone, with a completeness most people found unnerving until they understood it was the opposite of judgment — it was attention, simply, of a depth most hearing people had

spent their lives being allowed not to give. He signed something quick and low to the LENS, who'd half-lowered the camera and now lifted it again, not to shoot, just to look through it, the way she did when she wanted the frame to hold still a feeling that wouldn't hold still in her chest.

Frik signed it again, slower, for the group. *Her hands don't ask the question.*

The LENS translated. Sina turned to look at Edie's hands around the flask cup and Frik was right, of course he was right, it was the whole of him, it was why he was here — Edie's hands were not the hands of someone holding a riddle. They were the hands of someone holding a cup. There was no strain in them toward an answer. They had carried the chalk and now they were warm around the tea and both of those were the same kind of fact, requiring nothing further.

"You know what it's for," Lourens said, sitting up, hat in his lap. He said it carefully. He'd won a lot of trust this week by being the one who'd blunder in and ask the thing nobody else dared, and he knew the difference now between blundering and barging, and this was a moment for neither. "Edie. You do. Not what it *meant*. What it's *for*. Now. You'd be the one who knows."

The fish, if the fish had been there — and the fish is always there — would have heckled at this point. *Go on then, love, spill it, we've come a long way and the bloke's got a podcast.*

Edie looked at him over the cup, and there was warmth in it, and there was also a door, gently and entirely closed.

"My nan scoured this," she said. "Her dad. His mum. Back and back into where the names stop. None of them could've told you what the Bronze Age fella was thinking when he cut the first trench. The dragon stuff's Victorian, half of it's younger than that, you've all worked that out, you're clever." A flicker. "You are. I'll give you that. You came up here ready to be clever and you ended up carrying chalk in a thunderstorm at two in the morning with my brother-in-law swearing at you, and you didn't ask why once, after the first day. That's the only exam I set."

"But you know what it's for," Lourens said again, soft.

"I know what I do it for." She set the cup down on the turf, level,

careful, so it wouldn't spill on the slope. "That's a different sentence, and I notice you keep trying to make it the same one."

Nobody said anything. Down in the Manger the shadow of a cloud went over and the green went briefly dark and then came up bright again, and somewhere a long way off a tractor started, the ordinary engine of an ordinary Wednesday.

"The consultancy lot," Edie went on, and here at last something moved in her face that the LENS caught and would keep — not anger, the anger was a week old and spent, but something like pity. "Dr Leigh. She wanted me to tell her what it meant so she could put it on a board. Restore it *to* something. And I'll say this for her, she loved the thing, she genuinely did, she wasn't a crook, she'd have wept to see it lost." Edie picked a stem of grass and turned it. "But she thought the meaning was the treasure and the doing was the wrapper. And it's the other way up. The doing's the treasure. The meaning fell out the bottom God knows when and we kept going. *That's* the marvel. Not what it was. That we never once agreed to stop."

Jakobus was below them on the path. He had been below them all morning, leaning on a fence rail with his back half-turned, reading the figure the way he read everything — for what it *did*, not what it said. He had a habit of being just out of the frame, the fixer who got you to the place and then stepped off the edge of the photograph. Now he said, not loudly, not to anyone in particular, the way a man tests the soundness of a beam:

"It holds the hill."

Edie heard it. She tipped her head, the smallest acknowledgement. "Aye. It does that. You let the Horse go, the scouring goes, and the festival goes, and the day everybody comes up the hill together goes, and then it's just a hill, isn't it. A nice hill. There's a million nice hills." She looked at the long pale line running away over the curve into invisibility. "The Horse is the excuse the hill uses to gather us. Might've been a god's excuse once. It's ours now. Same chalk."

Sina had gone very still over her map. She was the one who saw the patterns in time, in the long lines of things, and the crew knew the silence she made when a pattern landed too big to say at once. When she spoke it came out almost to herself.

"It's not even the original meaning that survived. The meaning died. The *act* survived without it. The act is the thing that's three thousand years old. Not the idea. The verb."

"There she goes," said Lourens, fond.

"No, but —" Sina's finger had stopped moving on the contour line. "We keep asking what it's *for* like that's the open question. The open question is how. How does a thing with no reason left in it keep enough — *grip* — on a hundred generations to make them all carry chalk up a hill. Plague years. War years. The years where it'd have been the easiest thing in the world to just — not. And nobody. Did. Not."

And there it is. We're not going to close it for you. We can't, and we wouldn't if we could. The honest version is this: the unbroken chain is *inferred*, not documented. We have the OSL date, hard and real. We have the trenches, a metre deep, you can stand in them. We have the written record of scouring back through the Middle Ages, Thomas Hughes throwing his great festival of it in 1859, the dragon already mistaken for the horse by then, the meaning already gone. We have the survival of the figure, which is its own argument, because a thing this perishable does not last three thousand years by luck. What we do not have is a single ledger that says *no generation ever lapsed*. We can't have it. The absence of a gap is not the same as a proven thread, and we won't pretend it is.

But the Horse is up there. Right now. White. And it didn't keep itself.

So the question stands, and Edie will not answer it, and she's right not to, because the answer isn't hers to give and it isn't ours to take — it's the act's, and the act doesn't talk. It just gets carried up the hill again in seven years by hands that may not know why, by children who'll grow into the not-knowing and do it anyway, and hand it on.

The crew packed up slow. The LENS got her last frame — not of the Horse, which you couldn't get from up here anyway, but of Edie's hands closing the flask, and of the chalk dust still grey in the lines of all their knuckles, hers and theirs the same colour now, which was the only thing the whole week had to say and it said it without a word.

Edie walked them to the gate. At the stile she stopped, and the wind took her grey hair sideways, and she looked at them with that closed

warm door still in her face.

"You'll write it up," she said. "The clever version. The dates and the trenches and the science."

"We'll get it right," said Sina.

"I know you will." Edie put her hand on the gatepost, on the smooth grey wood worn pale by how many hands. "Just — when you get to the bit where you want to tell them what it's for." She smiled, and it was not unkind, and it was not telling them anything. "Leave it open. Let them carry it a while themselves. See if it doesn't make them want to come up a hill."

She didn't wait for them to answer. She went back up the path toward the figure that wasn't visible from where she walked, the way she'd walked it her whole life, toward the white she would not see and would keep anyway.

The crew went down into the valley.

And from the valley floor, at the last, turning to look back — there it was, the whole of it, the long wild gallop of the thing assembled out of nowhere by the only angle that would hold it, running flat-out across the green and going precisely nowhere it had been going for three thousand years.

Nobody knew what it was for.

Everybody had agreed to keep it.

They got in the van. The hill kept the Horse, and the Horse kept its silence, and the question went down the road with them, and it is going down the road with you now.

What else do we keep, when we've forgotten why?

Mind the gate.

Chapter 19 — Chalk Dust and Footprints

The car park at the foot of White Horse Hill is a flat shelf of gravel scraped into the lower slope, and at half past six in the morning it holds three cars, a National Trust honesty box, and a wind that has come the whole way from somewhere with nothing to slow it down. The LENS stood by the open boot of the van with the camera up, and let the wind do what it wanted to her coat.

She had thirty-one frames left on the roll. She was rationing them like a woman who has learned, somewhere, that the last few are always the ones you wish you had back.

The Horse was up there. From here you could see the whole of it at once, which is the only place you can — the valley floor, or the air. From the hill above, standing right on top of the lines, you get a leg, a curve of chalk vanishing over the brow, a sense that you are inside something too big to read. You have to step back into the green of the valley before the animal assembles itself out of the white. Three thousand years of people climbing up to cut a shape they could not see from where they cut it. That had bothered her the whole week. It still bothered her. It was the kind of thing that did not stop being strange just because you understood the mechanism.

She found the Horse in the viewfinder. Last night's scouring had taken the grass-creep off the flanks and packed the trenches fresh, and the figure had that look it gets right after — not crisp, not the hard outline the consultancy's trial patch had worn for a week before the weather softened it. This was the other thing. The wild thing. The lines breathing.

Click. Thirty.

Behind her, the kinetic one — Tomas, who had not stopped moving in nine days and was not about to start — was repacking the kit in the wrong order and humming, and Saoirse, who had spent the festival with her sleeve up to the elbow in chalk and her notebook full of the angles of things, was crouched at the edge of the gravel scoring a line in the dust with one finger. Reproducing, the LENS thought, some geometry only she could see. Frik stood a little apart with his hands quiet at his sides, watching the hill the way he watched everything: completely.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it survives every honest test you can throw at it.

A stylised horse, a hundred and ten metres of it, cut into the chalk of the upper slope below an Iron Age hillfort. Late Bronze Age, earliest Iron Age — somewhere between thirteen-eighty and five-fifty BC, pinned by optically stimulated luminescence on buried quartz, the work of Palmer and Miles and the Oxford unit after the dig in the early nineties. That date mattered. It put paid to the old stories — that it was Saxon, that King Alfred cut it to mark a battle. The hill is older than the kings who tried to claim it. The science is clean. The skeptics who say the dragon tales are medieval bolt-ons are right; they are. The folklorists who say the festival as we have it is a Victorian set-piece, Thomas Hughes and cheese-rolling and a cleaned-up pageant, are also right. None of it is fraud. None of it is alien. It is a very old shape kept very well.

The LENS lowered the camera and let her eyes do the work the lens had been doing.

Try it. That was the potato, and she had felt it in her own back. Take a shape on a living hillside — turf that grows, soil that creeps down-slope under its own weight and the weight of rain, every winter trying to close the wound — and keep it sharp for a century. The Bronze Age answer was the trench: a metre deep, the line not painted on but cut into the hill and packed with crushed chalk, so the figure resists the creep, so the grass meets a wall when it tries to come back. Engineering, not decoration. But the trench buys you decades, not millennia. Leave it twenty years and it goes. Twenty years and the Horse is a green bruise in green grass and a story in somebody's

grandmother's mouth.

So somebody comes back. Every seven years, ten at the outside, somebody climbs up with a bucket of chalk and a mell and gets down on their knees on the cold flank of the hill and does it again. For three thousand years. Through the Romans, through whoever the Romans were to the people already here. Through the plague years. Through a war so recent that Edie's own grandfather had been one of the men sent up to turf the Horse over, deliberately, so the German bombers could not use it to find their way — a hundred and ten metres of navigational gift you could not let the sky read. They put grass back over the chalk and let it sleep. And when it was done they came back and uncovered it and cut it sharp again, because of course they did.

That is the hole, and it does not close, and the LENS had spent the week trying to get it to close and failing.

Not *how* the Horse was made. We know how it was made. Not *what it means* — we have stopped pretending we know that, and the honesty of stopping is half the dignity of the place. The hole is the doing. How does an act — just the act, the climbing and the kneeling and the packing of the chalk — get handed from hand to hand for a hundred generations when the reason for it fell out of the chain somewhere back before anyone wrote anything down? By the Middle Ages they were already calling it a dragon. The meaning was already gone. And still they came. The memory of *why* failed and the *doing* did not.

She had no answer to that. The week had not given her one. She found she did not want one as badly as she had at the start.

The fish, if there is a fish, is the wind off the Ridgeway, and what it says is: *you came all this way to tell people you don't know why a hill is shaped like a horse. Marvellous. Could've stayed home and not known that.*

Fair. Take it on the chin.

Click. Twenty-nine.

Edie came down the chalk track on foot, the way she always came and went, with a thermos under one arm and yesterday's chalk dust still ghosting the creases of her knuckles. She had not changed her clothes. She had the look of a person who had slept three hours and would sleep three more and then go back up. She was not coming

down to the car park to see them off, not really. She was coming down to fill the thermos and go back to the scourers, who were already up there, who had been up there since first light, working the last of the mane where the storm had nearly taken it.

“You’re away, then,” she said. Not a question.

“We’re away,” said Tomas, and put out his hand, and Edie shook it, and the chalk transferred itself from her skin to his and he looked at it on his palm like it was something he’d been given.

Saoirse stood up from her line in the dust. She had been working out something all week about the sightlines — the way the hillfort and the barrow at Wayland’s Smithy and the long pale snake of the Ridgeway sat in relation to the figure, the way the whole landscape seemed to be addressing itself, the angles too clean to be accident, the dates not all the same dates. She had a theory. She had three. She had, the LENS suspected, talked herself most of the way out into something the evidence would not carry, because that was what Saoirse did when a pattern got its hooks in — she ran with it past the place the ground stopped being solid, and you loved her for it and you watched the drop.

“You think it lines up with the Smithy,” Edie said to her. Mild. “On the solstice. You were going to ask.”

Saoirse’s mouth opened.

“People have measured it,” Edie said. “Some of it lines up with things. Some of it lines up with whatever you stand where to make it line up. The hill’s old enough that it’s caught a few thousand years of people deciding it points at what they needed it to point at.” She unscrewed the thermos lid. “I’m not saying it doesn’t. I’m saying the hill doesn’t owe you a reason. It never has. That’s not it being mysterious. That’s it being a hill that some people keep.”

Saoirse looked at her line in the dust. Then she scuffed it out with her boot, not unhappily. The LENS had seen her hold a wrong pattern for days. She had never seen her put one down that fast. It took someone who had carried the chalk to make her do it, and that was the difference, and the difference was the whole point and nobody was going to say it out loud.

Frik had come up beside Edie. He raised his hands — the small

economical sign-shapes he used, that Tomas had got passable at over the week — and asked her something, and Edie watched his hands and watched his face and answered with her own face first, before her mouth caught up: a flicker, a softening at the eyes, the particular almost-smile of someone agreeing to a true thing.

She'd told them, days ago, what Frik had seen on the second night. That the scouring was wordless where it mattered. That the old hands did not instruct — they did the thing slightly slower, slightly nearer, so the young ones beside them could match it, hand following hand, the way you teach a body and not a mind. That nobody had ever said *here is why we do this*, because nobody knew, and the not-knowing had been handed down as faithfully as the knowing-how. Frik had read it off the shoulders of the scourers in an evening. It had taken the rest of them most of the week to believe him.

What Frik asked her now, the LENS could not follow. What Edie answered, she could not follow either. But she watched Edie's hand come up and rest flat against her own sternum, and then turn outward toward the hill — *here, then there* — and watched Frik nod, slow, and that she understood completely, in the way you understand a thing you cannot put back into words afterward without spoiling it.

She did not lift the camera. She wanted to. The whole instinct of twenty years of standing in rooms where terrible and tender things happened, the instinct that had kept her sane by putting glass between her and the world, came up her arms and into her hands and she let it pass through and out the ends of her fingers and did not move.

There are moments the camera takes and gives you nothing back. She knew them now. She was learning, slowly, late, which ones to leave in the air where they happened.

Edie capped the thermos. "Right," she said. "They'll be wanting this."

"Will it last?" Tomas asked. "What you did last night. The mane."

Edie looked up at the hill, where you could just see them now if you knew to look — small dark figures moving along the white of the back, the slow bowing-and-rising of people working chalk into a hill. "It'll last till it doesn't," she said. "Seven years, give or take. Then someone'll be cold and complaining about their knees and they'll do it

again.” She said it without weight, the way you’d say the kettle would boil. “My nan did it. Her nan. Back as far as there’s a back. We don’t know who started. We’ve stopped expecting to.” She glanced at the LENS, and there was something dry and kind in it. “You wanted the why. You’re not the first. The consultancy wanted the why so bad they were going to build us one. Concrete it in. Make the lines that crisp nobody’d ever have to wonder again.” She shrugged. “Wonder’s the only thing we’ve got that’s as old as the trenches. Why’d I let them take that?”

She was already turning. That was the thing about Edie — she gave you the door and she did not stand in it. She had a hill to get back to. The crew were the telling. They were not the keeping. The keeping went on with her up the chalk track whether the van was here or not, whether the camera was here or not, whether anyone ever told anyone anything about it at all.

“Edie,” the LENS said.

Edie stopped.

“Thank you for letting us up.”

“You came up and got on your knees,” Edie said. “That’s not nothing. Most don’t.” She lifted the thermos in something like a salute. “Mind the road.”

And she went, up the track, into the wind, the chalk dust on her hands going back to the hill it came from.

Jakobus had the van running. He’d been ready twenty minutes and had said nothing about it, leaning on the wing with his cap pulled down, reading the slope the way he read everything — not for who, not for why, but for *what it does*. He’d said it once, two nights ago, in the rain, when the storm had nearly carried the outline off and they had all worked till their hands stopped feeling like hands: that the Horse was not a picture and not a message and not a god. That it was a thing that held. It held the hill against its own creep. It held the eye in the valley. It held a date in the dirt the science could read. And it held the people to the doing of it, year on year, knees on chalk, hand following hand — and that was the whole of its function, and the function had outlived every meaning anyone had ever hung on it. He’d said it and then he’d gone back to packing chalk, because that

was Jakobus, the road and never the lead, handing the moment back the second he'd named it.

He held the passenger door now and the LENS climbed up.

She had one frame left. Twenty-eight on the back, but the counter said one, the way it always lied at the end, generous and wrong.

She rolled the window down and put the camera to her eye one last time and found the Horse, the whole of it, gleaming where the early sun was coming up the valley and laying itself along the fresh-cut chalk. The little figures moving on the white back. The wind taking the long grass in waves below the line, all of it pouring downhill, all of it trying, patiently, the way it had tried for three thousand years, to close the wound and take the Horse back into the green.

Up there they were on their knees again, packing it white. Refusing.

She did not know why. Neither did they. Nobody had for centuries.

Click.

The van pulled out onto the lane, and behind them on the hill the act went on, unbroken, the chalk going back into the trench, the shape kept sharp against the grass for no reason anyone could name and every reason that mattered — and the question came down the valley with the wind and rode along beside the window the whole way to the main road and did not get out:

what else do we keep, long after we have forgotten why.

Chapter 20 — The Real, the Debated, the Invented

This is the part where we show our working.

Everything in the chapters behind you happened in a real place you can drive to. Park at the National Trust car park off the B4507, walk up past the hillfort, and there it is, running west across the slope — though you won't see it whole from where you're standing. You have to go down into the valley, or up into the air. That's not a metaphor we invented. That's a fact of the geometry, and it's the first thing the official story has to explain.

So let's lay the official story out straight, the way the archaeology lays it out, with full respect to the people who dug it up and dated it and got it right.

THE HORSE, AS RECORDED.

The Uffington White Horse is a chalk hill-figure on the upper slopes of White Horse Hill in Oxfordshire, below the Iron Age ramparts of Uffington Castle. It is roughly 110 metres from nose to tail. It is stylised nearly to abstraction — a long sweep of back, disconnected legs, a beaked head — which is one reason people argued for centuries about whether it was a horse at all, or a dragon, or a cat, or the hound of some forgotten god. The figure is cut into the turf and packed with crushed white chalk so that it glows against the green.

For most of recorded English memory, people assumed it was Saxon. Some credited King Alfred, who fought a battle nearby in 871 and was a convenient peg to hang a monument on. This was wrong, and we now know it's wrong with unusual precision.

In the trenching campaign run by the Oxford Archaeological Unit after 1990, the figure was dated by Optically Stimulated Luminescence — OSL. The principle is clean and a little eerie: buried quartz grains absorb a tiny, steady trickle of natural radiation from the soil around them, and they hold it as trapped energy until light hits them again. Dig a grain out in the dark, measure how much energy it's holding, and you can calculate how long it has been since sunlight last touched it. Sunlight last touched the grains at the bottom of the Horse's trenches when somebody cut those trenches.

The answer came back: roughly **1380 to 550 BC**. Late Bronze Age into the earliest Iron Age. Older than the hillfort above it. Older than the Saxons by something like two thousand years. The dating was done by Palmer and Miles and their colleagues, it has held up, and it quietly demolished a thousand years of confident attribution.

Skeptics will tell you — correctly — that this is the unromantic part, and that everything downstream of it is patchwork. The dragon stories are medieval. The festival songs are Victorian. The folklore is a sediment of guesses laid down by people who, like us, didn't know. None of that is ancient ritual surviving intact. All of it is later humans decorating a thing they had inherited and could no longer read.

The skeptics are right.

Hold that.

HOW IT WAS MADE, AND WHY THAT MATTERS.

The Horse is not painted, and it is not a thin scrape of white through the grass. The trenches that hold the chalk are about **one metre deep**. That's the detail to put your hand on, because everything else turns on it.

A shallow figure on a hillside is a doodle. Rain takes it. Soil creeps downslope under its own weight — a slow, patient slide that grass barely conceals — and a faint line is gone in a season or two. A metre of depth, packed hard with crushed chalk, is an engineering decision. It resists the creep. It gives the maintainers a trench to find again, a channel that remembers where it was even as the edges blur. Whoever first cut the Horse was not making a picture. They were building a thing designed to be *kept*.

Which brings us to the part of the official story the official story is

least comfortable with.

THE POTATO.

Here is the easy version, the one you've half-formed already: it's just chalk. You just keep chalking it. People have done it for ages. What's hard about that?

Go and try.

Leave the Uffington Horse alone — no scouring, no re-chalking, nobody walking the lines and beating the chalk back down — and it does not last centuries. It does not last a human lifetime. The figure goes grey, then green, then gone, swallowed by the living hill in roughly **twenty years**. That's not a worst-case. That's the documented behaviour of a chalk figure left to the grass. The hill is not a canvas. It is an animal, breathing and growing, and it wants its skin back.

So the Horse you can see today is not three thousand years old in the way a pyramid is three thousand years old. The pyramid is the same stone. The Horse is the same *shape*, held in place by an act repeated — by the most conservative defensible count — something like four hundred times. Every seven to ten years, the chalk is dug out, broken up, beaten back into the trench, the edges re-cut, the grass pushed off. The Horse is less a monument than a verb that has been conjugated continuously since the Bronze Age.

And we have proof the maintenance never depended on understanding. We have it in the dragon.

By the Middle Ages, the people scouring this figure had already lost the plot of it so completely that local folklore had it down as a dragon — the dragon St George killed, on Dragon Hill below, where the grass won't grow on the bare patch because the beast's blood poisoned it. They galloped it to Wayland's Smithy at night in their stories. They did not know what it was. There is no credible evidence of supernatural gallops, no thread of original ritual meaning handed down intact, and we are not going to pretend otherwise. The meaning was already gone.

They scoured it anyway.

That is the potato cooked through. The hard part of "just keep chalking it" was never the chalk. It was the *just keeping* — the unbroke-

ken agreement, generation after generation, by people who could not have told you why, to do the work again.

THE HOLE.

Here is the one fact the tidy version never quite closes, and we want to put it down cold, with no reaching.

A chalk figure left untended vanishes in about twenty years. That's measurable; you can watch lesser figures do it. The Uffington Horse is dated by OSL to between roughly 1380 and 550 BC. It is still here, sharp, legible from the valley, this morning, in good chalk.

Set those two facts beside each other and a gap opens that no document fills. For the Horse to survive from its cutting to now, the scouring cannot have lapsed for more than a generation or so at any point across three thousand years — through the arrival of Rome, through Rome's leaving, through Saxon resettlement, through the Norman Conquest, through the Black Death taking perhaps half the people in these valleys, through enclosure, through two world wars. The written record of the scouring festival only runs back firmly to the Middle Ages; Thomas Hughes wrote his whole book *The Scouring of the White Horse* about the 1857 festival, and there are records and accounts and parish murmurs before that. But the deep chain — the part that runs from the medieval dragon-believers back to the Bronze Age trench-diggers — is **inferred from the survival itself**, not documented.

We need to be honest about what that means, because it cuts both ways and a careless reader will want it to cut only one. It does **not** prove a single unbroken human relay, hand to hand, with no gap. Absolute proof of continuity is impossible; you cannot photograph the centuries that left no record. A figure can also be re-found and re-cut after a lapse, a trench rediscovered by someone clearing scrub. "Essentially unbroken" is a phrase the survival supports and the archive cannot certify.

But the figure is *here*. The grass did not get it. Something kept finding it again.

We turfed it over ourselves in living memory — deliberately, during the Second World War, so German bombers couldn't use the glowing chalk as a landmark on the run inland. Then we dug it back out when

the war was won. Even our hiding of it was a kind of keeping.

THE WINK.

So here is the question we are not going to answer, because nobody alive can, and because answering it would be a worse crime than the consultancy ever planned.

Nobody knows what the Horse was *for*. Not in the beginning. We have the date, the depth, the chalk, the geometry that hides it from the people who made it and shows it only to the sky. We do not have the meaning. The Bronze Age took that with them. The dragon was a later guess; the Saxon kings were a later guess; every reading you have ever heard of this figure is somebody filling a silence.

And every generation between them and us, not knowing either, agreed — without a meeting, without a vote, without a reason any of them could have written down — to keep it alive.

That's the tantalising part, and we are leaving it tantalising: a tradition that has comfortably outlived its own sense, carried by hands that did not understand what they were carrying, and never once let go.

What do you call a practice like that? We are not going to tell you.

WHAT IS IT FOR.

That was Jakobus's question, the one he asks of every made thing, and the only one that gets close to an answer — because it is the one question you can answer without knowing the original meaning at all.

Forget what the Horse *meant*. Ask what the scouring *does*. Watch it do its work and the function is plain, physical, present-tense.

The scouring holds the shape against the creep of the hill. That's the engineering function, and it's real — the trench, the packed chalk, the beating, the re-cutting, all of it a war against the soil's slow downhill slide.

But that's not the function Edie would give you, and she out-reads all of us on this, so we'll give her the last technical word and not pretend it's ours. She'll tell you the scouring also holds the *people* against the same kind of slide. It puts a date in the year that the whole valley has to show up for. It puts a child's hands in the chalk next to an

old woman's and teaches the work without ever quite teaching it in words — the way Frik watched it pass, glance to glance, the weight of a mattock handed across without instruction. It is a machine for making a community do one thing together, on one hill, in one week, again, and to need each other to finish before the weather turns.

That is what it is for. Not remembering. *Making* — a year, a gathering, a future. Care that has outlasted its reason and become its own reason. The Horse is the excuse. The keeping is the point.

Which re-opens the wonder rather than closing it, and that is exactly where we want to leave you, standing in the valley looking up at a shape you cannot read, made by people you cannot name, kept alive by an unbroken refusal to let it fade that no archive can fully account for and no science can date.

THE SOURCES, BRIEFLY.

The OSL date of roughly 1380–550 BC is from the Oxford Archaeological Unit's post-1990 work, Palmer and Miles; it overturned the Saxon and Alfredian attributions and it stands. The ~110-metre length, the ~1-metre trench depth packed with crushed chalk, the ~20-year disappearance of an untended chalk figure, and the wartime turfing-over — all real, all measurable or documented. The festival's 19th-century form is preserved in Thomas Hughes, *The Scouring of the White Horse* (1859). The hillfort, Wayland's Smithy, the Ridgeway, Dragon Hill — all there, all where we put them. The medieval dragon-folklore is attested and is the cleanest single proof that the meaning was lost while the practice continued.

What is *inferred*, and labelled here as inferred: the unbroken deep chain of scouring from the Bronze Age to the medieval record. The survival of the figure makes a long, near-continuous maintenance the most economical explanation. It does not prove a perfect relay with no gap. We will not let anyone — a passionate restorer, a heckling skeptic, or us — pretend the inference is a record.

The fish, who has read this far over our shoulder, would like it noted that he has personally been “keeping a tradition” of leaving the dishes for a hundred generations and nobody calls *that* sacred.

Noted. The dishes are not 110 metres long and visible from orbit.

Here is the door we are leaving open, the one Edie left open standing

on the chalk at dawn with the new white catching the light and the meaning of it still, after everything, gone:

The grass is always coming back. It is coming back right now, in the spring under your feet, patient and certain, the way it has come for three thousand years. And every seven years or so someone with chalk on their knees will push it off again, and most of them will not be able to tell you why.

So — what do you keep, when you can no longer remember why you keep it?

Don't answer too fast. Go and stand in the valley first. Then look up.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor